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NEET re-exam: Govt passes litmus test

Examination at 5,440 centres in 551 cities across India passes peacefully

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Hundreds of thousands of medical aspirants took the NEET (UG) re-examination on Sunday after the original May 3 test was cancelled over paper leaks. The re-test drew public attention and protests. The Centre and the National Testing Agency (NTA) also treated it as a test and pulled out all the stops to ensure the NEET-UG re-examination was held without a hitch, and they passed the 'litmus test' on Sunday.

According to officials, the examination was held at 5,440 centres in 551 cities across India and 14 centres internationally, with more than 138,000 CCTV cameras monitoring 95,000 rooms. To enhance security against electronic malpractice, authorities deployed 51,311 signal jammers.

Earlier, Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan reviewed the arrangements for the re-examination at the National Testing Agency (NTA) headquarters in Okhla, Delhi.

"NTA apprises the Minister of the logistical and technical arrangements put in place for the efficient and transparent conduct of the examination," the Ministry of Education said.

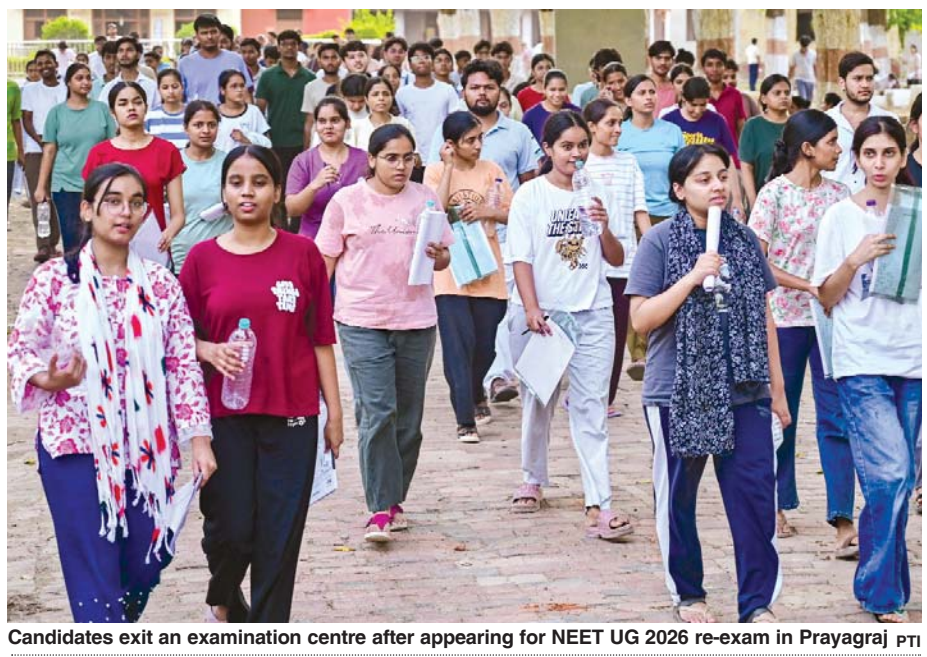
The examination, administered in English and 12 Indian languages, was scheduled from 2:00 pm to 5:15 pm. Candidates with disabilities (PwD/PwBD) who were eligible for compensatory time were permitted to write the examination until 6:20 pm.

In Madhya Pradesh, a candidate told that, after the re-examination, the paper was good and the arrangements this time were much better, particularly the identity-checking system. The aspirant added that while it felt unusual to take the exam again, the retest also brought confidence and hope, as it offered another chance at selection.

Another candidate said the paper was very lengthy and tougher than expected, and that the second attempt did not go as well as the first.

An aspirant in Bengaluru said only Physics was difficult, while other sections were easy. We got more time to read and solve problems. The candidate added that the extra time to read and solve problems helped improve performance.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



Candidates exit an examination centre after appearing for NEET UG 2026 re-exam in Prayagraj PTI

PM gentle gesture for NEET aspirants

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi

On a bright Sunday afternoon at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had just landed back in the city around 1:15 pm. Usually, the next step would be a swift departure for home.

But this Sunday was different. The NEET-UG re-examination, an important day filled with hope and nerves for hundreds of thousands of students across India, was about to start at 2 pm. Many students were on their way to exam centres, hoping to become doctors.

If the Prime Minister's convoy had moved suddenly, it could have caused traffic diversions, delays, and extra stress for students rushing to their exams. Instead of going home right away, PM Modi decided to stay at the airport and wait until after the exam had started.

FULL REPORT ON >> P4

PM Modi calls yoga bridge between health, peace

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday led the nation in observing the 12th International Day of Yoga here and advocated the utility of yoga in not only boosting personal health but also acting as a catalysing agent in opening up the path for world peace.

His remarks, against the backdrop of multiple conflicts and geopolitical tensions, came across as an assertion that yoga, an ancient Indian practice, holds relevance beyond personal health and wellness, with the potential to promote collective peace and harmony across societies.

Addressing the nation on the occasion of the 12th International Day of Yoga celebrations at the iconic Red Road here, amid thousands of participants, Modi underscored the need for a balanced personal lifestyle that yoga teaches, and the need to embrace the tradition across all ages. The PM quoted the Bhagavad Gita to state that a balanced lifestyle involving work, nutrition and sleep is the key to eradicating suffering, which yoga can guide people to. "That balance is yoga's basic crucible, just as it is the crucible of our lives," Modi said.

"Most people are struggling to maintain that balance in their modern lifestyle. Yoga teaches us the art of living our lives in a balanced manner; it teaches us dos and don'ts. When we learn to operate our bodies in the right manner, health becomes a habit," he added.

Stressing that yoga does not merely focus on physical health, but, in fact, helps in finding the path to physical fitness through mental health, the PM connected the individual to the global.

"The consciousness of identifying the dos and don'ts not only brings inner peace, but it also opens up the path to world peace. That's why yoga is not only required for our personal lifestyles, it is essential for a better future for this world," he said.

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Prime Minister Narendra Modi participates in a yoga session during the International Day of Yoga celebrations PTI

The ByStander

Maritime prowess key to great nation status: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Underlining that strong maritime prowess and capability are the deciding factors for a nation's economic and strategic influence, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday here said India recognises this and is preparing for it.

Making this assertion here after commissioning three indigenously built naval ships at the Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port, he also said India does not want to remain only a buyer country in the defence sector, and the nation's armed forces cannot become just a market for the world.

"The recognition of our capabilities lies in our self-reliance and not in becoming a market for the world," he said. "No nation can become a big power without maritime prowess. Development, security and prosperity are tied to the seas. A country with maritime capabilities is strong and has more economic and strategic influence," Modi said. He said India understands this reality well and is preparing itself for it.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a ceremony to commission Indian Navy warships in Kolkata, West Bengal PTI

Rebel MPs to formalise split from Uddhav Thackeray camp

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
Mumbai/New Delhi

The Shiv Sena (UBT) split is likely to be formally announced after days of speculation and sharp exchanges. The rebel MPs are expected to hold a joint press conference and release photographs and video footage of their meeting with Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, along with a copy of the letter they submitted to him.

They are also expected to cite the reason behind their departure from the Uddhav Thackeray camp. The six rebel Lok Sabha MPs-Sanjay Dina Patil (Mumbai North East), Sanjay Deshmukh (Yavatmal-Washim), Sanjay Jadhav (Parbhani), Bhausaheb Wakchaure (Shirdi), Nagesh Patil Ashtikar (Hingoli) and Omprakash Raje Nimbalkar (Dharashiv)-form two-thirds of Shiv Sena (UBT)'s nine-member parliamentary strength.

Their move marks the second major fracture in Shiv Sena (Uddhav Thackeray) within four years, following the 2022 rebellion by Eknath Shinde that split the original Shiv Sena and ended the Maha Vikas Aghadi Government in Maharashtra.

Events escalated rapidly on June 16, when the MPs reportedly flew into Delhi late that day and stayed at a hotel in Noida. The following morning, they met Speaker Om Birla and submitted a formal letter seeking recognition as a separate parliamentary group. The letter also requested a change to the Lok Sabha seating to align with the Shinde faction.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

PIONEER IN SHORT

CLASS 12 RE-VALUATION RESULTS ANNOUNCED

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) declared the revaluation results on Sunday for students who applied for verification and re-evaluation of their Class 12 board exam answer sheets. "CBSE has commenced the release of Class XII Verification of issues observed and Re-evaluation outcomes," CBSE said in a post on X. "The outcomes are being released in a phased manner, with over 87 per cent of the total applications received being declared today. The outcomes of the remaining applications will be available in phases, and the entire process is expected to be completed soon," it said.

FULL REPORT ON P5

SOORYAVANSHI'S 94 SHINES BRIGHT

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi showcased his astonishing talent and big-match temperament with a 29-ball 94, laying the foundation for India A's lopsided 66-run over Sri Lanka A in the tri-series final here on Sunday. Sooryavanshi's romp, which also contained an 11-ball 50, the fastest in List A cricket, guided India A to a massive 377 for nine. Sri Lanka A mustered 311 all out in reply as pacer Yash Thakur (3/45) and spinner Vipraj Nigam (3/60) inflicted timely blows. If the hosts had to get closer to that improbable target, they needed a good start and consistent partnerships. Earlier, Sooryavanshi's shrugged off a lean run in this tournament with typical gusto.

FULL REPORT ON P16

US, Iran hold talks in Switzerland

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Obburgen (Switzerland)

US and Iranian negotiators were in Switzerland on Sunday for talks on their interim agreement to end the Iran war. Pakistani and Qatari mediators were also there for the technical-level discussions on resolving the conflict that the US and Israel began in late February.

The US team, led by Vice President JD Vance, includes Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff. They are meeting with Iranian negotiators led by Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi. On the eve of talks, Tehran said it closed the Strait of Hormuz again over Israel's ongoing military campaign in Lebanon. The interim deal is meant to stop fighting on all fronts, including Lebanon.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

From left, US Vice President JD Vance, Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Qatar's Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman bin Jassim Al-Thani PTI

Nihangs storm gurudwara, take Sikh devotee hostage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Rudraprayag (Uttarakhand)

A group of Nihangs, armed with spears and swords, allegedly stormed a gurudwara here and took a Sikh devotee hostage on the roof of the shrine to demand the release of four members of the Sikh sect who were arrested following a clash in Chamoli on June 16, police said on Sunday.

A heavy police force was deployed at the scene following the standoff that began on Saturday evening, and efforts were underway to persuade the six Nihangs holed up in the gurudwara to come down.

The Rudraprayag district magistrate and the superintendent of police reached the gurudwara in Nagrasu and urged them to vacate the premises. The Garhwal Commissioner has also arrived in Rudraprayag to handle the situation. However, police said the six Nihangs who had locked the third floor leading to the terrace continued to remain on the roof of the gurudwara.

People responsible for managing the gurudwara said the Nihangs had asked for "50-60 rooms" to be arranged to house protesters who would come for a demonstration against the clash in Karnaprayag, Chamoli.

When the gurudwara failed to do it, the Nihangs resorted to violence, warning the authorities against any forceful action against them, they said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Nihangs stand on the roof of a gurudwara to demand the release of 4 members of the Sikh sect in Rudraprayag PTI

SIT asks temple officials to remain in Ayodhya

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
Lucknow/New Delhi

A three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) investigating alleged misappropriation at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya has asked the temple trust's office-bearers and other officials to remain in the city. The SIT gave this instruction before leaving for Lucknow on Sunday for consultations with the Uttar Pradesh administration.

Sources said that daily investigation reports, which include detailed records of questioning trust officials and others involved in the probe, have been saved in digital form. These reports will be finalised before being presented to Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath.

This move by the SIT is a major step in the ongoing investigation into the finances of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, which manages the Ram Temple. The temple, built at the historic Ram Janmabhoomi site in Ayodhya, was consecrated in January 2024 after years of legal struggle and construction work.

It is one of India's most important religious sites, attracting hundreds of thousands of devotees from India and abroad each month.

The trust, established after the Supreme Court's 2019 decision, oversaw the temple's construction with public donations.

These donations, totalling hundreds of crores of rupees, were intended to build, maintain, and support the temple. The SIT has been tasked to examine possible irregularities and pilferage of funds, but the specific complaints have not been shared publicly. Temple sources said the SIT has been carrying out inquiries in Ayodhya in recent days, questioning officials and others linked to the trust.

The sources said the order to remain in Ayodhya is intended to ensure officials are available for further questioning and to avoid any delays in the investigation. These steps are common in sensitive financial cases to keep the process fair.

Saving daily reports in digital form demonstrates a modern approach to handling the investigation, the sources added.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Delhi practices yoga together on International Yoga Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

While Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu led mass yoga sessions at the Yamuna Sports Complex alongside thousands of citizens, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta chose a strikingly different setting for her own practice on Sunday.

She rolled out her mat beside the Neeli Jheel inside the Asola Bhatti Wildlife Sanctuary, home to leopards, deer, and nilgai. On Sunday, Delhi marked the 12th International Day of Yoga with simultaneous events spanning all 70 Assembly constituencies, 29 DDA sports complexes and parks, and neighbourhood ghats and gardens across the capital.

The Chief Minister, joined by Cabinet Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa, South Delhi MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, and a large number of citizens and yoga instructors, said yoga is not merely physical exercise but a complete way of life that brings balance between the body, mind, and soul.

She noted that the Delhi government had organised the celebrations under the theme "One Delhi, One Yoga," with simultaneous programmes held across every Assembly constituency in the city, drawing participation from students, youth, women, and senior citizens.

The Chief Minister used the setting to draw attention to a part of Delhi, she said, that many residents remain unaware of. She described Asola Bhatti as one of the city's most valuable natural treasures, its lake, dense greenery, and resident wildlife making visitors feel transported far from the Capital.

She said plantation and forest conservation work is underway across the Asola region and the Southern Ridge, with native species like mango, neem, peepal, and banyan now replacing the kikar and babool trees that once dominated the landscape.

After the session, she visited the Viksit Bharat Nursery within the sanctuary and reviewed ongoing biodiversity work before interacting with soldiers of the 132 Infantry Battalion, Territorial Army, Eco Rajput Unit, deployed there, and commended them for protecting forest wealth alongside their military duties. She also planted a sapling under the Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam campaign and announced that a city-wide Clean Delhi, Green Delhi campaign, targeting 70 lakh saplings this year, will be launched in July by Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

PWD Minister Parvesh Verma performed yoga at Durga Puja Park, Shahjahan Road, near Junior Modern School, while Ashish Sood performed at his constituency, Janakpuri.

At the Yamuna Sports Complex, the LG was joined by Union Minister of State Harsh Malhotra and DDA Vice Chairman N. Saravana Kumar for the authority's main event, held under this year's national theme, "Yoga for Healthy Ageing." DDA organised sessions across 29 venues citywide, including the Siri Fort, Saket, Dwarka, Rohini, and Vasant Kunj sports complexes, as well as parks such as Baansera, Coronation Park, Hauz Khas Park, and Sanjay Lake Park. Sessions were conducted by Ministry of Ayush-trained instructors and included asanas, pranayama, and guided meditation.

DDA noted it manages nearly 15 per cent of Delhi's urban green area across more than 730 parks and 18 sports complexes. MLA Om Prakash Sharma, former Union Minister Dr Harsh Vardhan, Delhi Deputy Mayor Dr Monica Pant and Shahdara District BJP President Deepak Gaba were also present.

BJP National General Secretary Dushyant Gautam participated in the Yoga Day programme organised at Paharganj. MP Bansuri Swaraj participated in the Yoga Day programme at East Kidwai Nagar, while Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal attended the programme organised at Divya Yogashram, Bhamashah Road.

Delhi Culture Minister Kapil Mishra participated in International Yoga Day celebrations along the sacred banks of the Yamuna River, from Sonia Vihar to Wazirabad and across various embankments, along with thousands of citizens. He appealed to the people not to limit Yoga to a single day but to make it an integral part of their daily lives and contribute to the building of a healthy, strong, and self-reliant India.

Health Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh led a mass session at Chhath Ghat, Talab Park, in Kunwar Singh Nagar, framing yoga as a pillar of preventive healthcare. He said the Health Department is working to integrate yoga into public health programmes, including activities at Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, and stressed its value for both children developing healthy habits early and senior citizens pursuing active ageing.

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta joined hundreds of residents at District Park, Sector 14, Rohini, calling yoga India's timeless gift to humanity that strengthens the body and calms the mind. He urged the younger generation in particular to make it part of their daily routine.

Former Delhi BJP president and Gandhi Smriti vice-chairman Vijay Goel led people in performing Yoga in the backdrop of historic Jama Masjid in Old Delhi.

What stood out across Sunday's celebrations was the sheer range of backdrops against which the same simple practice unfolded: a Chief Minister stretching beside a forest lake within earshot of wildlife, a Lieutenant Governor leading thousands at a major sports complex, a Health Minister at a riverside ghat, and a Speaker among children and grandparents in a neighbourhood park.

केनरा बैंक Canara Bank
भारत सरकार का उपक्रम A Government of India Undertaking
सिंडिकेट Syndicate

TAGORE GARDEN DELHI Branch

DEMAND NOTICE [SECTION 13(2)]

Ref: CB0391/SARFAESI/RAJEEVKHANNA/2026-27 **Date: 20/06/2026**

To,
1. Mr. Rajeev Khanna S/O Late Sh. Balraj Khanna,
P-3 /53, DLF CITY, PHASE-II, GURGAON, HARYANA , 122001
2. Mr. Yogesh Khanna S/o Late Sh. Balraj Khanna,
P-3 /53, DLF CITY, PHASE-II, GURGAON, HARYANA , 122001
3. Mrs. Anuradha Khanna,
P-3 /53, DLF CITY, PHASE-II, GURGAON, HARYANA , 122001
4. Mrs. Shaloo Khanna
E-440 IST FLOOR, GREATER KAILASH II, NEW DELHI, 110048

Dear Sir / Madam,
Sub: **Notice issued under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation & Reconstruction of Financial Assets & Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.**
The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Canara Bank, **TAGORE GARDEN DELHI Branch** (hereinafter referred to as "the secured creditor"), appointed under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, (hereinafter referred as the "Act") do hereby issue this notice to you as under:
That **Mr. Rajeev Khanna S/O Late Sh. Balraj Khanna, Mr. Yogesh Khanna S/o Late Sh. Balraj Khanna, Mrs. Anuradha Khanna & Mrs. Shaloo Khanna**(hereinafter referred to as "the Borrower/Co-Borrower") has availed credit facility / facilities stated in the **Schedule A** hereunder and has entered into the security agreement/s in favour of the secured creditor. While availing the said financial assistance, you have expressly undertaken to repay the loan amount/s in accordance with the terms and conditions of the above mentioned agreements. That ... (hereinafter referred to as "the Guarantor") has guaranteed the payment on demand of all moneys and discharge all obligations and liabilities owing or incurred to the secured creditor by the Borrower for credit facilities up to the limit of with interest thereon.
You (The person mentioned in schedule B) are also entered in to agreements against the secured assets which are detailed in **Schedule B** hereunder.
However, **From December 2013** the operation and conduct of the said financial assistance / credit facilities have become irregular. The books of account maintained by the secured assets shows that the liability of the Borrower towards the secured creditor as on date amounts to **Rs 1,52,19,013.16 (Rupees: One Crore Fifty-Two Lakhs Nineteen Thousand Thirteen & Paisa Sixteen Only)**, the details of which together with future interest rate are stated in **Schedule C** hereunder. It is further stated that the Borrower/Guarantor having failed to keep up with the terms of the above said agreement in clearing the dues of the secured creditor within the time given and have been evasive in settling the dues. The operation and conduct of the above said financial assistance / credit facility/ies having come to a standstill and as a consequence of the default committed in repayment of principal debt/ installment and interest thereon, the secured creditor was constrained to classify the debt as Non Performing Asset (NPA) as on **25/02/2014** in accordance with the directives/ guidelines relating to asset classification issued by the Reserve Bank of India.
The secured creditor through this notice brings to your attention that the Borrower has failed and neglected to repay the said dues/ outstanding liabilities and hence hereby demand you under Section 13(2) of the Act, by issuing this notice to discharge in full the liabilities of the Borrower as stated in **Schedule C** hereunder to the secured creditor **within 60 days from the date of receipt of this notice**. Further, it is brought to your notice that you are also liable to pay future interest at the rate of **Interest as mentioned in Schedule C** per annum together with all costs, charges, expenses and incidental expenses with respect to the proceedings undertaken by the secured creditor in recovering its dues.
Please take note of the fact that if you fail to repay to the secured creditor the aforesaid sum **Rs 1,52,19,013.16 (Rupees: One Crore Fifty Two Lakhs Nineteen Thousand Thirteen & Paisa Sixteen Only),** together with further interest and incidental expenses and costs as stated above in terms of this notice under Section 13(2) of the Act, the secured creditor will exercise all or any of the rights detailed under sub-section (4)(a) and (b) of Section 13, the extract of which is given here below to convey the seriousness of this issue: 13(4)- In case the Borrower/Guarantor fails to discharge liability in full within the period specified in sub-section (2), the secured creditor may take recourse to one or more of the following measures to recover his secured debt, namely;
(a)Take possession of the secured assets of the Borrower/Guarantor including the right to transfer by way of lease, assignment or sale for realizing the secured asset;
(b)Take over the management of the business of the Borrower including the right to transfer by way of lease, assignment or sale for realizing the secured asset:
Provided that the right to transfer by way of lease, assignment or sale shall be exercised only where the substantial part of the business of the Borrower is held as security for the debt; Provided further that where the management of whole of the business or part of the business is severable, the secured creditor shall take over the management of such business of the borrower which is
relatable to the security for the debt and under other applicable provisions of the said Act. Your attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.
You are also put on notice that **in terms of section 13(13) the Borrower/Guarantor shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise the said secured assets detailed in Schedule B hereunder without obtaining written consent of the secured creditor**. It is further brought to your notice that any contravention of this statutory injunction/ restraint, as provided under the said Act, is an offence and if for any reason, the secured assets are sold or leased out in the ordinary course of business, the sale proceeds or income realized shall be deposited with the secured creditor. In this regard you shall have to render proper accounts of such realization / income.
This notice of Demand is without prejudice to and shall not be construed as waiver of any other rights or remedies which the secured creditor may have including further demands for the sums found due and payable by you.
This is without prejudice to any other rights available to the secured creditor under the Act and/or any other law in force.
Please comply with the demand under this notice and avoid all unpleasantness. In case of Non-compliance, further needful action will be resorted to, holding you liable for all costs and consequence.

Thanking you,
Yours faithfully,
AUTHORIZED OFFICER

SCHEDULE A
[Details of the credit facility/ies availed by the Borrower]

Sl No	Loan No	Nature of Loan/Limit	Date of sanction	Amount
1.	0391619000020	HOME LOAN	22.02.2011	Rs. 37,00,000/-
			Total :	Rs. 37,00,000/-

SCHEDULE B
[Details of security assets]

IMMOVABLES			
S No	DESCRIPTION OF THE PROPERTY	NAME OF TITLE HOLDER	CERSAI DETAILS
1	All the part & parcel of the Residential House Bearing No 53, Road No P-3 measuring 179.76 Sq. Mtrs having covered area 2900 Sq. Ft. Approx. situated in the residential colony known as DLF CITY, Phase- II in and around Village Shahpur, The. & Dist Gurgaon, Haryana Boundaries:- (As per Sale Deed) East:- Plot No. P-3/54 West:- Plot No. P-3/52 North:- Road South:- Plot No. P-4/22	Mr. Rajeev Khanna S/O Late Sh. Balraj Khanna, & Mr. Yogesh Khanna S/o Late Sh. Balraj Khanna	CERSAI ID - 1000201212

SCHEDULE C
[Details of liability as on date]

Sl No	LOAN NO	NATURE OF LOAN/LIMIT	LIABILITY WITH INTEREST AS ON DATE 19.06.206	RATE OF INTEREST
1.	0391619000020	HOME LOAN	Rs. 1,52,19,013.16	10.75%
		TOTAL	Rs. 1,52,19,013.16	

Yours faithfully,
AUTHORIZED OFFICER, CANARA BANK

Yoga offers solutions to global health challenges: Pradhan at DU event

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan performs yoga on the occasion of International Yoga Day in New Delhi PTI

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Sunday said yoga offers solutions to many of the health challenges confronting the world today, from mental health concerns to issues of physical fitness.

Pradhan, who attended the 12th International Day of Yoga event at Delhi University's South Campus as the chief guest, said yoga, one of the oldest traditions of Indian civilisation, has reached every corner of the world over the last decade under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"The world today is facing numerous health challenges, ranging from mental health concerns to issues of physical fitness. The science of yoga offers solutions to many of these problems," he said. The minister urged people to devote at least 10 minutes every day to yoga, whether in the morning or before going to bed, and adopt it as a year-round practice.

A healthy individual, he said, is better equipped to contribute to society and serve humanity.

Pradhan said yoga is gradually becoming an integral part of people's lives and credited Modi with successfully positioning the ancient Indian practice on the global stage in the 21st century.

Congratulating Delhi University on its improved performance in the QS World University Rankings 2027, Pradhan noted that the institution had moved from the 600-plus bracket some years ago to rank 322 and was poised for further progress.

"As India advances towards becoming a Viksit Bharat, the University of Delhi will play a significant leadership role and should aspire to be among the world's top 100 universities in the coming years," he said.

Speaking to reporters after the programme, the minister also expressed confidence in the conduct of the NEET examination, saying he had full faith in the National Testing Agency, state governments, district administrations and the education community.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public at large is hereby informed that our client intends to purchase the properties – 1. Unit No.27 on ground floor having Super area of 660 sq. ft., and 2. Unit No.28 on ground floor having super area of 771 sq. ft., both owned by Mrs Garima Arora are situated in Commercial Complex known as "Eros City Square" at Rosewood City, Sector 49-50, Gurgaon, Haryana; hereinafter referred to as the said property.

Any person(s)/Govt. agencies having any claim, right, title, or interest in the said property, by way of sale, mortgage, lease, lien, gift, inheritance, possession, or otherwise, is hereby requested to inform the undersigned with documentary proof within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.

If no objection is received within the said period, it shall be presumed that no such claims exist and the transaction will proceed accordingly.

Progressive Law Group
Advocates, Legal Advisors & Consultants
9/14, Third Floor, East Patel Nagar, New Delhi 110008. Mob. 9871430462

Police mark Yoga Day with force-wide participation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Satish Golcha

Delhi Police celebrated the International Day of Yoga 2026 with a large-scale yoga session at the Police Headquarters on Jai Singh Road. On the occasion, senior officers and personnel gathered to promote physical fitness, mental well-being, and stress management through the ancient Indian practice.

The main programme was held on the lawns of the Police Headquarters and was attended by Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golcha as the chief guest.

Senior officers, including Special Commissioners, Joint Commissioners, Additional Commissioners, Deputy Commissioners and personnel from different units of the force, participated in the event.

The session was organised by the Welfare Division of Delhi Police under the supervision of Special Commissioner of Police (Welfare) Atul Katiyar. Officials said the event reflected the force's continued focus on the health and well-being of its personnel, who routinely perform demanding duties under challenging circumstances.

Yoga instructors from the Delhi Police conducted the programme in accordance with the Common Yoga Protocol. Participants performed a series of yoga postures, breathing exercises and meditation practices aimed at improving flexibility, reducing stress, and enhancing overall physical and mental health.

The event formed part of the nationwide observance of International Day of Yoga, which is celebrated every year on June 21. The day was adopted by the United Nations in 2014 following a proposal by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and is observed across the world to highlight the benefits of yoga in promoting a balanced and healthy lifestyle.

Delhi Police officials said the enthusiastic turnout demonstrated the force's commitment to maintaining discipline, fitness, and emotional resilience. They noted that yoga has become an important tool for preventive healthcare and stress management, particularly for police personnel who work under constant pressure and demanding operational conditions.

Senior officers attending the programme encouraged personnel to make yoga a regular part of their daily routine. They said the practice not only contributes to better health but also helps improve concentration, endurance, and professional efficiency. The event at Police Headquarters was accompanied by similar programmes across Delhi Police districts and specialised units. Officers and staff at various locations participated in yoga sessions organised as part of the force-wide observance of the day.

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Maya Devi, Mother of No.16022361F Hav Sandeep R/o- VPO- Nayagaon, Teh- Kosli, Dist- Rewari, Haryana-123303, have changed my name from Maya Devi to Mayakaur, vide affidavit dated 20/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1426)C

I, Syed Mohemod Sadiq S/o JC-676327K Sub/MT Syed Mahaboob Basha, R/o- 6-1-425/1 Sivanagar, Gopavaram Mandalam, Badvel Post, Dist- Cuddapah, A.P- 516227, have changed my name from Syed Mohemod Sadiq to Syed Mohammad Sadiq, vide affidavit dated 20/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1427)C

I, Syed Mahamad Haneef S/o JC-676327K Sub/MT Syed Mahaboob Basha, R/o- 6-1-425/1 Sivanagar, Gopavaram Mandalam, Badvel Post, Dist- Cuddapah, A.P- 516227, have changed my name from Syed Mahamad Haneef to Syed Mahammad Haneef, vide affidavit dated 20/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1428)C

I, Aaisha W/o No.16022828F Nk Rahish, R/o- Khatoli Jat, PO- Kamania, Teh- Narnaul, Dist- Mahendergarh, Haryana-123001, have changed my name from Aaisha to Ayasha Bano & DOB from 13/09/1996 to 13/09/1998, vide affidavit dated 19/06/2026 before Executive Magistrate Narnaul.
PD(1429)C

I, Karishma Khatun, W/o-No.15671340W Hav MD Khushnoor, R/o- Vill- Mednipur, Po & Teh- Manihari, Dist- Katihar, Bihar-854113, have changed my name from Karishma Khatun to Karishma Khatoon, vide affidavit dated 20/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1430)C

I, Syed Husen Peera, Father of JC-676327K Sub/MT Syed Mahaboob Basha, R/o- 6-1-425/1 Sivanagar, Gopavaram Mandalam, Badvel Post, Dist- Cuddapah, A.P- 516227, have changed my name from Syed Husen Peera to Sayed Hussaia Peera, vide affidavit dated 20/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1431)C

I, Syed Bibi, Mother of JC-676327K Sub/MT Syed Mahaboob Basha, R/o- 6-1-425/1 Sivanagar, Gopavaram Mandalam, Badvel Post, Dist- Cuddapah, A.P- 516227, have changed my name from Syed Bibi to Sayed Bibi, vide affidavit dated 20/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1432)C

I, Bolla Koteswari, W/o- JC-780075P Nb/Sub Madhava Rao Bolla, R/o- H.No. 12-2-479/16/132, MSR Township, Sagar Road, Macherla, Dist- Palnadu, A.P.- 522426, have changed my name from Bolla Koteswari to Koteswari Bolla, vide affidavit No. IN-DL37050289123209Y dated 20/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1433)C

I hitherto known as Pavaninder Singh Ahluwalia S/o Rajinder Singh Ahluwalia, R/o WZ-688, Ground Floor, Gali No. 1, Behind DDA Market, Shiv Nagar Ext, Janakpuri B-1, West Delhi, Delhi-110058, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as **P S Ahluwalia**.
PD(1434)C

GURUGRAM ROAD RAGE

Two BBA graduates arrested for assault, vandalism

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

In a road rage case, two BBA graduates, travelling in a Scorpio SUV, allegedly assaulted a car driver and vandalised his vehicle on Sohna Road near Rajiv Chowk, in Gurugram. Police arrested both accused within hours of the incident taking place. The attack, captured on video by the injured motorist, left him with a shoulder injury and cuts near his eyes from shattered glass.

According to the complainant, the incident occurred on June 20 while he was travelling from Sohna Road towards Rajiv Chowk in his Windsor car. He alleged that two men in a Scorpio were driving recklessly and in a zigzag manner, narrowly avoiding a collision with his vehicle. When the complainant objected, the accused allegedly stopped his car, verbally abused him and created a scene on the road.

In a video that he filmed from inside his car, the man is seen screaming at the accused before turning to bystanders for help. "Why are you doing this? What have you done? Mera muh tod diya (They smashed my face). Stop these goons," he is heard saying.

In another video, he recounted the attack by the two students. "My car's windowpanes were smashed, and I was beaten with sticks. They indulged in road rage. I am left bloodied," he said.

The police acted swiftly after a video of the incident went viral on social media. The two accused, both residents of Sector 48, were arrested within hours, and their Scorpio SUV was seized. They are being questioned, and further legal action is underway.

During questioning, the accused allegedly admitted that an argument broke out after the complainant did not give way to their vehicle, following which they attacked him in anger.

JJ rehabilitation policy to provide dignified life for Gen Z: Sood

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi Government's newly approved rehabilitation and relocation policy for residents of Jhuggi-Jhopri (JJ) clusters seeks to provide a dignified living environment for Gen Z, helping them access better education and pursue their aspirations.

January 1, 2025, had been fixed as the eligibility cut-off date for rehabilitation benefits under the policy. Targeting nearly four lakh families, the policy promises a transition from precarious slum living to formal, *pucca* housing through a mix of in-situ rehabilitation and selective relocation with essential civic amenities, including schools, health centres, playgrounds, and anganwadi centres.

Announcing the Delhi Slum and JJ Cluster Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy, 2026, Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood said on Sunday. the policy would help young residents realise their dreams and become active contributors to the country's growth.

He said providing secure housing and better civic amenities was essential for their social and economic progress. Calling it a major step towards building a "Viksit Rajdhani," Sood said the policy aligns with the broader vision of a "Viksit Bharat" and seeks to ensure inclusive urban development for all sections of society.

Sood said January 1, 2025, has been fixed as the eligibility cut-off date for rehabilitation benefits under the policy, intended to bring greater clarity and relief to eligible beneficiaries. He alleged that the previous AAP government had failed to adequately address rehabilitation concerns, resulting in difficulties for many residents.

By ensuring a proper educational environment, it aims to help them realise their dreams so they can actively contribute to the nation's growth, he said. The minister expressed gratitude to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah for their support in making the policy possible and advancing the rehabilitation agenda for slum residents in the national capital.

Expressing confidence in the policy implementation, Sood said the chief minister Rekha Gupta-led government would achieve its targets and ensure that eligible residents receive the benefits envisaged under the rehabilitation and relocation plan.

On June 16, Shah said the Delhi government should issue tenders for at least five public-private-partnership-based rehabilitation projects every month. Chairing a review meeting on the rehabilitation of slum dwellers in the national Capital, the home minister directed the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB) to issue tenders for five clusters within 45 days.

He told officials to prepare project documents and tender forms for an additional 50 JJ clusters.

"In the meeting, Shah said the Delhi Slum and JJ Cluster Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy, 2026, has been finalised today and the Delhi government should notify it at the earliest," according to an official statement.

The home minister directed that sufficient provisions for community facilities, such as anganwadi centres, educational facilities, health centres and playgrounds, must be made during the construction of the rehabilitation colonies. Shah underlined that the decisions taken at the meeting will benefit four lakh families living in Delhi's "jhuggi-jhopdi" (JJ) clusters.

Parents, candidates benefit from special NEET re-exam arrangements

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Nearly 45,000 parents and candidates benefited from special facilities arranged by the Delhi Government for Sunday's NEET re-examination. The facilities, including free DTC bus travel for all candidates and cooling zones equipped with seating, drinking water, and first aid set up outside all 97 examination centres across the capital, in what Chief Minister Rekha Gupta described as a first-of-its-kind initiative in the country.

The Chief Minister said the examination was conducted peacefully and smoothly across Delhi and that feedback received throughout the day showed the arrangements brought considerable relief to students and their families. She said the government's initiative extended attention not just to candidates but specifically to their parents, a dimension she described as new for an examination of this scale.

Ahead of the examination, the government's stated objective was to ensure no candidate faced transport difficulties reaching their centre and that parents did not have to endure discomfort while waiting outside in the heat. To meet this, free travel in DTC buses was extended to all NEET candidates, who could avail the facility simply by presenting their valid admit cards. Students said the free travel arrangement reduced transportation-related worries and allowed them to concentrate better on the examination itself.

Guardians of NEET-UG candidates wait at a cooling zone set up at an examination centre in New Delhi PTI

The cooling zones set up outside all 97 centres drew particular appreciation from parents. These zones were equipped with seating arrangements, clean drinking water, ORS, shikanji, tea, and first-aid facilities. Parents said the arrangements made the long hours of waiting outside considerably more comfortable.

Officials said nearly 45,000 candidates and parents who visited the centres made use of these facilities, with many expressing satisfaction that such support had been extended to them for the first time during a competitive examination.

The Chief Minister said competitive examinations represent a significant milestone in the lives of young people and that the government's responsibility on such occasions goes beyond administrative arrangements to understanding the actual needs of candidates and their families. She said that when parents feel reassured during the waiting period, it has a tangible positive effect on students' confidence and performance during the examination itself.

The Chief Minister credited the coordinated work of the district administration, the Transport Department, DTC, Delhi Police, the Health Department, and other agencies involved in the day's arrangements. She said the smooth conduct of the examination was the result of multiple departments working together rather than any single agency's effort. She added that the Delhi government accords high priority to education, youth empowerment, and citizen services and indicated that similar citizen-centric initiatives for students and their families during examinations would continue going forward.

Sunday's NEET re-examination, necessitated after disruptions affected the original test process, saw the city's police, traffic, and crowd management arrangements run in parallel with these welfare measures. The pairing of strict security checks at entry points with cooling zones and free transport outside reflects an approach that treated the day as both a law-and-order exercise and a logistical exercise in reducing strain on families, particularly given the heat conditions that have persisted in Delhi through much of June.

For many parents who spent hours outside examination centres while their children sat the test inside, the availability of shade, water, and a place to sit may have been a modest addition to an otherwise stressful day, but one that organisers said made a measurable difference in how families experienced the wait.

Delhi witnesses tight security for NEET re-examination

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi witnessed elaborate security arrangements across examination centres on Sunday for the NEET re-examination. Police deploying additional personnel and carrying out strict checks at entry points to ensure the test is conducted smoothly without any untoward incident.

Senior police officers said security was intensified around all examination venues in the capital for the day. Entry points at every centre saw heightened checks as students arrived for the test.

Adequate police deployment, traffic regulation measures, and crowd management arrangements were put in place to maintain law and order around the venues, officials said. The arrangements were aimed specifically at preventing any disruption during the examination and ensuring candidates could access centres without difficulty.

Beyond the security cover, authorities also made provisions for the families accompanying candidates. Free drinking water and refreshments were arranged for parents and guardians waiting outside examination centres, a gesture aimed at easing the wait for those accompanying students through what is typically a long and anxious morning outside the gates.

A NEET-UG aspirant enters an examination centre after security screening ahead of the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination in New Delhi PTI

The scale of the security deployment reflects the sensitivity that has come to surround NEET examinations in recent years, particularly re-examinations, which are conducted only when the original test process is disrupted or compromised in some way and therefore draw additional scrutiny from both authorities and the public. Centres conducting re-examinations are typically treated with the same, if not greater, level of security as the original exam date, given the consequences of any further disruption for the affected candidates.

For families waiting outside, the day often combines the ordinary tension of an important examination with the added anxiety of knowing this is a second attempt necessitated by circumstances beyond the students' control.

PWD undertakes city-wide pothole repair drive ahead of monsoon

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

With the Monsoon approaching, the Public Works Department (PWD) on Sunday undertook a special drive to repair over 2,000 identified potholes across the national Capital.

According to the departmental records, 14,757 potholes were identified on PWD roads between January 1 and June 4, 2026, out of which 12,762 potholes had already been repaired. The special drive was aimed at fixing the remaining potholes at the identified locations before the monsoon, said a PWD statement.

Engineers, field staff and maintenance teams were deployed across the capital to repair identified potholes on priority before the onset of heavy rains.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma personally inspecting ongoing repair works at multiple locations and reviewing the progress.

Senior officials of the department also remained on the ground to ensure that the task is completed within the stipulated timeframe. "PWD remains vigilant throughout the year in addressing complaints related to potholes and road maintenance. With the monsoon approaching, our focus is to ensure that roads are in the best possible condition before the rains begin," Verma said.

FILE PHOTO

Many of the potholes being repaired today are on roads constructed several years ago where quality standards were not adequately maintained, Verma said and added "We have strengthened quality control measures and introduced greater accountability."

The PWD minister said that new roads being constructed by the department are covered under a five-year maintenance provision, under which contractors are responsible for rectifying any defects that arise during the warranty period.

He emphasised that the Delhi government is focused not only on creating infrastructure but also on ensuring its sustained quality and performance through regular monitoring and timely maintenance. New roads being constructed by PWD are covered under a five-year maintenance provision, under which contractors are responsible for rectifying any defects that arise during the warranty period, the minister added.

Police rescue man attempting to jump from ISBT building

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Police personnel rescued a 32-year-old man who was threatening to jump from the fifth floor of the ISBT Kashmere Gate building.

A Delhi police head constable climbed out through the window himself to reach the man and pull him back to safety, averting what could have been a tragedy.

Police said a PCR call was received on June 19 reporting that a man was standing at the building threatening to jump. Head Constable Ajay and Constable Piyush of the ISBT police post rushed to the spot and found the man standing on the outer ledge outside a fifth-floor window.

The two policemen began talking to the distressed man in an effort to calm him while simultaneously working out a plan to bring him to safety. A safety rope was secured around his waist, with the other end anchored inside the building as a precaution.

FILE PHOTO

"Risking his own safety, Head Constable Ajay climbed out through the window and moved towards the man. At an opportune moment, he managed to grab hold of him and pull him back inside," a senior police officer said.

The rescued man has been identified as Mohammad Kamran, a resident of Unnao in Uttar Pradesh. After the rescue, he was provided counselling and, following verification, handed over to his father.

The episode highlights the kind of split-second judgment calls that police personnel at transit hubs like ISBT Kashmere Gate are sometimes called upon to make, balancing the need to keep a distressed person talking and calm against the urgency of physically intervening before it is too late. The safety rope arrangement, anchored inside the building before Head Constable Ajay went out onto the ledge, reflects a degree of procedural caution even in a moment that demanded quick action.

Kamran's case ended with him being handed over to his father after counselling, suggesting police were able to establish contact with his family and ensure he would not be left without support following the incident.

Police did not disclose further details about what led to the distress that brought Kamran to the building's fifth floor that day, though that information was not material to the rescue effort that followed.

Police arrest man in online rental fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Police have arrested a 21-year-old man for allegedly providing his bank account to receive proceeds from an online rental fraud. In the fraud, a flat owner was duped of ₹34,999 by a scammer posing as an Indian Army subedar interested in renting the property.

The complainant had listed his flat on an online property portal. He was contacted by a prospective tenant who introduced himself as an Army subedar, a designation that typically lends an air of trustworthiness and urgency to such transactions.

After the two finalised the rental deal, the fraudster asked the victim to share his UPI details and send ₹1 as a verification step, a request that, on the surface, appeared routine and low-risk. The fraudster then generated a "request money" transaction for ₹34,999 through the UPI app and presented it to the victim as if it were a payment being sent to him rather than a request for money to be debited from his account.

Believing he was simply accepting an incoming payment, the victim approved the request and entered his UPI PIN.

The amount was immediately debited from his account and transferred to the fraudster. Technical investigation into the transaction trail led police to the beneficiary account holder, identified as Himanshu Mondal, a resident of Gurugram. He was arrested on June 18. One mobile phone was recovered from him during the arrest.

The fraud follows a pattern that has become increasingly common in India's rental and property listing ecosystem, where UPI's "request money" feature is exploited to reverse the

usual direction of a transaction in the victim's mind. Most users are conditioned to associate UPI prompts with receiving money when a notification appears to confirm a payment, and fraudsters have learned to use this assumption against them. By disguising a payment request as an incoming transfer and pairing it with a low-value, seemingly harmless ₹1 "verification" step beforehand to build trust, scammers are able to extract significantly larger sums once the victim's guard is down.

The use of a fabricated military designation, in this case an Army subedar, is also a recurring feature in such scams. Posing as defence personnel lends credibility and urgency to a transaction, since military buyers and tenants are often perceived as reliable and time-constrained, making victims less likely to question unusual payment steps or insist on meeting in person before proceeding.

Mondal's arrest reflects how investigators in such cases typically work backward from the money trail rather than the original deception. Rather than the fraudster who impersonated the Army officer, it was the individual who allowed his bank account to be used to receive and presumably forward the stolen funds who was identified and apprehended first, a common pattern in online financial fraud investigations where mule accounts are often easier to trace than the original perpetrators, who frequently operate through fake identities and disposable phone numbers.

Three held for conspiracy to extort ₹10 crore from defence firm owner

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Police has arrested three people for allegedly conspiring to extort ₹10 crore from a defence equipment manufacturer by issuing life threats in the name of Khalistani and gangster elements, an official said on Sunday.

The accused were identified as Gurpinder Singh alias Prince, 32, and Shamsher Singh alias Sam, 35, both residents of Tarn Taran in Punjab, and Jaswant Singh, 59, a resident of Amritsar.

Police said the arrests helped crack two extortion-related cases, including a Punjab case involving firing at the complainant Sahil Luthra.

"The case pertains to an FIR registered at the Chanakyapuri police station in October 2025 on a complaint by Sahil Luthra, founder and managing director of Vijayan Trishul Defence Solutions Pvt Ltd (VTDS)," a senior police officer said.

According to the police, Luthra had alleged that he received extortion calls and messages in August and September 2025 demanding ₹10 crore and threatening him with dire consequences in the name of gangster Goldy Brar and Khalistani elements.

On June 4 this year, he allegedly received another threatening voice note from an international number reiterating the demand and issuing fresh threats," the officer said.

The investigation was transferred to the Crime Branch on June 10. A team conducted technical analysis of digital evidence and obtained information from several service providers, leading to the identification and arrest of the accused, the police said.

During interrogation, Gurpinder and Shamsher disclosed that they had transmitted the threatening voice note at the instance of Jaswant Singh, who was overseeing the Punjab operations of the complainant's company.

"Further investigation revealed that earlier extortion calls and messages were allegedly orchestrated through a man identified as Manni, operating from Spain, in connivance with Jaswant Singh," police said.

The accused allegedly helped create a false threat narrative involving Khalistani and gangster elements and coordinated threatening communications as part of a criminal conspiracy to extort money from the businessman.

Police said the disclosures are being corroborated through technical evidence and other independent sources. Police also found the accused were allegedly linked to a firing incident targeting the complainant in Punjab, which is being examined as part of a separate extortion case.

Jaswant Singh, a former Punjab Police assistant sub-inspector who was dismissed from service in 2006, has previously been named in two criminal cases in Punjab. Further investigation is underway to identify other persons involved in the conspiracy.

The Pioneer
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IN FOCUS

Indian Naval Ship Tarkash arrives at Port Louis during its operational deployment to the South West Indian Ocean Region, in Port Louis, Mauritius. PTI

A quiet pause, thoughtful heart: PM Modi's gesture for NEET aspirants

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi

On a bright Sunday afternoon at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had just landed back in the city around 1:15 pm. Usually, the next step would be a swift departure for home.

But this Sunday was different. The NEET-UG re-examination, an important day filled with hope and nerves for hundreds of thousands of students across India, was about to start at 2 pm. Many students were on their way to exam centres, hoping to become doctors.

If the Prime Minister's convoy had moved suddenly, it could have caused traffic diversions, delays, and extra stress for students rushing to their exams. Instead of going home right away, PM Modi decided to stay at the airport and wait until after the exam had started.

During that time, the roads stayed clear for students. There were no diversions or last-minute rushes, just an easy trip for young people on a big day. While people often see the Prime Minister handling global or national issues, this choice at the airport showed he also cares about everyday problems, especially for young people whose futures depend on days like this. For students rushing to their centres, the roads stayed open. For parents waiting outside exam halls, there was one less thing to worry about. For everyone watching, it was a reminder that leadership can also mean making quiet, thoughtful choices.

In today's busy world, PM Modi's choice to wait sent a clear message: "Your dreams matter. Your journey matters. And I will make sure nothing gets in your way today".

This thoughtful pause allowed thousands of students to focus on their exams, preparation, and future. Sometimes, the most meaningful gestures are the simplest ones.

A story of resilience: Shrishti's brave path to NEET re-exam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi/Kolkata

On a Sunday morning in Kolkata, Shrishti Dubey sat for an exam that could change her life. As a NEET aspirant from the city, she faced many reasons to stay home. Only a week before, on 14 June 2026, a serious road accident left her with nine broken ribs and severe lung injuries.

She had major vascular surgery and needed artificial ventilation. Her recovery had just begun, and she still needed oxygen and a chest drain. When the re-NEET exam came on 21 June, she decided to take it. Her story shows her determination and the support she received from others.

Her family contacted the authorities to explain her situation, and the National Testing Agency responded. At Binodini Girls High School in Dhakuria, Kolkata, her exam centre, special arrangements were made. She got a separate room on the ground floor. Doctors and paramedics from ILS Hospital stayed with her during the three-hour exam. An ambulance waited outside, and she was allowed to take the test with her medical equipment.

On the day of the exam, Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan spoke with her parents. By evening, Shrishti had finished her paper. Her family thanked the minister, the NTA, and the medical team for helping their daughter continue her dream of becoming a doctor while she was still recovering.

Stories like Shrishti's remind us that every NEET roll number belongs to a young person with hopes, pressures, and personal struggles.

346 Sikh pilgrims depart for Lahore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Amritsar

A jatha (group) of 346 Sikh pilgrims crossed over to Pakistan from the Attari-Wagah border here on Sunday to attend the death anniversary congregation of Maharaja Ranjit Singh in Lahore, located adjoining the historic Sikh shrine Gurdwara Panja Sahib, officials said.

An SGPC official said the jatha will visit Gurdwara Nankana Sahib after paying obeisance at Gurdwara Sacha Sauda Sahib, Mandi Chuharkana and will then return to Nankana Sahib.

The official said the jatha will stay at Gurdwara Panja Sahib to participate in the main congregation.

The official said afterwards, the group of Sikh pilgrims will visit Gurdwara Dehra Sahib (Lahore), Gurdwara Rori Sahib (Eminabad), and Gurdwara Sri Kartapur Sahib.

After staying at Gurdwara Dehra Sahib (Lahore), they will return to India on June 30.

He said the SGPC sent copies of holy Gutka Sahibs of Gurbani, kanghas (combs), karhas (iron bracelets), Kirpans, shawls, and tea with the jatha.

The official said for the pilgrims' convenience, the SGPC provided help filling out entry forms, etc, at the Attari border, and special buses were arranged for their transportation.

He said the SGPC also arranged langar and tea and water for the pilgrims at the Attari/Wagah border.

Identity crisis has hit those who created UP's identity crisis: CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE Hamirpur

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday said political parties responsible for the identity crisis of Uttar Pradesh, reducing its status to that of a "BIMARU" state, are now facing an identity crisis.

He said public funds are now used on centres of faith as opposed to building "boundary walls of kabristans" — an oft-repeated criticism by Adityanath against opposition parties.

"Uttar Pradesh is no longer struggling for an identity. Instead, those who once reduced the state to the status of a 'BIMARU' (sick) state are the ones now facing a crisis of identity. Those who had created an identity crisis for Uttar Pradesh are now confronting such a crisis themselves," the chief minister said.

Addressing a gathering in Hamirpur after inaugurating and laying the foundation stones for 75 development projects worth Rs 636 crore, Adityanath said these projects materialised because the people elected capable representatives. Their votes for the "lotus" (BJP's election symbol) have transformed the destiny of Uttar Pradesh.

Citing examples of the Kumbh Mela, the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, Adityanath slammed the the Samajwadi Party, the state's main opposition party.

"The Samajwadi Party used to order lathi-charges and firing on those chanting 'Jai Shri Ram,' and imposed bans on the celebration of Shri Krishna Janmotsav and the Kanwar Yatra. Yet it openly encouraged rowdy behaviour on the streets during Muharram and Eid."

Adityanath said the Ram Temple, the Kashi Vishwanath corridor and the shrine of Goddess Vindhyavasini in Mirzapur as examples of development.

He added his government has taken steps to beautify such places of worship. "Funds are now directed towards centres of faith. The money contributed by the public is no longer spent on constructing boundary walls for graveyards. That is the difference now," Adityanath asserted.

Speaking on the occasion of yoga day, he said that millions of people connected through yoga across the globe is a reflection of a transforming India.

Adityanath said yoga is a gift from India's tradition of sages and Prime Minister Modi has secured global recognition for it.

Hitting out at previous governments, he said, "In the past, 'mafia' used to encroach on the land of the poor, engage in illegal mining, endanger both traders and daughters and attack the police."

"The image of Bundelkhand and Hamirpur used to be tarnished, but today, under the BJP government, there is no place for the mafia. They are either behind bars or have been reduced to dust," the CM said.

Rajasthan CM directs to prepare blueprint for Abu Raj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Jaipur

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma on Sunday directed officials to prepare a comprehensive development blueprint for Abu Raj, earlier known as Mount Abu, keeping in view its tourism and spiritual potential, and environmental significance.

The government has rechristened Mount Abu, the sole hill station of the desert state and a prominent tourist place, as Abu Raj.

Chairing a meeting of development committee at Abu Raj, Sharma said development works should be completed in a coordinated and time-bound manner and directed the chief secretary and divisional commissioner to regularly monitor the projects.

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NEET re-exam: Govt passes litmus test

Their families reported difficulties commuting to the examination centres. Authorities in several cities implemented measures to mitigate these challenges.

In Bhopal, two students were denied entry to the centre after arriving late. Amir Qadri, uncle of one of the aspirants, said, "I have come here with my nephew for his examination. While on our way to the examination centre, we were involved in an accident and were a bit late because my nephew needed first aid. Now that we have reached here, we are being denied entry. The authorities are saying the exam has already begun and that it won't be possible to permit us entry."

In the same city, an injured candidate was granted a separate room at the examination centre, along with medical support and a standby ambulance after requesting special arrangements. The candidate, Shrishti Dubey, suffered severe injuries in a road accident on June 14 and sought assistance from the authorities for special arrangements.

Pradhan also spoke to the aspirant's parents, who conveyed their gratitude for the assistance provided by the NTA and the authorities.

In Mumbai, the Brihanmumbai Electric Supply and Transport (BEST) undertaking organised special bus services for students attending the re-examination, despite an ongoing employee strike. Officials also reported that in some States, including the national Capital, free drinking water and refreshments were provided for parents and guardians waiting outside examination centres.

Another NEET-UG candidate, Sonia, also said security was tighter this time. She added that such arrangements earlier could have reduced the chances of a paper leak and spared students trouble before taking the retest. Wearing a burqa and a dupatta, she alleged that she was denied entry to an examination centre in Rajasthan's Ajmer. The candidate, Kulsum Bano, claimed she had appeared for the earlier exam wearing the same attire.

"I have come from Beawar to take the NEET exam. The candidate said she had come from Beawar to take the NEET exam and had worn the same attire during the May 3 test. She said officials first asked her to remove the dupatta and then the *burqa*. If I am to take the exam and they don't allow me in this attire, then I won't take it," she had said. The NTA later clarified that the aspirant was allowed entry to the centre.

In Ahmedabad, a brief commotion was reported outside an exam centre after some parents objected to students being asked to remove *kanthi* (Hindu sacred threads) during frisking, while girls wearing *hijab* were allowed inside, police said. The issue was later resolved after police explained the NTA dress code guidelines to the parents and members of the groups gathered outside the centre.

The issue was later resolved after police explained the NTA dress code guidelines to the parents and members of the groups gathered outside the centre.

PM Modi calls yoga bridge between health...

The Prime Minister's stress on yoga fostering balance, self-awareness and inner stability — values, he said, that can help societies navigate divisions and discord — comes at a time when several regions continue to grapple with wars, armed confrontations and diplomatic strains, underscoring India's longstanding emphasis on dialogue, coexistence and peaceful resolution of disputes.

"Let us pledge not to restrict yoga to only one particular day or to an event; rather, make it a part of our lives and that of our families and our future generations," he added.

Modi said yoga has become the world's largest community celebration, bringing people together across countries and cultures. "June 21, which marks the longest day on Earth, has now become the largest community celebration day because of yoga. Yoga brings people together. I congratulate the people of the world on this occasion," he said.

The PM also congratulated the people of Kolkata for pursuing the 'Swachhata se Swagat' initiative. "I congratulate the people of Kolkata for their unwavering dedication and effort to make the 'Swachhata se Swagat' slogan into a mission and reality; their citizen duty has inspired the whole nation," he said.

Referring to this year's International Day of Yoga theme, 'Yoga for healthy ageing', Modi said the ancient practice plays a crucial role in promoting physical health, mental well-being and active ageing, thereby improving the quality of life. "Yoga is not just physical exercise. It is not restricted to any age group. It is an expression of the human spirit," he said.

"Our target is to be more flexible at 40 than we were at 20. We aim to be more energetic at 50 than we were at 30. Our target must be to be more resistant to lifestyle-related diseases at 70 than we were at 50. This is where yoga can help us," he added. The PM referred to Nobel laureate Rabindranath Tagore, who, he said, believed that the true essence of humanity lies not in independent living but in connecting with the world around it.

Addressing the gathering at the first such event on a grand scale in the city, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari credited Modi for the achievement of "bringing yoga home", while stressing that the tradition of yoga had been practiced in Bengal for over a century.

"Earlier, for reasons unknown, the previous State Government was not connected to the massive event which the PM has spread across the globe. But we believe that the day is being observed across the State today because of the people who took a historic decision," Adhikari said, referring to the change of guard in the State's power corridors.

Maritime prowess key to great nation status: PM

The PM commissioned the indigenously built stealth frigate Dunagiri, survey vessel Sanshodhak and anti-submarine warfare shallow water craft Agray. He said the frontline platforms represent key operational capabilities across maritime combat, hydrographic surveying and anti-submarine warfare. Modi said India demonstrated its maritime capabilities a few years ago by commissioning the aircraft carrier INS Vikrant. India's first indigenously built aircraft carrier, INS Vikrant, was commissioned in 2022.

West Bengal Governor RN Ravi, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, and Navy Chief Admiral Krishna Swaminathan were among the dignitaries present at the commissioning event.

PM said India's journey from INS Vikrant to this date is not just about new warships but towards increasing self-reliance. The PM said the commissioning of INS Agray, INS Dunagiri and INS Sansodhak is giving momentum to that journey. "These three ships were designed and built in India and represent the country's talent," he said.

The PM said Indian enterprises, engineers and workers were involved in the construction of the three naval platforms commissioned on Sunday. The vessels were designed by the Indian Navy's Warship Design Bureau and built by Kolkata-based Defence PSU Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers Ltd.

These platforms have indigenous content exceeding 75 per cent, with extensive participation by the Indian industry, including more than 200 MSMEs, in their construction, an official said.

Modi said India has been expanding new river waterways and developing multi-modal logistics network. He said the Sagarmala project is aimed at catalysing port-led economic prosperity.

Rebel MPs to formalise split from Uddhav...

The rebels are expected to explain their move by citing what they describe as the UBT leadership's deviation from the Shiv Sena's founding ideology. According to sources, they have cited concerns over an alleged plan to merge with the Congress, an MVA ally, as well as grievances including insufficient attention to constituency work, lack of organisational support, and limited access to senior leaders such as Aaditya Thackeray.

The UBT leadership has reacted sharply. Senior leader and Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut has strongly condemned the rebels, accusing them of betrayal and claiming they were poached through inducements. He alleged that the dissidents were flown to Delhi in chartered aircraft and offered large sums of money in what he called "Operation Tiger."

The party has issued show-cause notices to the six MPs for defying a whip and skipping a crucial parliamentary party meeting on June 18, which only three MPs attended. According to party representatives, they have separately approached Speaker Birla, urging him to reject the rebels' claims and uphold the provisions of the anti-defection law. If the split is formalised, UBT's strength in the Lok Sabha will fall from nine to three MPs.

This development is expected to strengthen the Shinde-led Shiv Sena faction, which is aligned with the BJP-led NDA Government in Maharashtra. It represents a clear setback for Uddhav Thackeray, who has sought to position his faction as the State's main Opposition voice. According to sources, the move could also shift parliamentary arithmetic during the upcoming Monsoon Session and further strain the MVA alliance of the Shiv Sena (UBT), the Congress, and the Sharad Pawar-led NCP. After the press conference, the rebel MPs are likely to meet Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde.

Speculation is strong that they will eventually merge with his faction, following the precedent set in 2022. The rebels had already stayed away from UBT events, including the party's 60th foundation day celebrations on June 19. This episode underscores the continuing internal divisions within Shiv Sena, a party founded by Bal Thackeray in 1966 on the planks of Marathi pride and Hindutva.

Meanwhile, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Sunday asserted that his party remains the only true Shiv Sena, in response to Union Home Minister Amit Shah's statement that the Eknath Shinde-led faction is the sole Shiv Sena. Thackeray made these remarks while addressing party workers in Bhandup, which falls under the Mumbai North-East Lok Sabha constituency represented by rebel Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Patil.

Thackeray stated that the undivided Shiv Sena, established by his father Bal Thackeray, spent three decades opposing the Congress. He added that despite this, the Congress did not attempt to dismantle or take control of the party.

US, Iran hold talks in Switzerland

US President Donald Trump has threatened to impose American tariffs on the Strait if a final deal with Iran isn't reached in 60 days. The interim agreement calls for toll-free travel for 60 days in the waterway that is vital for the world's supply of oil, natural gas and related goods like fertiliser.

Iranian State television says the Iranian and Qatari delegations are having discussions after the four-way negotiations, including the US and Pakistan.

Israeli President Isaac Herzog told Fox News that a peace agreement between Israel and Lebanon cannot be reached if Iran is "trying to squeeze itself into this conflict" via the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group.

Herzog's position is largely ceremonial. He said Israel and Lebanon will hold another round of talks in Washington on Tuesday. Hezbollah is not a party to the talks.

Iran wants any agreement with the US to include peace on all fronts, including Lebanon. It has been said that Lebanon will be a focus of today's talks in Switzerland.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian has expressed concern that some Iranians could openly protest again. He said in a speech reported by semiofficial news outlets that "what I fear is that we may fail to satisfy the people, and that they may come out into the streets to protest," which could affect the country's unity during negotiations with the US.

Nihangs storm gurudwara, take Sikh...

According to the police, the Nihangs engaged in vandalism, then took an elderly Sikh devotee who was at the gurudwara to the roof and started raising slogans. They are armed with spears, swords, axes, and kirpans, they said.

The four Nihang devotees were arrested in connection with the June 16 clash that stemmed from an altercation over parking near a hotel in Karnaprayag market.

A group of Nihang pilgrims were returning after offering prayers at the Sri Hemkund Sahib Gurudwara when they got into a war of words with locals at the market. Subsequently, the pilgrims allegedly attacked the other group with swords, injuring four locals. A Nihang pilgrim was also injured in the clash. Later, four Nihang pilgrims, all from Mohali, Punjab, were arrested in connection with the incident.

SIT asks Temple officials to remain in Ayodhya

By keeping statements, documents, and other evidence in digital form, the SIT ensures that records remain safe, easily accessible, and protected from tampering.

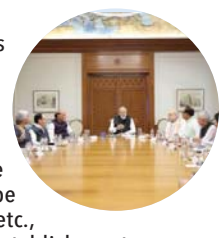
Once finished, the report will be sent to Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath for further action. It will include findings from interviews, financial checks, and other evidence. Based on the results, the government may choose to investigate further or take other actions to fulfil a long-standing aspiration. Any allegations of financial misconduct at such a high-profile project naturally attract widespread attention.

Devotees and observers are hopeful that the investigation will be conducted thoroughly and transparently to restore public trust in the institution. The SIT's visit to Lucknow on Sunday is believed to be linked to consultations with senior officials or the compilation of preliminary findings, the sources said.

The team is expected to return to Ayodhya to continue the investigation. Temple sources said the investigation is still ongoing and more people may be questioned soon. As the SIT continues, many are watching Ayodhya to see what happens next. More updates are expected after the final report goes to the Chief Minister's office.

GRAPEVINE

Cabinet reshuffle anticipated, invitations on hold

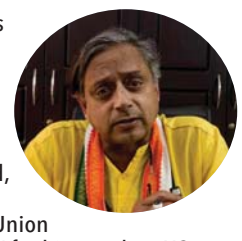


As a major overhaul of the Modi Cabinet has been doing the rounds for the last fortnight, an interesting observation has come to light. Except for the Government functions, the incumbent Council of Ministers are putting on hold the invitations to be the Chief Guest, Guest of Honour, etc., when approached by individuals, establishments, organisations, institutions, based on presumptions whether they continue to be the Minister or could be reallocated to a different Ministry. Grapevine has it that several new faces could be inducted, with an overall 60 per cent of the ministers likely to be replaced.

8th Pay Commission. When?

From Friday onwards, the top to bottom of bureaucracy is abuzz with the news on the forthcoming implementation of the Eighth Pay Commission. There were reports flashed in Social Media Groups that the Justice Ranjana Desai Commission has finished the preparation of the long-overdue Pay Commission Report. Most believe that by next month or before Diwali, the Report will be submitted to the Government. The question is when the Government will approve it, resulting in salary hikes. Many veteran officers say the implementation announcement will take more than a year. Some say the Government prefers to announce in mid 2028, a few months away from the Lok Sabha election, to keep Bureaucracy and retired persons in the vote bank.

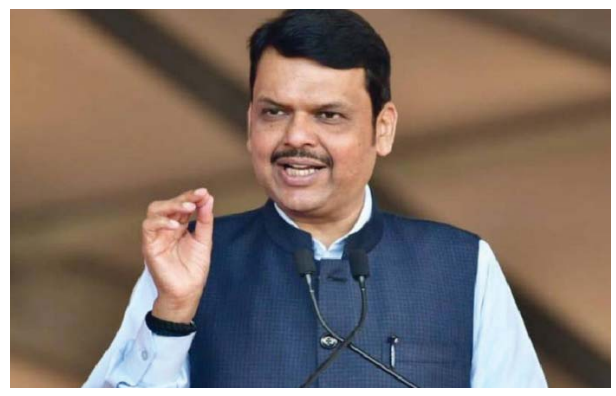
Tharoor annoys Congress again for talking Modi



Lok Sabha MP Shashi Tharoor has once again got into trouble for praising Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Just before the assembly elections in Kerala, the strained relationship between Tharoor and Congress was settled, and both sides maintained each other's sanctity until the former Union Minister once again talked 'Modi' for his stand on US diplomatic developments during the West Asia crisis. Congress officially attacked Tharoor on Saturday for giving statements on the good strategy presented by PM Modi. Grapevine has it that Tharoor flak from his party began a day after he attended and delivered a speech at an event backed by the Adani Group, which is always forbidden by the party's first family, the Gandhis.

Sena (UBT) crisis: Operation successful, says Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai



Amid the buzz over a split in the ranks of Lok Sabha MPs of Shiv Sena (UBT) through "Operation Tiger", Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday said the "operation" has been successful.

His deputy and Shiv Sena president Eknath Shinde said he never leaves an operation incomplete.

Responding to questions over the "Operation Tiger" aimed at securing defections from the Uddhav Thackeray camp, Fadnavis said, "The operation has been successful, and the body is in very good health. There is no need for anyone to worry. Those who need to introspect should do so."

Shinde, who addressed a joint news conference with Fadnavis, said he didn't conduct incomplete operations. "Whenever I undertake an operation, I complete it fully. We have already shown it," he said.

When asked about the status of Operation Tiger, Shinde said, "You will get breaking news soon. The MPs are abused, and then you (Thackeray camp) want them (back). There is a chemical locha." MPs Sanjay Dina Patil, Sanjay Deshmukh, Sanjay Jadhav, Bhausaheb Wakchaure, Nagesh Patil-Ashtikar and Nimbalkar skipped the Sena (UBT) parliamentary party meeting in Delhi on June 17, fuelling speculation that they were on their way to the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena.

The Sena (UBT) has nine Lok Sabha members, and the rebel bloc needs at least six MPs — two-thirds of the total strength — to avoid disqualification under the anti-defection law.

On Sunday, at least two of the six rebel MPs belonging to the Sena (UBT) confirmed they crossed over to the Shinde camp. Fadnavis said the Shiv Sena, led by Shinde, is carrying forward the legacy of the party founder Bal Thackeray.

"Shiv Sena is not merely a political party. It is Balasaheb Thackeray's ideology. It is not a legacy of property, but a legacy of ideas. The moment some people abandoned those ideas, those who believed in them chose a different path.

"All those people came together under the leadership of Eknath Shinde to keep Shiv Sena alive and carry forward that ideological legacy. Workers and public representatives who believe in those ideas are continuously coming together under his leadership," the Chief Minister said.

He advised Uddhav Thackeray to introspect.

"Uddhav ji did not introspect, and this is the consequence. There is no doubt in anyone's mind now that the Shiv Sena being run by Eknath Shinde is the real Shiv Sena. Balasaheb's bow-and-arrow symbol is with Eknath Shinde, and he is carrying forward Balasaheb's ideology," Fadnavis added.

When asked about the removal of several beneficiaries from the Ladki Bahin scheme, Fadnavis said the initiative was initially launched on the basis of self-certification.

CBSE declares Class 12 re-evaluation results

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) declared the revaluation results on Sunday for students who applied for verification and re-evaluation of their Class 12 board exam answer sheets, with over 87 per cent of the applications announced in the first phase.

"The CBSE has commenced the release of Class XII Verification of issues observed and Re-evaluation outcomes," the CBSE said in a post on X.

"The outcomes are being released in a phased manner, with over 87 per cent of the total applications received being declared today. The outcomes of the remaining applications will be available in phases, and the entire process is expected to be completed soon," it said. Students can check their updated marks on the official CBSE website results.digilocker.gov.in using their login credentials, the board said.

The CBSE assured students that every application was processed through a "robust, transparent, and carefully monitored system" to ensure fairness and accuracy. "Students are advised not to believe rumours or unverified social media posts and to rely only on official CBSE communications for authentic information," the board said.

"The CBSE offices will always remain available to provide guidance and assistance to students," it said.

The CBSE declared the results of the Class XII examinations 2026 on May 13, 2026, for approximately 17.69 lakh candidates. The CBSE provided candidates the facility to obtain scanned copies of their evaluated answer books from May 19 to May 25, 2026. Subsequently, candidates could apply for verification of observed issues and/or re-evaluation from June 2 to June 7, 2026.

The board said the post-result services platform functioned under the supervision of technical experts from the Digital India Corporation, IIT Kanpur and IIT Madras. To ensure the integrity of the entire process, the board said these experts supported the CBSE team to safeguard the system against unauthorised and malicious access.

"As was done last year, in all cases where a candidate's claim regarding observed issues is established, the CBSE corrects the evaluation, updates the marks, and the candidates can see the status of their requests on DigiLocker," it said. The board said candidates who applied for verification of observed issues and for whom CBSE reported the outcome as "No-change" if they wish to inspect their answer books at the concerned CBSE Regional Office.

2 dead in ammonia gas leak in Tamil Nadu's Tiruvallur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Tiruvallur (Tamil Nadu)

Two women died, and 62 others were affected following an ammonia gas leak at the production unit of a private fish meal export factory in Tiruvallur district on Sunday, the Tamil Nadu Government said.

The incident happened at Kannigaipair village near Periyapalayam.

According to a Government press release, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay has instructed the formation of a three-member committee with the Director of Industrial Safety and Health, the Member Secretary, Pollution Control Board and the Additional Director of Public Health, and to submit an interim report within 24 hours and a final report within three days.

Earlier, the police said the death toll was seven, but a CMO release and Health Minister KG Arunraj later put it at two.

Speaking to reporters, Arunraj said that an ammonia gas leak with an impact of this scale has never happened. "Doctors say we haven't seen cases with such high levels anywhere else," the minister said. He also said the health condition of some patients shows a worsening trend, adding that critical patients have been shifted out of private hospitals to Government hospitals.

Stop mosque demolitions in Rajasthan: Owaisi to Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Hyderabad

AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi on Sunday alleged that a wave of demolitions targeting mosques, dargahs, and other Muslim religious sites was underway across Rajasthan's border districts and urged Union Home Minister Amit Shah to immediately stop the "discriminatory and targeted" demolitions. The Hyderabad MP said he spoke to AIMIM Bikaner District President Shafi Jameel Qasmi, who informed him that four mosques in Bikaner and nine mosques and dargahs across Phalodi, Jaisalmer, and Barmer have already been demolished.

In a post on 'X', Owaisi said, "Notices have also reportedly been issued to hundreds of other religious sites. These demolitions are being justified on national security grounds. However, none of the people in these areas has ever been involved in any such activities. Only Muslim places of worship are being targeted."

The AIMIM chief further said the authorities have claimed that some structures were built on grazing land. However, in cases where it has been shown that the structures stand on private property, the allegation has reportedly shifted to a lack of permissions or approvals, he said. "@Amit Shah, these discriminatory and targeted demolitions are illegal and must be stopped immediately," Owaisi urged.

9 detained over suspected impersonation during NEET-UG re-exam in Bihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Patna

Nine persons were detained on Sunday in connection with alleged impersonation during the NEET-UG re-examination in Bihar's Lakhisarai district, officials said.

SP Prerna Kumar said the detainees were suspected of appearing in the examination in place of registered candidates.

"Nine persons have been detained on suspicion of impersonating NEET-UG candidates during the examination. An FIR may be registered after written complaints are received from the centre superintendents concerned," Kumar said. Police were also questioning 10 to 12 other persons allegedly linked to the racket, including biometric operators and middlemen, she said.

The SP did not immediately share details of those detained, adding that further information would emerge after preliminary questioning was completed. The NEET-UG re-examination was conducted across Bihar under tight security arrangements.

Jan Suraaj seeks justice in Bhojpur encounter case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Patna

Founder of Jan Suraaj Party Prashant Kishor

Jan Suraaj Party on Sunday held a candlelight march in Patna, demanding "justice" for the man who was killed in a police encounter in Bihar's Bhojpur district.

Bharat Bhushan Tiwari, a resident of Bilauti village in the Shahpur police station area of the district, was killed in an encounter with police on Wednesday.

"The manner in which the social worker was killed in a so-called encounter is tragic and condemnable. We are holding this candlelight march to demand justice for the victim," the party's state president, Manoj Bharti, told reporters.

He claimed that Tiwari had long raised public issues and fought for people's rights.

"We seek a swift judicial inquiry into the matter alongside suspension of all officials involved in the killing until the investigation is completed. We also demand a Government job for a member of the victim's family and compensation of Rs 1 crore," Bharti said.

The Bihar Government on Saturday announced a judicial inquiry into the recent police encounter in Bhojpur district in which Bharat Bhushan Tiwari was killed.

The Bihar Police has suspended four policemen, including the Station House Officer (SHO), in connection with the incident.

Former MLA and Jan Suraaj leader Kishore Kumar Munna accused police of acting "impartially" and said that "a fair investigation at an earlier stage might have prevented Tiwari's death..

Describing the suspension of SHO as "inadequate", Munna asked for lodging a murder case against senior district police officials.

He alleged that incidents of fake encounters had increased in the state since the formation of the new Government under Samrat Choudhary.

Karnataka plans India's first AI-powered mega city

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Bengaluru

Representative image

Karnataka is moving ahead with one of its most ambitious urban development initiatives as Chief Minister DK Shivakumar pushes forward the proposed Greater Bengaluru Integrated Township at Bidadi, a project envisioned to reshape the State's economic and urban landscape while reducing pressure on Bengaluru's overstretched infrastructure.

Planned across nearly 7,500 to 9,600 acres in nine villages of Ramanagara district, around 30 to 40 kilometres southwest of Bengaluru, the township is being designed as India's first AI-powered integrated city. The project aims to create a modern "work-live-play" ecosystem that combines residential, commercial, industrial and innovation-driven spaces within a self-sustaining urban framework.

Officials estimate that the development could attract investments exceeding Rs 20,000 crore and generate lakhs of direct and indirect employment opportunities across sectors, including artificial intelligence, advanced manufacturing, technology services and logistics. More than 2,000 acres have been earmarked for AI and innovation hubs, while around 1,800 acres are proposed for residential development. Commercial districts, industrial clusters and supporting infrastructure will further strengthen Bidadi's role as an emerging economic centre.

Sustainability remains a central pillar of the project. Nearly 950 acres have been reserved for green buffers and environmental conservation. Plans also include the rejuvenation of water bodies such as Byramangala Lake, alongside advanced water-management systems aimed at ensuring long-term water security. A proposed 40-kilometre transport network connecting key roads and rail corridors is expected to significantly improve regional connectivity.

The initiative comes at a crucial time for Bengaluru, which continues to grapple with rapid urbanisation. With the city's population estimated at nearly 15 million, mounting challenges such as traffic congestion, housing shortages, water stress, and increasing pressure on civic infrastructure have underscored the need for satellite growth centres. The Bidadi township is expected to emerge as a major economic hub along the Bengaluru-Mysuru corridor, helping decentralise commercial activity and create employment opportunities beyond the city's core. Government officials have also highlighted plans for skill development programmes and local employment initiatives to ensure surrounding rural communities benefit directly from the project.

Chief Minister Shivakumar has described the township as the continuation of a long-standing development vision rather than a new political initiative. He has repeatedly noted that the concept dates back to 2006 and has evolved through multiple administrations. In public statements, he has acknowledged the role of former Chief Minister HD Kumaraswamy in conceptualising the project and reaffirmed his government's commitment to implementing it through established legal and administrative processes. To facilitate land acquisition, the Government has introduced an enhanced compensation and rehabilitation package. Compensation has reportedly been increased to as much as Rs 2.55 crore per acre, among the highest offered in Karnataka. Landowners are also being given options to receive developed residential or commercial plots, along with additional incentives and financial assistance during the transition period.

While concerns have been raised by some farmers and environmental groups regarding land acquisition and ecological impact, the Government has responded with assurances on rehabilitation, compensatory afforestation and stakeholder consultations.

As planning moves into implementation, the Bidadi Integrated Township is emerging as a defining project of the Shivakumar Government's development agenda. Supporters believe that if executed successfully, it could position Karnataka as a national leader in artificial intelligence, sustainable urbanisation and advanced manufacturing, while creating lasting opportunities for both urban and rural communities.

Five more jails in J&K to get CISF security cover

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Union Government is set to deploy CISF security personnel to secure five more prisons of Jammu and Kashmir after the two central jails in Jammu and Srinagar.

A force spokesperson said on Sunday that "plans are under consideration" for extending the security cover of the paramilitary to the high security prison at Mahanpur (Kathua) and district jails of Jammu, Anantnag, Kupwara and Baramulla.

The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) was inducted to provide armed security to the Central Jails in Srinagar and Jammu (Kot Bhalwal) at Jammu in October 2023.

The force is responsible for securing both the inner and outer perimeters of these sensitive facilities through a combination of trained manpower, modern surveillance systems, and strict access control measures, the spokesperson said.

In order to check crimes in these two prisons, including smuggling of narcotics, the CISF has deployed non-linear junction detectors (NLJD), capable of detecting concealed electronic circuits, dual-view x-ray baggage inspection systems (X-BIS) and hand-held metal detectors (HHMDs) at all access points.

States Focus

YOGA SESSIONS HELD AT HUMAYUN TOMB, ASI SITES

From the world-famous Humayun Tomb in New Delhi to the iconic Warangal Fort in Telangana, yoga sessions were hosted on the premises of several ASI sites across the country to mark the International Day of Yoga. In Delhi, Union Culture Secretary Vivek Aggarwal attended a session held at the Purana Quila, where he was joined by the director general of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), Yadubir Singh Rawat, and other senior officials. This year marks the 12th International Day of Yoga (IDY) with the theme 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing', which emphasises the importance of yoga for all ages.On the occasion, the ASI organised yoga day celebrations across ASI-protected monuments nationwide under the theme 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing', the ASI said in a post on social media. (*PTI*)

DIPLOMATS JOIN JAISHANKAR FOR YOGA SESSION

Several members of the diplomatic corps in Delhi on Sunday took part in a yoga session along with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar to mark the International Day of Yoga. Besides, the Australian High Commission and French Embassy here released special videos to mark the occasion. This year marks the 12th International Day of Yoga (IDY) with the theme 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing', which emphasises the importance of yoga for all ages. "Joined the Diplomatic Corps at New Delhi to celebrate the #InternationalDayofYoga. As PM @narendramodi highlighted, we must strive to make yoga a part of our lives, part of our families, and a part of our coming generations. #YogaForHealthyAgeing," Jaishankar posted on social media. Prime Minister Narendra Modi led the nation in celebrating IDY and took part in a mega yoga session held in the streets of Kolkata. The video by the Australian High Commission was shared on social media on Sunday by the country's envoy Philip Green. " From New Delhi to Chennai, Mumbai to Kolkata & Bengaluru – Team Australia in India is moving together! Watch our teams across India unite for a powerful #International YogaDay celebration. Yoga truly connects us all across borders and cultures, Australia India," he posted. (*PTI*)

Yoga is India's gift to the world: President

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Jabalpur (MP)

President Droupadi Murmu on Sunday said that yoga is an invaluable gift of India's cultural heritage to the world, playing a vital role in guiding humanity towards peace and harmony amid multiple global challenges.

She led International Yoga Day celebrations, performing exercises along with Madhya Pradesh Governor Mangubhai Patel, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and thousands of participants at a State-level event in Jabalpur.

The mass yoga session, organised at the Garrison Ground, conveyed a message of making yoga an integral part of life and adopting a healthy, balanced lifestyle.

Programmes to mark the 12th International Yoga Day also took place in other cities of Madhya Pradesh, drawing enthusiastic participation from public representatives and citizens.

Dressed in a white salwar-kurta, Murmu performed various yoga asanas on a blue mat. Yadav and Patel also participated in the session. Addressing the gathering, Murmu said, "Today, we are celebrating India's great tradition that has shown humanity the path to a healthy, balanced and meaningful life. Yoga is an invaluable gift of our cultural heritage to the global community. It is the result of thousands of years of penance by our sages and seers."

She said scriptures regarded the balance of body, mind and soul as the basis of success in life and yoga provided the means to establish that balance.

"The literal meaning of the word yoga is to unite. It is a powerful medium that connects individuals with themselves, society with nature

and humanity with the larger universal consciousness," she said. Murmu said yoga was playing an important role in guiding humanity towards peace, balance, harmony and social welfare at a time when the world faced multiple challenges. Yoga has emerged as a powerful medium for global welfare over the past 12 years, and crores of people across many countries have adopted it as part of their daily lives, she noted.

Referring to this year's International Yoga Day theme focusing on healthy ageing, Murmu said yoga helps people remain active and self-reliant as they advance in age while also providing mental peace and emotional balance.

She urged people to resolve to make yoga an integral part of their daily lives.

Governor Patel said yoga was not merely a means to keep the body healthy but a way to make life balanced, simple and joyful.

He said the path to healthy living shown by India's knowledge tradition is now being embraced across the world. "Just 20 to 30 minutes of yoga, meditation and pranayama every day is the simplest way to bring effective and positive changes in our lives," he said.

CM Yadav said yoga not only strengthens physical and mental health but also promotes global welfare, peace and harmony.

"It is a matter of good fortune for us that we are celebrating the 12th International Yoga Day alongside the completion of 12 successful years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership," he said.

Yadav said India has always worked to unite the world through its knowledge, culture and wisdom.

"Prime Minister Modi has given yoga global recognition and introduced the international community to India's rich cultural heritage, ancient traditions and philosophy of life. He has also conveyed a global message of healthy, balanced and positive living for humanity," he said.

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan participated in a yoga programme in the state capital, Bhopal.

"Yoga connects the body with the mind, the mind with intellect, intellect with the soul and the soul with the Supreme Being. When we connect with the Supreme Being, we realise that we are all part of the same consciousness," Chouhan said.

A large number of people also participated in yoga sessions at TT Nagar Stadium in Bhopal, while thousands of participants in Indore performed 'Bhramari Pranayama' continuously for over 3 minutes.

Yoga energises mind, body and soul, says Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Ahmedabad

Yoga is India's invaluable gift to humankind, nourishing holistic well-being, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Sunday as he performed exercises at an event to mark the International Day of Yoga in Ahmedabad. Speaking to the audience, Shah said that he was highly diabetic and after bringing discipline in lifestyle from May 2020, he is not using any allopathic medicine or insulin. He advised the young generation to take enough rest and bring discipline to life.

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel participated in the state-level yoga event at Mansa town in Gandhinagar district.

"Yoga is India's invaluable gift to humankind, which nourishes holistic well-being through energising mind, body and soul.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah during a yoga session on the occasion of the International Day of Yoga in Ahmedabad PTI

Joined millions across the world in Yoga Day celebration by participating in a public yoga session in Ahmedabad," Shah said in a post on X.

Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi also attended the programme in Ahmedabad. CM Patel said this year's theme is Yoga for Healthy Ageing, which gives the message that people can remain healthy through yoga. Several enthusiasts performed aqua yoga (yoga in the water) in Vadodara. The Yoga Day events were held at nearly 330 places in Gujarat.

Yoga teaches dialogue and self-restraint: Om Birla

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Sunday led a yoga session with Members of Parliament in the Parliament House Complex on the occasion of International Day of Yoga. Extending his greetings to everyone, he said that this day celebrates India's timeless civilizational heritage, which has provided humanity with a path to health, balance, and inner peace. He stated, "Yoga not only balances the body but also the mind and thoughts. Differences of opinion are natural in Parliament, but yoga shows us the path of dialogue and self-restraint."

Highlighting the importance of yoga, Birla said that India's sages and scholars worked for centuries to preserve the tradition of yoga and established it as a way of life. Its purpose was to promote physical health,

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla leads yoga session with Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairperson Harivansh Narayan Singh, MP Ravi Shankar Prasad in Parliament House Complex on International Day of Yoga PTI

mental peace, and the awakening of human consciousness. He noted that yoga has now become a global mass movement embraced around the world, but it remains a gift from India's thousands-year-old knowledge tradition.

Emphasising the relevance of yoga in contemporary life, the Lok Sabha Speaker said that modern life is surrounded by stress, imbalance, and uncertainty. In such times, yoga serves as an effective means of maintaining mental peace, patience, emotional balance, and a disciplined lifestyle. He added that one of the greatest challenges of the 21st century is mental stress, and yoga offers an accessible, scientific, and inclusive solution.

He further remarked that today's digital generation must make yoga a part of their lifestyle to balance screen time and stress.

Yoga helps us move from good to great, says VP Radhakrishnan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Leh

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Sunday participated in the International Day of Yoga celebrations in Leh, joining hundreds of yoga enthusiasts at Astro Turf Stadium in Spituk.

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor VK Saxena, Ladakh MP Haneefa Jan and chief executive councillor of the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council (LAHDC), Kargil, Mohd Jaffer Akhoon, also participated along with senior civil and military officers, students, and members of the public at the

Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan along with Ladakh LG Vinai Kumar Saxena performing yoga at Spituk Stadium in Leh, Ladakh PTI

event, officials said. The celebrations featured a mass yoga session, with participants performing various 'asanas' against the scenic backdrop of the Himalayan mountains.

Armed forces mark Yoga Day from Siachen to the seas

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

From the icy heights of Siachen Glacier to the vast Rann of Kutch, and from the hills of the northeast to naval platforms at sea, the armed forces observed the International Day of Yoga across the country, reaffirming their commitment to physical fitness and mental resilience.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh led the celebrations in Shillong, as he, accompanied by IAF Chief Air Chief Marshal AP Singh and other air warriors, took part in a yoga session hosted by the Eastern Air Command.

"Celebrating the International Yoga Day at

Eastern Air Command in Shillong. I urge everyone to make Yoga an integral part of their lives," he said in a post on social media and also shared a video of the session. Chief of Defence Staff Gen NS Raja Subramani led the Yoga Day celebrations organised by Headquarters Integrated Defence Staff at the National War Memorial in Delhi. Meanwhile, Army Chief Gen Upendra Dwivedi fronted the celebrations with troops in Tezpur, Assam.

"His participation alongside soldiers in the Eastern theatre symbolised the Army's continued emphasis on fitness, resilience and operational readiness in all terrains and conditions," a senior official said.

This year marks the 12th International Day of Yoga (IDY) with the theme 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing', which emphasises the importance of yoga for all ages.

"From the icy heights of Siachen Glacier to the southern tip at Kanyakumari; from the land of the rising sun in the northeast to the vast expanse of the Rann of Kutch, soldiers performed yoga in diverse and challenging terrains, reaffirming their commitment to physical fitness, mental well-being and holistic health," the Army said in a post on social media. The celebrations reflected the Indian Army's ethos of discipline, resilience and wellness, while reinforcing yoga's role in promoting a healthy lifestyle and enhancing operational effectiveness. In the national capital, the Indian Army hosted the event at the Cariappa Parade Ground at Delhi Cantonment.

Army jawans and others, positioned in a huge grid formation, stretched their arms and legs to perform various 'asanas'. Vice Chief of the Army Staff, Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth, participated in the yoga session at the Cariappa Parade Ground with over 3,500 enthusiastic participants, including several personnel and their family members, veterans, women, children, NCC cadets and many civilians, officials said.

Dr P K Mishra, Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, led the officers and staff of PMO, NSCS and Cabinet Secretariat to perform yoga at Seva Teerth on Sunday PTI

Union Minister of Ayush (Ministry of Ayurveda, Yoga and Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, and Homoeopathy) Prataprao Ganpatrao Jadhav PTI

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma along with Union Minister for Finance and Corporate Affairs Nirmala Sitharaman attending International Day of Yoga programme in Guwahati PTI

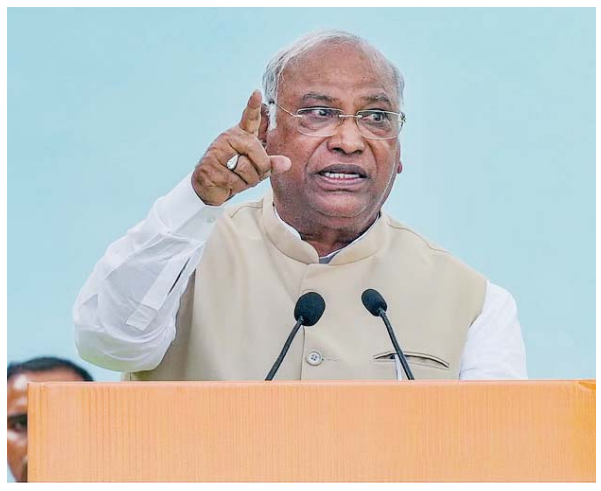
Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw performs yoga during a session on the International Day of Yoga, in Bikaner, Rajasthan on Sunday PTI

CJI Surya Kant performs yoga on the occasion of the 12th International Day of Yoga in the SC premises in New Delhi on Sunday PTI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh participates in the International Day of Yoga celebrations at the Eastern Air Command in Shillong, Meghalaya PTI

Kharge alleges Ram temple loot; slams PM Modi, Trump

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru



Targeting the BJP over allegations of embezzlement of funds linked to the Ram Temple trust in Ayodhya, AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday claimed there was "loot" in the name of religion.

Kharge attacked the Modi Government over the conduct of the NEET examination, accusing it of "betraying" students and parents, and demanded the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Taking a dig at Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump, he claimed the two leaders, who call themselves "good friends," were destroying their respective domains-one, the country, the other the world.

He was addressing a mega convention here where BK Hariprasad assumed charge as Karnataka Congress president.

"Modi is destroying the country. Trump is destroying the whole world. Both of them call themselves good friends. Both good friends, you are bringing a bad name to the country, and people are suffering because of both of you," Kharge claimed.

Blaming Trump for rising fuel prices, he claimed, "India followed a policy of non-alignment since Nehru's time and maintained good relations with all countries. But that policy has been abandoned, and Modi, by going around calling everyone his friend and hugging them, has brought us to this situation."

"We (Congress workers) should keep in mind which Government will be beneficial for the country and its people. We should inform people about it. Go to the people and make them understand what is happening," he said, calling on Congress workers to strengthen the party without compromising its core values and ideology.

Noting that donations and materials were collected for the construction of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya following LK Advani's Rath Yatra, Kharge alleged that no proper account had been given of those collections and claimed there were now reports of financial irregularities linked to the temple.

"There are reports that about ₹5,000 crore has been misused. The priests are robbing the money. *Ram naam japna, paraya maal apna* (chant the name of Ram and make someone else's property your own). A loot has happened in the name of Ram. The temple was constructed to loot crores of rupees," he alleged.

Pointing out that the Ram Mandir was inaugurated by Prime Minister Modi, Kharge said that temples are usually inaugurated by swamijis and seers, but in this case, the PM had inaugurated it himself.

"The money from the donation boxes of temples is going somewhere. Whether his own people are behind it or someone else, it should be

Nagaland shifts Yoga Day observance to June 22 following objections

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

Representative image

The Nagaland Government has deferred the official programme to mark International Day of Yoga to Monday in the face of strong opposition from student bodies, tribal organisations, church and political bodies over holding the event on a Sunday in the Christian-majority State.

The School Education Department issued a revised order, directing the Directorate of School Education to postpone the observance of the day in all institutions to June 22.

The decision came after widespread objections to an earlier directive that had instructed both Government and private schools to organise Yoga Day programmes on June 21, ensure participation of students and staff, and submit reports along with GPS-tagged photographs.

The Naga Students' Federation (NSF) had described the previous directive as insensitive to the religious sentiments of Nagaland's predominantly Christian population.

The federation argued that Sunday is a sacred day of worship and that compelling schools to organise yoga programmes amounted to disregarding the constitutional rights and beliefs of the people.

The Central Nagaland Tribes Council had stated that educational institutions should not be compelled to participate in programmes perceived to have religious or cultural connotations inconsistent with the faith of the majority community.

The Nagaland Congress and several other organisations had similarly demanded the withdrawal of the original circular.

Church bodies also opposed the Government's earlier directive.

The Nagaland Baptist Pastors' Union (NBPU) maintained that yoga is rooted in religious and philosophical traditions incompatible with Christian beliefs and called upon churches and educational institutions to refrain from participating in the observance.

Despite the deferment of the official observance, some Central Government institutions, security forces and other organisations did conduct Yoga Day programmes independently as part of the nationwide celebrations.

7 Naxals held in Jharkhand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Khunti (Jharkhand)

Seven Naxals, including an area commander of the banned outfit PLFI, were arrested in Jharkhand's Khunti district on Sunday, police said.

People's Liberation Front of India (PLFI) area commander Shravan Das was injured in a gunfight with the police when he allegedly snatched a firearm and opened fire on the law enforcers in a forest, where he had led them on the pretext of unearthing a hidden cache of arms and ammunition. He was subsequently taken to RIMS, Ranchi for treatment.

The gunfight took place in Tilmi forest in Jariyagarh police station area early this morning.

Acting on a tip-off, Das and his associates were nabbed in Jariyagarh area on Saturday night and two firearms were seized from their possession, a senior officer said.

YSRCP flags irregularities in SIR implementation in Andhra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

A BLO interacts with a voter as he checks and collects filled enumeration forms for the SIR of electoral rolls PTI

The YSRCP has alleged that certain issues, irregularities and practical difficulties are plaguing the implementation of the SIR of the electoral roll in Andhra Pradesh, and requested the ECI to immediately take corrective measures.

In a letter addressed to the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), YSRCP MLC and State General Secretary L Appireddy raised several issues, such as Booth Level Officers (BLOs) being interrupted, lack of adequate public awareness and others.

"I respectfully submit this representation bringing to your (CEO) kind notice certain serious issues, irregularities and practical difficulties being faced in the implementation of the ongoing SIR in Andhra Pradesh, which require immediate corrective measures in the interest of free, fair and transparent electoral roll revision," he said.

According to Appireddy, BLOs, who are assigned to SIR work, are also burdened with their regular departmental duties.

While carrying out SIR work, BLOs are frequently being summoned by their respective departmental superiors to attend routine official work, affecting the SIR process and causing its delay, the YSRCP leader said.

Consequently, he called for necessary instructions to all departments to ensure that BLOs are allowed to devote adequate time exclusively to SIR activities during the revision period.

Though Enumeration Forms (EFs) are being distributed by BLOs in their respective areas, the MLC noted that in many places they are "not being properly collected, verified and filed."

Hence, he said it is causing confusion regarding the status of applications.

Claiming that public awareness of SIR is inadequate, Appireddy said many electors are not aware of the purpose, procedure and timelines of the exercise.

Therefore, extensive awareness campaigns through mike announcements, local publicity and other communication methods may kindly be undertaken by the poll body, he noted.

ED summons ex-Kerala CM's daughter again in money laundering case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

Vijayan's daughter Veena T

The ED has issued a fresh notice to former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan's daughter Veena T, asking her to appear for questioning on June 29 in a money laundering case linked to mining company CMRL and her now-defunct IT firm, sources said on Sunday.

This will be the second round of questioning of Veena by the central agency in the case.

She was questioned for over nine hours at the Enforcement Directorate (ED) Kochi office on June 17 in connection with the case registered under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

On June 19, ED officials inspected Veena's bank lockers in Thiruvananthapuram as part of the ongoing probe.

According to ED sources, further questioning was deemed necessary after analysing Veena's statement and the evidence collected during the investigation. A fresh notice was subsequently issued directing her to appear before the agency on June 29. Sources said statements of four other accused persons have also been recorded so far. The ED probe pertains to allegations that Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) made payments totalling `2.78 crore to Exalogic Solutions Pvt Ltd, owned by Veena, without receiving any services in return. According to the agency, another company, Empower India Capital Investments Private Limited, operated by CMRL Managing Director Sasidharan Kartha, had extended loans worth `50 lakh to Exalogic despite the firm allegedly failing to repay them on time.

The ED has alleged that Veena and the management of CMRL generated "proceeds of crime" through these transactions.

The agency registered the case under the PMLA based on a prosecution complaint filed by the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) before a court in Ernakulam in April 2025.

The SFIO, the investigation arm of the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, had accused Exalogic and CMRL of entering into an arrangement under which payments were allegedly made without any corresponding services being rendered.

TMC MP Abhishek's aide Sumit Roy booked in fraud, forgery case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Abhishek Banerjee's close aide Sumit Roy

A close aide of Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee has been booked in a case of fraud and forgery in West Bengal's Paschim Medinipur district, a police officer said on Sunday.

The accused, Sumit Roy, was recently booked in a land-grab case, and the West Bengal Police has issued a lookout notice against him. Police had conducted a search operation at Banerjee's residence in Kolkata to locate Roy. On Sunday, a police officer said a case of fraud and forgery has been registered against Roy at the Debra police station in West Bengal's Paschim Medinipur district. The complainant accused Roy, who has been absconding for quite some time, of cheating and forgery, he said, adding that the arrested former Medinipur MLA Sujoy Hazra has also been named in the case.

A senior CID official said the allegations mentioned in the complaint are being examined, and the agency would extend all necessary assistance to the local police, if required. "We are looking into the contents of the complaint and collecting all relevant documents. Every allegation will be verified based on evidence, and appropriate legal action will follow," the official said.

The officer in Paschim Medinipur district added that investigators would question all individuals named in the complaint and ascertain their roles, if any, in the alleged offences. He, however, declined to divulge further details. Hazra was recently arrested by the Shalboni police in connection with another case.

Conrad seeks Rajnath's help for airport expansion in Meghalaya

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shillong

Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K Sangma on Sunday said he sought Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's intervention for expediting key infrastructure projects in the State, including Shillong Airport expansion and strategic road connectivity along the India-Bangladesh border.

Sangma said several projects require the cooperation of the armed forces.

"We have requested the defence minister to help the State Government achieve these goals," he told reporters, following an International Yoga Day event at the Advanced Landing Ground in Upper Shillong.

Sangma said the State was receiving "full support" from the Defence Ministry for the expansion of Shillong Airport and the defence minister had also backed the proposed four-laning of the Rilbong-Barik Point stretch in the city.

The chief minister said he also raised the issue of improving connectivity between Ranikor in South West Khasi Hills district and Ratacherra in East Jaintia Hills district, describing it as a critical missing link close to the India-Bangladesh border with strategic significance.

"We share a very long and important border with Bangladesh. The road connectivity from Ranikor to Dalu has already been established," he said.

Sangma said the corridor would ultimately connect through National Highway 217 and National Highway 127B to the Phulbari-Dhubri Bridge, creating an important route towards Silchar.

"There is a gap in the Ratecherra-Ranikor stretch, and we have requested the Defence Ministry that this be declared a strategic road not just for economic or civilian purposes but also for ensuring the security of the nation," he said.

Sangma said Rajnath Singh had responded positively to the proposal.

Goa Govt notifies 1.13 crore sqm land as no-development zone

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant

The Goa Government has issued a notification declaring nearly 1.13 crore square metres of eco-sensitive land across the coastal State as a no-development zone, officials said on Sunday.

The move aims to safeguard Goa's ecological assets and prevent indiscriminate development in environmentally fragile areas, they said.

In the past also, large tracts of land in the state had been declared no-development zones.

The latest notification was issued on June 18 following the decision taken by the State Town and Country Planning Board, chaired by Minister Vishwajit Rane.

According to the notification, several environmentally significant areas, including paddy fields, khazan lands, mangroves, water bodies, rivers and nallas, fish farms, orchards, salt pans, sand dunes, and natural cover areas, have been recommended as non-developable zones.

Assam Rifles, DRI seize poppy seeds worth ₹1.31 cr

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In a major breakthrough against trans-border smuggling and drug trafficking, the Assam Rifles, in a joint operation with the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), seized a massive consignment of poppy seeds valued at ₹1.31 crore in Assam's Cachar district.

Acting on specific intelligence inputs regarding the movement of contraband, the joint team intercepted a Tata truck on the Silchar Bypass Road late on Saturday evening.

Upon searching the vehicle, security personnel recovered 8,764 kg of high-grade poppy seeds smuggled into the region. Two residents of Silchar have been apprehended in connection with the seizure. The security forces also confiscated the truck and two mobile handsets from their possession.

"The operation is a significant milestone in our ongoing efforts to combat contraband trafficking in the Northeast. Assam Rifles and the DRI remain committed to disrupting and dismantling these illicit networks," the release said.

The apprehended individuals, along with the seized poppy seeds and vehicle, have been handed over to the DRI for further investigation and legal proceedings to trace the forward and backward linkages of the smuggling network.

PMK opposes new tribunal on Mekedatu, urges TN Govt to withdraw proposal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss on Sunday strongly opposed the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly's resolution seeking a tribunal to resolve the Mekedatu dam issue, warning that such a move would compromise the state's established legal rights and favour Karnataka.

Terming the proposal "unnecessary and counter-productive," the PMK leader, in a statement, urged Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay to remove the clause demanding a new tribunal from the House resolution before forwarding it to the Union Government.

"Farmers' organisations opposed the demand for a separate tribunal in the Government resolution passed by the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly to resolve the crisis arising from Karnataka's attempts to build the Mekedatu dam across the Cauvery river", he said.

"When justice clearly sides with Tamil Nadu on the Mekedatu issue, seeking central mediation through a new tribunal instead of asserting our existing rights amounts to mortgaging our own State's interests," he added. The PMK leader also pointed out that both the Cauvery Tribunal and the Supreme Court have clearly ruled that the upper-riparian states must obtain the explicit consent from the lower-riparian state (Tamil Nadu) before executing any new constructions.

"Given this clear legal edge, the Tamil Nadu Government demanding a new tribunal will only invite unnecessary complications, but it is equivalent to needlessly putting our own head into a crocodile's mouth", he alleged.

Claiming that Tamil Nadu's rights on the Mekedatu issue can only be safeguarded through sustained legal battles and political pressure, Anbumani said, "All political parties, including the PMK, stand firmly behind the Tamil Nadu Government's efforts in this regard". "In such a scenario, we must ensure that we do not hand an advantage to Karnataka by demanding a tribunal", he said, adding, "Therefore, the portions demanding a new tribunal must be removed from the passed resolution using appropriate Assembly rules before it is dispatched to the Union Government".

Editor's TAKE

Yoga Day and the Rise of a Vishwa Guru

International Yoga Day once again underscored that India's greatest export is its ancient wisdom — a gift that resonates deeply in a chaotic world

Yoga, India's ancient art of living is now its most prestigious and recognised export to the world. Long before the yoga studios in New York came up and holistic wellness became a buzz word, yoga had established its immense potential for spiritual mental and physical health. However, after it was after UN annouced JUne 21 as yoga day, it has become a rage.

From the United Nations plaza in New York to the beaches of Sydney, from Red Square in Moscow to the deserts of the UAE, people of every nationality, faith, and political persuasion lower themselves onto a mat and breathe together. International Yoga Day, observed since 2015 after India's proposal won near-unanimous backing at the UN General Assembly, has quietly become one of the most successful unifier the modern world has seen.

This is not power exercised through coercion or capital. It is power exercised through resonance. Yoga asks nothing of its practitioner except presence – no conversion, no allegiance, no ideology. That neutrality is precisely what makes it such an effective ambassador for India. While geopolitics increasingly fractures along lines of sanctions, tariffs, and military alliances, yoga offers something rarer: a shared vocabulary of stillness that transcends borders.

Herein lies India's opportunity – and its responsibility. The term Vishwa Guru – world teacher, is often invoked with nationalist pride, but its real meaning is more modest and more profound: a civilization that has metabolised suffering into wisdom, and is willing to share that wisdom freely. India's contribution to the world need not be military bases or extractive trade. It can be mentorship – in the literal sense of helping other nations and peoples find equilibrium amid chaos. Consider the moment we are in.

Conflicts simmer or rage across Eastern Europe, the Middle East, and parts of Africa. Anxiety, displacement, and mistrust rule the world. Diplomacy alone, built on negotiation and deterrence, struggles to address this deeper exhaustion.

This is where India's spiritual inheritance – yoga, meditation, the contemplative traditions of the Upanishads and Buddhism – can do work that treaties cannot. They do not resolve conflicts, but they can heal the people who must live through and after them.This is also where India must be careful not to squander its advantage. Soft power is fragile; it dies the moment it starts to feel like propaganda or commercial branding. If India wants to be taken seriously as a Vishwa Guru rather than merely the original supplier of a global wellness industry, it must invest in scholarship, accessible teaching, and authentic cultural exchange – not just spectacle. The opportunity is real.

No other nation possesses a living, continuous tradition of contemplative practice with this much global goodwill. If India can pair its ancient inheritance with humility, openness, and genuine intellectual rigor, it will not need to declare itself a Vishwa Guru. The world, mat by mat, breath by breath, will simply start calling it one.

Europe's Two 'Queens' at War

Israel's decision to sever ties with EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas has exposed a deepening battle at the heart of the European Union– an escalating rivalry between Kallas and Ursula von der Leyen over who should steer Europe's foreign policy in an increasingly volatile world. It is a contest between competing visions of European power

NILANTHA ILANGAMUWA

When Israel announced last Thursday that it was cutting "all contact" with Estonia-born EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas after accusing her of comparing Israel's treatment of Palestinians with apartheid-era South Africa, the fallout created an immediate political crisis in Brussels. The obvious casualty was Kallas, the European Union's High Representative for Foreign Affairs. But inside the EU's power structure, some may have viewed the decision with quiet satisfaction. For Ursula von der Leyen, the powerful president of the European Commission and Kallas's institutional superior, the controversy arrived at the height of their growing rivalry over who controls Europe's foreign policy. A weakened Kallas would strengthen von der Leyen's position in a battle that increasingly resembles a Cold War inside the EU itself.

This is not simply a clash between two ambitious women. It is a fight over what kind of power Europe wants to become. One side believes the European Union needs stronger central institutions, tighter coordination and a Commission powerful enough to act like a government. The other believes Europe's influence depends on a strong diplomatic voice, clearer foreign policy and a tougher response to threats such as Russia. The rivalry between Kallas and von der Leyen is the latest battle in Europe's unresolved argument over whether the EU should move towards something closer to a United States of Europe or remain a union of independent states. The irony is that both women want a stronger Europe. They simply disagree over who should control that strength.

Kallas entered Brussels in December 2024 with a reputation shaped by Estonia's history, a country whose modern identity has been defined by Soviet occupation and fears of Russian expansion. As Estonian prime minister, she became one of Europe's most outspoken critics of Moscow and one of Ukraine's strongest supporters. Her critics argue that she has continued to act like a national leader rather than an EU official whose role requires balancing the interests of 27 governments. Her supporters argue that this is exactly what Europe needs, a clear voice at a time when Russia, China and geopolitical competition are becoming more aggressive.

Her ally Marko Mihkelson, chairman of Estonia's parliament foreign affairs committee, captured this argument when he described representing EU foreign policy as almost "Mission Impossible". His point was not that Kallas was without faults, but that the role itself is designed to create weakness. The High Representative is expected to speak for Europe abroad, yet real foreign policy decisions remain controlled by member states. One government can block action. The diplomat speaks, but national capitals decide. That contradiction sits at the centre of the dispute with von der Leyen. The European Union created the High Representative role after the Lisbon Treaty to give Europe a stronger international voice. But instead of creating a genuine foreign minister, it created a position caught between institutions. The High Representative serves as a vice-president of the European Commission while also leading the European External Action Service, the EU's diplomatic body. The title suggests power. The reality is limited authority.

> HISTORY SHOWS THAT CONFLICTS BETWEEN POWERFUL WOMEN OFTEN EMERGE WHEN INSTITUTIONS CREATE COMPETING CENTRES OF AUTHORITY. THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN MARGARET THATCHER AND QUEEN ELIZABETH II REMAINS ONE OF THE MOST DISCUSSED EXAMPLES

The result is predictable. Every major international crisis becomes a struggle over who leads.

The Commission under von der Leyen has steadily moved into areas once controlled mainly by traditional diplomacy. Russia's invasion of Ukraine changed the nature of European foreign policy. Sanctions, defence production, energy security and industrial strategy became tools of geopolitical competition. China's economic rise turned trade into a strategic weapon. The Commission argues that modern power is not just about diplomats and statements. It is about economic strength, technology and industrial capacity. Kallas's supporters see this differently. They argue that von der Leyen's expansion of Commission power has weakened the very diplomatic structure created to give Europe a single foreign policy voice. In their view, the Commission is gradually taking control of foreign policy without having the same democratic legitimacy or political accountability as national governments.

The dispute over the European External Action Service reflects this deeper struggle. Reports that the EEAS could be weakened or absorbed triggered concern among European diplomats. Kallas warned staff that the institution's role was protected by EU treaties and that its structure remained unchanged. Her allies accused forces inside the EU system of attempting to reduce her influence and shift foreign policy authority towards the Commission. The roots of this conflict go back to the euro crisis, when another powerful woman faced a similar battle over the future of European power.

During the financial crisis, former German Chancellor Angela Merkel rejected the idea that Europe should respond by rapidly transferring more authority to Brussels. She stressed that under the Lisbon Treaty, "the member states are masters of the treaties". The message was clear. Europe should integrate, but national governments must remain in control. It was a direct rejection of the federalist vision supported by figures such as Ursula von der Leyen, who had previously spoken about the idea of a "United States of Europe". Merkel feared that transferring power during a crisis would create public anger and make citizens feel that decisions were being taken by distant institutions they could not control. Merkel and von der Leyen came from the same German conservative tradition, but their instincts were different. Merkel believed Europe advanced through compromise, caution and gradual integration. Von der Leyen believed Europe needed stronger institutions capable of acting quickly when faced with global threats. The Kallas dispute is the latest version of that unresolved disagreement. History shows that conflicts between powerful women often emerge when institutions create competing centres of authority. The relationship between Margaret Thatcher and Queen Elizabeth II remains one of the most discussed examples. Their tension was not simply personal. It reflected a clash between two forms of power. Thatcher represented electoral authority, political change and ideological conviction. A similar pattern appeared in American politics between Hillary Clinton and Nancy Pelosi. They were not direct enemies, but they represented different sources of influence. Pelosi controlled legislative power in Congress, while Clinton represented executive diplomacy and presidential politics. Their rivalry reflected a wider reality. Political systems often create overlapping authority, and those overlaps produce competition. The lesson is simple. Institutional rivalries are rarely caused only by personalities. They emerge when systems allow multiple figures to claim leadership. This is why the Kallas-von der Leyen relationship has become so politically sensitive. Von der Leyen's Commission has increasingly presented itself as Europe's geopolitical centre. Her supporters argue that the old separation between economics and foreign policy no longer exists. A Europe facing Russia, China and uncertainty from Washington needs a stronger institution capable of acting quickly.

Kallas's supporters argue that Europe risks becoming a system where diplomacy serves Commission priorities rather than member states' foreign policy interests. For them, the question is whether the EU will still have an independent foreign policy chief or whether that role will gradually become symbolic. However, this question will be decided by whether Europe's institutions can adapt quickly enough to match a world that has become more competitive and dangerous.

The writer is a columnist based in Colombo

PIC TALK

ITBP personnel perform yoga on the banks of Pangong Tso lake on the occasion of International Yoga Day, in Leh-Ladakh PHOTO: PTI

India's quiet promise of ageing well

GAURAV SHARMA

2ND OPINION

On the morning of 21 June 2026, dawn broke over Kolkata's Red Road, the Hooghly carrying the reflections of five hundred boats, as India marked the twelfth International Day of Yoga with a message both understated and civilisational. What began as a UN resolution has grown into a grassroots movement now visible everywhere from neighbourhood parks to ancient monuments and global landmarks. With the Prime Minister leading the Common Yoga Protocol along Kolkata's riverfront, this year's event reinforced a simple truth: yoga has stopped being a once-a-year spectacle and become woven into ordinary Indian life.

This year's theme, "Yoga for Healthy Ageing," suited a nation that is simultaneously youthful and, in raw numbers, ageing fast. Lifestyle disorders now strike urban professionals in their forties while rural elders silently manage chronic conditions. Yoga answers this with something unglamorous but powerful: a daily practice that slows physical and mental decline. This isn't a fresh discovery repackaged by modern wellness culture - it's a return to insight long held by Indian tradition. Patanjali's Yoga Sutras describe the discipline as quieting the restless mind, and at its core, the day stands as an invitation to find calm amid modern chaos.

Kolkata's selection as host city carried its own resonance. The former capital of British India, home to Bankimchandra's verse and Vivekananda's spiritual conviction, staged a mass gathering that fused colonial-era avenues with a practice millennia old. Broadcast nationwide, the Red Road scenes showed a country comfortable with both its modern identity and ancient roots. Thousands moving through asanas together became more than a fitness display - it read as a democracy learning to breathe as one.

Equally striking was the decision to anchor sessions at heritage sites: a hundred ASI-protected monuments and a dozen landmark locations, from Nalanda to Konark, the Red Fort to Metcalfe Hall. Stone and sculpture became living backdrops for living practice. At a time when many societies struggle to reconcile faith, history, and modern life, India placed yoga mats before Buddhist ruins, in Mughal courtyards, near Chola temples, and along old riverbanks - a reminder that yoga transcends sect and era, a civilisational thread outlasting empires and ideologies alike.

The Bhagavad Gita offers a timeless lens here. As Arjuna hesitates on the battlefield of Kurukshetra, Krishna teaches him the paths of action, knowledge, and devotion - describing yoga essentially as skill and excellence in action. Where Patanjali turns attention inward toward stillness, the Gita turns it outward toward engaged, compassionate living. Healthy ageing, in this light, isn't just supple joints or stable blood pressure - it's ageing with purpose, clarity, and continued duty.

This link between inner discipline and outward responsibility showed up far beyond the cameras. Across towns and neighbourhoods, yoga has become routine: residential societies hosting dawn sessions, offices building wellness breaks into the workday, schools treating it as a life skill rather than an extracurricular. The most touching scenes weren't of officials on a stage but of grandchildren guiding grandparents through gentle stretches, seniors using chairs for support, everyone sharing the same open sky.

That is where this year's theme truly lives. The real test now is simple: will people return tomorrow to that same patch of ground where breath and body meet? If even some do, Red Road's images will endure - not as archived photographs, but as quiet markers on India's path toward ageing not just longer, but wiser.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

PEACE IN WEST ASIA CANNOT REST ON FRAGILE CEASEFIRES

Apropos the report, "Tehran closes Hormuz over Lebanon fighting" (June 21), Iran's decision to once again shut the Strait of Hormuz highlights the precarious nature of peace in West Asia. Barely days after the much-publicised US-Iran peace agreement, the region finds itself caught in another cycle of confrontation, triggered by continuing violence in Lebanon.The Strait of Hormuz is not merely a regional waterway; it is a critical artery of the global energy trade. Any disruption in shipping through this narrow passage can trigger volatility in oil prices, fuel inflationary pressures and unsettle economies across the world. For energy-importing countries such as India, the consequences could be particularly severe.Equally troubling is the humanitarian dimension of the crisis. The loss of civilian lives in Lebanon, including women and children, underscores the devastating impact of prolonged hostilities. Military responses may offer temporary strategic gains, but they seldom produce lasting peace.

The proposed diplomatic talks in Switzerland provide an opportunity to prevent further escalation. However, negotiations can bear fruit only when all stakeholders demonstrate sincerity, honour commitments and refrain from provocative actions. The international community must intensify efforts to restore trust and encourage dialogue. Durable peace demands political wisdom, restraint and a commitment to diplomacy over confrontation.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

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In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Banking accountability must for public trust

The Supreme Court's observations regarding the alleged settlement of a ₹1,537-crore debt for merely ₹73.5 crore have raised important questions about accountability in India's banking sector. While the facts of the case are yet to be fully examined, the concerns expressed by the court go beyond a single transaction and touch upon the larger issue of public confidence in financial institutions. When large loans are settled at steep discounts, it becomes essential to ensure that such decisions are transparent, professionally justified and subject to rigorous scrutiny. Public money cannot be treated casually.

Equally concerning is the perception that some senior bank officials nearing retirement become more focused on securing comfortable postings than on safeguarding institutional interests. This point to the need for stronger accountability mechanisms and performance-based evaluations at higher administrative levels.The banking system functions on public trust. If losses arising from questionable decisions ultimately burden taxpayers and depositors, confidence in the system inevitably suffers. The need of the hour is greater transparency, stronger oversight and a culture where responsibility accompanies authority at every level.

YASH PAL RALHANI | JALANDHAR

Making Yoga a habit, not a remedy

This refers to "Yoga: A lifelong companion on the journey of ageing" (June 20). The article rightly challenges the common misconception that ageing begins only after retirement. In reality, the process starts much earlier, often accelerated by sedentary lifestyles, prolonged screen exposure and diminishing physical activity.Yoga offers a simple yet powerful response to these modern challenges. It is not merely a wellness practice for senior citizens but a lifelong investment in physical and mental health. Regular stretching, mindful breathing and gentle movement help preserve flexibility, improve balance, reduce stress and enhance overall well-being. The benefits accumulate over time, making yoga an effective preventive tool rather than a corrective measure.Public policy should reflect this understanding. Schools should incorporate daily movement and mindfulness sessions, while workplaces must encourage short breaks for stretching and posture correction.

One of yoga's greatest strengths is its accessibility. It requires minimal equipment, can be adapted to all age groups and can be practised almost anywhere. By embracing yoga early and consistently, individuals can transform ageing from a period of decline into a journey marked by vitality, resilience and grace.

VEDA CHIDANAND | BENGALURU

Restoring faith in examinations

Your editorial, "Rebuilding student trust after the paper leak crisis," rightly identifies the central challenge facing India's examination system: the erosion of trust. When the integrity of examinations such as NEET, JEE, or UPSC is compromised, it is not merely an administrative lapse but a betrayal of the aspirations of millions of students. The solutions suggested in the editorial—encrypted digital transmission of question papers, an independent statutory examination authority, and forensic tracking of the paper trail—are timely and necessary. However, additional safeguards could further strengthen accountability. First, a Public Exam Ombudsman should be established to address student grievances within a fixed timeframe and recommend remedies, including re-examinations where necessary. Second, private agencies involved in printing or transporting examination papers must face stringent penalties, including long-term blacklisting and criminal prosecution. Third, anonymised audit reports detailing paper movement and security protocols should be released after examinations to enhance transparency. Today's students are not demanding easier examinations; they are demanding fair ones. Institutions must demonstrate transparency and accountability.

S VAITHIANATHAN | MADURAI

India's food safety crisis: Time for bold, systemic reform

Ensuring that every child receives a safe meal, every consumer gets what the label promises, and every food business is held accountable is not merely a matter of public health; it is essential for restoring trust in the nation's food system and securing its future.

SUBHASH CHANDRA AGRAWAL

India's food supply chain is sending out distress signals that can no longer be ignored. From children falling ill after mid-day school meals to honey samples failing international purity tests, the warning signs point to one conclusion: India needs a structural overhaul of how it produces, certifies, and serves food - not piecemeal fixes.

The Mid-Day Meal Problem

Reports of insects, lizards, frogs, and rodents turning up in school lunches, alongside complaints about poor-quality rice and pulses, have become a recurring and troubling feature of the Mid-Day Meal Scheme. A practical fix worth serious consideration is shifting toward packaged, preferably baked, food for school meals. This would sidestep many hygiene risks tied to on-site cooking and would also accommodate children whose families avoid specific ingredients like onion and garlic for cultural or religious reasons. Notably, a group of Members of Parliament once pushed for exactly this - sourcing packaged biscuits from established manufacturers vetted by the Mumbai-based Biscuit Manufacturers' Welfare Association, to replace freshly cooked meals altogether.

There's also a funding angle here. Large food manufacturers could be incentivised to sponsor the programme in exchange for brand visibility, while corporates could route their mandatory Corporate Social Responsibility spending into supplying packaged meals - a win for children's health and a way to ease the financial burden on the state.

IRCTC: An Underused Asset

The Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation already has the infrastructure and expertise to produce packaged food at scale. Expanding its footprint to every district - including baked goods - could serve two purposes simultaneously: supplying safer meals to both schoolchildren and train passengers (where complaints about freshly cooked food are equally frequent), and creating a public-sector competitor that keeps private food companies honest on quality and pricing.

Such expansion need not strain public finances. Long-term, tax-free bonds could fund the initial buildout, and - in a more ambitious version - these bonds could even be structured to encourage disclosure of undeclared wealth. Beyond food safety, the ripple effect on employment could be significant: district-level IRCTC units would create rural jobs and potentially slow the steady migration of youth toward overcrowded cities.

FSSAI is Moving, But Needs to Go Further

Credit is due to the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India for mandating hygiene-rating displays at eateries. But ratings that focus only on dining-area aesthetics miss the point - kitchens and storage areas, where rodent infestations and unsanitary conditions are most common, deserve equal scrutiny.

FSSAI's move to regulate the repeated frying and reuse of cooking oil - a known health hazard - is similarly welcome. The next logical steps would be mandating RO water purifiers in all eateries, however small, with visible signage confirming installation, and requiring separate kitchen equipment for vegetarian and non-vegetarian food preparation, with that separation clearly displayed for customers who care about it.

The Honey and Sugar Problem

In April 2021, the Supreme Court sought government responses to reports that imported adulterated sugar syrups were being blended into honey - including in well-known brands - in ways that slip past FSSAI's existing tests. A study by the Centre for Science and Environment found that only a handful of dozens of honey samples tested passed the internationally recognised NMR spectroscopy standard. Given that diabetics often consume honey precisely because it's considered a safer sweetener, this is a serious public health concern. FSSAI should adopt NMR spectroscopy as the standard testing protocol before granting sale approvals.

On sugar, India's diabetes burden is staggering - estimates put the number of diabetics in the country at over 100 million, with well over 100 million more in the prediabetic range as of 2025-2026. One way to nudge consumption patterns would be mandating brown sugar for commercial and medicinal use in place of refined white sugar. Market signals already point this way - confectioners in places like Delhi's Chandni Chowk have begun introducing diabetic-friendly sweets - and if demand for brown sugar grows, manufacturers are likely to shift production voluntarily.

> ON THE QUESTION OF DIETARY PREFERENCE, INDIA'S VEGETARIAN CULINARY TRADITION IS INTERNATIONALLY RESPECTED, AND THERE'S A CASE FOR THE GOVERNMENT PROMOTING A "WORLD VEGETARIAN DAY" ON OCTOBER 1ST WITH THE SAME ENTHUSIASM IT HAS SHOWN FOR INTERNATIONAL YOGA DAY

Stopping Dual Pricing and Adulteration

Branded bottled water and soft drink companies routinely charge more for identical products sold in airports, cinemas, and luxury hotels compared to open-market prices. This practice deserves to be curbed, and expanding IRCTC's Rail Neer bottling plants across the country offers a public-sector alternative that could help normalise pricing.

Adulteration of ghee and butter - including the use of cheaper oils and animal fats mislabeled as "pure" - remains widespread, particularly at roadside eateries. The episode involving allegedly adulterated ghee in temple prasad offerings at Tirumala Tirupati was a wake-up call. Manufacturers of desi ghee should be required to register their brand and sourcing details with FSSAI, and that information should be displayed prominently at the point of sale so consumers can make informed choices.

Separately, several states have moved to require food outlets to display the names of operators and staff, mandate masks, gloves, and CCTV installation, following incidents of deliberate food contamination. Encouraging consistent adoption of such basic accountability and surveillance measures across all states - regardless of political alignment - would strengthen consumer trust everywhere.

Cutting Waste, Encouraging Choice

Food wastage at large social gatherings, particularly weddings, is a persistent and visible problem in a country where rising vegetable and grocery prices already strain household budgets. Curbing elaborate buffet spreads at such functions - even restricting service to beverages alone - could meaningfully reduce waste and make these events more affordable for ordinary families.

On the question of dietary preference, India's vegetarian culinary tradition is internationally respected, and there's a case for the government promoting a "World Vegetarian Day" on October 1st with the same enthusiasm it has shown for International Yoga Day. Separately, mandating distinct kitchens and cooking equipment for vegetarian and non-vegetarian food at restaurants - clearly signposted - would let vegetarian customers make informed choices, likely growing that customer base for businesses that adopt it.

Milk, Brands, and Public Pride

Reports of synthetic milk and counterfeit paneer or khoya continue to surface from unregulated production units. In cities where reliable branded alternatives - Amul, Mother Dairy, and regional players like Verka, Saras, Sudha, and Nandini - are already widely available, restricting sales to certified branded milk and milk products would meaningfully reduce health risks.

On a more positive note, Amul's ranking at 15th among the world's 100 most valuable food brands (per the Brand Finance Food and Drink 2021 report), alongside Britannia at 54th, is a genuine point of pride for India's cooperative model. This success deserves further state support - subsidised land, easier approvals - to encourage more Indian companies, public and private, to compete globally. At the same time, it's fair to ask why public-sector giants like IRCTC and Mother Dairy, despite years of public investment, haven't achieved similar global brand recognition - and what structural changes might change that.

Writer is Guinness World Record Holder for writing most letters and RTI Consultant

Viksit Panchayat for Viksit Bharat

ASHOK PANKAJ

India added a third tier of governance by the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992, which, however, fell short of integrating PRIs with the federal structure. While the Union and State Governments derived their powers from the 7th Schedule of the Constitution, viz., the Union, State, and Concurrent Lists, the PRIs derived their powers from an Act of devolution by the State Governments. A simple reading of the Constitution makes it clear. Article 243G provides that "... a state may, by law, endow the Panchayats with such powers and authority...". The use of the word "may" in Article 243G, in contrast to the use of "shall" in Article 243B, that is, for the Constitution of Panchayat, debilitated PRIs from the inception. An amendment in Article 243G would correct this congenital weakness.

On 24 April 2026, PRIs completed three decades of operationalisation, yet the statutory devolution of powers, functions and funds remains profoundly uneven and largely half-hearted across the States. The latest report of the Ministry of Panchayati Raj on devolution to Panchayats in states shows that on the six identified dimensions of devolution, viz. Framework, Functions, Finances, Functionaries, Capacity Enhancement and Accountability, most of the states score poorly. On the one hand, state governments have remained reluctant; on the other hand, and rather unseemingly, the Union Government has provided funds, functions and functionaries. Its various rural development, social welfare and other programmes have helped in strengthening the PRIs. The successive Finance Commissions, especially the 13th, 14th, 15th and 16th, have further strengthened PRIs by providing grants-in-aid, directly from the Consolidated Fund of India, as a share of the divisible pool. Notwithstanding the congenital weakness in the constitution of PRIs, noticeable progress has been achieved in institutionalising them. Some of them can be highlighted.

Firstly, the constitution of the PRIs through democratic elections every 5 years, on the basis of universal adult franchise, has become regular, predictable and irreversible. There are some cases of delays in conducting panchayat elections, often on some technical, administrative and judicial grounds, but inordinate delay is now rare. People go to the court for directions on how to conduct elections.

Secondly, 2.55 lakh GPs, 6600 IPs and 660 ZPs, and about 32 lakhs PRI representatives, including about 50 per cent women, directly elected by the people, make them the world's largest body corpus of elected representatives and network of grassroots democratic institutions.

Thirdly, PRIs have moved beyond elections and have become grounded in many ways. In the past, GPs in many places used to function from the residence of the GP heads. Now almost every GP has its own office. Every GP has a bank account, an independent fund, designated functionaries, and a functioning office. A number of centre-sponsored schemes have made PRIs the nodal agency for planning and implementation. Fourthly, Gram Sabha meetings have become regular. There are fixed dates on which holding of the G.S. meeting is mandatory. Also, some projects need mandatory approval of the Gram Sabha. Though participation level in the Gram Sabha meeting remains low, and sometimes pre-decided projects are placed for formal approval, the holding of the Gram Sabha meeting is itself an important development. In some places, Gram Sabha meetings are lively as well. Most of the GPs now also prepare a GP development plan. Fifthly, GP elections have become highly contested and competitive. Younger generation and qualified professionals like engineers, management graduates, etc. have shown interest in contesting elections. Some of them have won as well. Many of the GP representatives graduate to a higher level of political participation. In a way, GPs are increasingly becoming a nursery of democratic politics.

While these developments are welcome, challenges remain in terms of:

1. Variation in the devolution of the 3Fs across states
2. Heavy dependence of PRIs on FC and state grants
3. Reluctance on the part of PRIs to mobilise their own resources
4. Low level of human resources
5. Stringent administrative control by the State Government

FCs have duly recognised the role and significance of PRIs. The 13th FC made a departure by recommending the share of PRIs in the divisible pool. The 14th FC enhanced allocation; so did the 16th FC, which recommended allocation of Rs. 4,35,236 crore for 2026-27 to 2030-31, 84 per cent higher than the allocation of the 15th FC.

Allocation of resources is important, but not sufficient. PRIs should not be seen merely as a body of local self-government for providing water, sanitation facilities and issuing birth and death certificates. Its role should be visualised beyond that. PRIs are institutions in nation-building, and therefore, their role should be defined in fulfilling the goals of Viksit Bharat. One, while development goals are defined and targets are set at the national and state levels, they are to be achieved at the local level. Further, national and state-level achievements are a summation of the local-level results.

Two, Rural India contributes about half of India's national income and employs 67.68 per cent of the workforce. About 65 per cent of the total population continues to reside in rural areas. PRIs are their first contact with governance. PRIs have the principal responsibility for providing them with basic services, including amenities that are crucial to their well-being. It is also important for enhancing the productivity of rural workers.

Three, the call for environmental action and disaster management is essentially local. PRIs can play a crucial role in these two vital services.

Fourth, a higher level of urbanisation is also associated with a higher level of development. However, urbanisation should be natural and healthy and should not be driven by distress and poor living conditions in rural areas. Five, PRIs can bridge the rural-urban divide in living conditions by providing those facilities essential for good living conditions. Urban areas are increasingly becoming unlivable due to air pollution, water shortage, and traffic congestion. Rural areas can become an attractive destination for housing and living. In the era of the internet and work from home, this is greatly feasible. To conclude, PRIs have completed three decades of operationalisation. Though progress in institutionalisation has been slow, achievement in democratisation has been remarkable. It is high time that the PRIs role should be envisaged beyond conventional responsibilities.

The writer is Professor at Council for Social Development, New Delhi

From rhetoric to statecraft: India's institutional turn on illegal infiltration

SANCHITA BHATTACHARYA

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi, from the ramparts of the Red Fort in August 2025, framed illegal infiltration as a challenge to employment, welfare access and demographic stability, the statement was more than a political declaration. It reflected a broader concern increasingly visible across many nations: how should states respond when vulnerabilities linked to illegal infiltration begin to intersect with questions of governance and internal stability? Yet an even more difficult question lingered, what happens after the rhetoric?

The answer is now beginning to take shape. On May 26, 2026, Union Home Minister Amit Shah announcement of a high-level committee to examine illegal infiltration and what the government describes as "unnatural demographic change" suggests a shift from political messaging to governance architecture.

The concern itself is not entirely new. In September 2024, the Prime Minister had also spoken about the rapid demographic shift in the Santhal Parganas and Kolhan regions of Jharkhand. Significantly, Jharkhand is not a bordering state. Irrespective of the political contestation surrounding the issue, these interventions are analytically significant because they attempt to place a long-debated concern within a more structured administrative framework rather than episodic public discourse.

For decades, India's conversation around infiltration has oscillated between moments of public urgency and periods of administrative reaction. Concerns emerge, particularly in border regions and vulnerable districts where infiltration pressures intersect with fragile governance systems, only to recede without sustained institutional attention. What has often remained missing is a long-term mechanism that treats illegal infiltration not merely as a border challenge but as a larger governance question requiring policy coordination.

It is in this context that Amit Shah's committee deserves closer attention. The significance of the exercise lies less in political rhetoric and more in institutional design. Chaired by former Supreme Court Judge Justice Prakash Prabhakar Navlekar (Retired) and tasked with studying demographic changes at regional and district levels, the committee seeks to replace broad political claims with a structured administrative process. In essence, it seeks to answer a difficult but legitimate question: what are the implications for governance systems, welfare delivery and local administration when demographic changes occur in vulnerable regions?

Such concerns are not unique to India.

Modern states routinely monitor demographic trends because governance depends upon administrative predictability. Public infrastructure, including schools, healthcare systems and employment ecosystems, is planned around demographic assumptions. Sudden shifts, particularly in sensitive or resource-constrained regions, can place unexpected pressure on local institutions if governance mechanisms remain unprepared.

The security dimension cannot be dismissed either. As the Union Home Minister has repeatedly argued, infiltration today is rarely a question of physical entry alone. It intersects with forged documents, identity fraud and weak verification systems, all of which can make administrative loopholes easier to exploit over time. In such situations, what begins as a border management issue can gradually evolve into a broader governance concern with implications for internal stability and institutional credibility.

At the same time, the strength of any democratic response lies in procedural legitimacy. Administrative vigilance must remain evidence-based and legally sound, carefully distinguishing unlawful infiltration from lawful citizenship. This is precisely where the committee-led approach acquires significance. By focusing on district-level assessment, consultation and structured policy recommendations, the government appears to be prioritising process over impulse. It reflects a recognition that durable governance solutions require administrative precision, not merely political urgency.

More broadly, the initiative reflects an evolving understanding of national security itself. Security is no longer confined to fences, patrols and intelligence intercepts. It increasingly resides in administrative capacity, institutional preparedness, databases and the state's ability to anticipate vulnerabilities rather than merely react to them.

Seen through this lens, the committee announced by the Union Home Minister may represent something larger than an intervention on infiltration alone. It may signal an attempt to institutionalise a preventive governance framework, one that seeks to identify vulnerabilities before they mature into larger administrative or social challenges.

For a country as vast and administratively complex as India, governance is often tested not by the intensity of political declarations but by the durability of the institutions that follow them.

If implemented with consistency and legal clarity, the committee may well signal a broader shift in India's governance imagination, from reacting to vulnerabilities after they surface to preparing for them before they deepen into more difficult challenges.

The writer is Research Fellow at Institute for Conflict Management

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Legal rights must turn to dignified support for women: Justice Vikram Nath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Srinagar

Supreme Court Judge, Justice Vikram Nath, on Saturday said legal rights must translate into accessible, coordinated, and dignified institutional support for women.

Justice Nath, who is the Executive Chairman of the National Legal Services Authority, was addressing a mega awareness programme on "Empowering Women and Strengthening Institutional Legal Support" at SKICC here, which was organised by the Jammu and Kashmir Legal Services Authority under the guidance of the National Legal Services Authority.

The programme was conceived as a common institutional platform to strengthen awareness of the legal rights of women and girl children and to improve coordination among the Legal Services Institutions, Police, Health, Education, Social Welfare, One Stop Centres, Child Welfare Committees and other authorities responsible for protection, legal assistance, compensation, rehabilitation and follow-up support.

In his presidential address, Justice Nath emphasised that the effectiveness of Legal Services Institutions must be judged by whether a person in distress is able to approach the system without fear, be heard with dignity and receive competent assistance without avoidable delay.

He called upon all stakeholders to strengthen legal literacy, institutional coordination and grassroots outreach so that constitutional and statutory safeguards become a practical reality for women and girl children.

The SC judge stressed that the proceedings and key deliberations of the conference should be translated

into vernacular languages and circulated among all concerned stakeholders, so that the knowledge and guidance emanating from the conference are easily understood and effectively acted upon at the grassroots level.

Speaking on the occasion, Supreme Court Judge and Supervising Judge for the J&K Legal Services Authority, Justice SVN Bhatti, highlighted the need for functional grievance mechanisms, trained stakeholders and victim-sensitive procedures.

He observed that women and children should not be compelled to navigate a fragmented institutional system or repeatedly recount traumatic experiences before different authorities. Clear referral pathways, confidentiality and accountability, he said, are necessary for meaningful legal empowerment.

While delivering the inaugural address, Chief Justice (Acting), High Court of J&K and Ladakh and Executive Chairman, J&K Legal Services Authority, Justice Sanjeev Kumar, underscored that access to justice cannot be measured merely by the availability of laws and institutions.

Justice Kumar called for stronger grassroots outreach and effective functioning of front offices, legal aid clinics, panel lawyers and para-legal volunteers so that persons in need are guided to appropriate remedies without procedural hardships. He also stressed the importance of convergence among all stakeholder institutions dealing with women in distress.

Justice Sanjay Dhar, Judge, High Court of J&K and Ladakh and Chairperson, High Court Legal Services Committee, in his address, said that recognition of a right in law is only the beginning and that the real test of justice lies in whether the right can be understood, approached and effectively enforced.

Justice Dhar emphasised that the constitutional character of the justice system is reflected in the manner in which the first institution a woman approaches receives her. Prompt assistance, confidentiality, sensitivity and institutional follow-up, he said, are essential to prevent secondary victimisation and restore confidence in the justice system.

Order Order

Thane court convicts man in 2018 fake currency case

A Thane court has convicted a 38-year-old man after he pleaded guilty in a 2018 fake currency and illegal firearms possession case, sentencing him to imprisonment already undergone during his nearly eight-year judicial custody.

Additional Sessions Judge VL Bhosale on June 17 ordered the immediate release of the accused, Ashish Shivkumar Sharma, subject to the payment of a collective fine of ₹8,600.

A copy of the court order was made available on Saturday.

Sharma had been in jail since July 11, 2018, following a police raid at Diva in Maharashtra's Thane district where counterfeit notes with a face value of ₹1,09,650, a scanner-printer, and an unlicensed firearm were seized.

The judge in the order noted, "The offence of counterfeiting currency notes is a serious economic offence. Counterfeit currency undermines financial stability and harms ordinary citizens and the national economy."

However, the court also took into account his poor health, lack of family support, and previous record.

"Taking an overall view of the matter and balancing the gravity of the offence against the substantial period already undergone, this court is of the considered view that the sentence of imprisonment already undergone by the accused, together with a fine, would meet the ends of justice in this case," it said.

The court ordered the man to pay a collective fine of ₹8,600 for various offences.

The case against the co-accused, Mohd Ismail Yasin Siddhiqui, who pleaded not guilty, will proceed separately through a regular trial. (*PTI*)

Ban on political advt in Delhi Metro during MCC valid: HC

The Delhi High Court has upheld the Election Commission rules not allowing political advertisements in the Delhi Metro when the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) is in force.

A bench of Justices V Kameswar Rao and Manmeet Pritam Singh Arora said ban on political ads for a limited time does not amount to "total restriction" on carrying out business, nor does it violate freedom of speech under Article 19 (1).

The bench was hearing a plea by a group of companies with advertising rights in the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), including contracts for advertising inside and outside trains, and outside civil structures.

The petition challenged the January 2020 order of a single judge which upheld DMRC banning political advertisements from being displayed in metro stations and trains while the MCC was in force.

Counsel for the companies pointed out that the Election Commission of India had issued a letter to DMRC in June 2019 stating, "No political advertisement shall be displayed/posted at the space provided on lease for commercial advertisement during the period of Model Code of Conduct.

"If there is any political advertisement in the provided space, the same shall be removed immediately on enforcement of the Model Code of Conduct," it said.

The counsel argued that the EC's direction was violative of the constitutional provisions as "there was no ban on the use of bus queue shelters, etc., for media campaigns by political parties and candidates during the operation of the MCC".

In an order dated June 19, the bench said, "There is no total restriction put on the appellants (companies) in carrying out their business. They are free to display advertisements that are not political in nature, even during operation of the MCC." (*PTI*)

5 acquitted in trespassing, assault case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A Delhi court has acquitted five people accused of trespassing into a neighbour's house and assaulting three members of a family, saying the prosecution failed to prove the charges beyond a reasonable doubt and its case was riddled with material contradictions.

Additional Sessions Judge Yadvender Singh acquitted Hari Ram, Promila, Sunita, Hari Kishan and Sunil Lakra of charges under Indian Penal Code (IPC) Sections 452 (house trespass after preparation for hurt), 308 (attempt to commit culpable homicide) and 323 (voluntarily causing hurt), all read with section 34 (common intention).

The three accused were also acquitted of offences under IPC sections 354 (assault on a woman with intent to outrage her modesty) and 354B (assault or criminal force with intent to disrobe a woman).

In an order dated June 9, the court said, "The prosecution has miserably failed to prove the complicity of the accused persons for the commission of the crime beyond the shadow of all reasonable doubts and has not been able to prove all the ingredients of the offences for which the accused persons have been charged and facing trial."

The case arose from an incident on March 26, 2014, in west Delhi's Ranhola area. The complainant had alleged that the accused had entered her house, assaulted her and her two sons with iron rods and sticks, tore her clothes and outraged her modesty.

The court said the testimonies of the complainant and her two injured sons could not be relied upon because they gave conflicting accounts about the weapons allegedly used, the role played by each accused and the manner in which the injuries were caused.

The judge noted that the prosecution had failed to recover the alleged weapons of offence and that the weapons were not even mentioned in the initial complaint. The court also found serious discrepancies regarding the seizure of blood-stained clothes allegedly worn by the injured persons at the time of the incident. "Merely bald allegations against the accused persons cannot be a substitute of proof against them. Merely the bald allegations also cannot remove the burden of proof from the prosecution to prove its case beyond a reasonable doubt," the court said.

The medical evidence also failed to support the prosecution's case, it pointed out, noting that all injuries were opined to be simple and a doctor had conceded that some of the injuries could have been caused by a fall on a hard surface.

The court further said allegations of outraging the complainant's modesty and tearing her clothes were not corroborated by other eyewitnesses and remained doubtful. Holding that the prosecution had "miserably failed" to establish the charges and that its case did not inspire confidence, the court acquitted all five accused.

Need to monitor Periyar River cleanliness: HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kochi

The Kerala High Court has stressed the need for a unified authority to monitor the cleanliness of the Periyar river, saying that lives of millions are at stake and all stakeholders, including the State Government, need to behave responsibly and discharge their obligations.

A bench of Chief Justice Soumen Sen and Justice Syam Kumar VM noted that in view of the importance of the Periyar river in the state, the need for a unified authority to monitor it "does not require any further emphasis".

The court said that the government had earlier suggested the creation of an Integrated River Basin Conservation and Management Plan back in September, 2025.

"The lives of millions are at stake and we should not wait for doomsday to arrive. We expect all the stakeholders to behave responsibly and discharge their obligations in order to ensure that all preventive and remedial measures are taken to save the Periyar river," the bench said.

Delhi tribunal awards ₹31 lakh compensation to accident victim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A Delhi Motor Accident Claims Tribunal has awarded over ₹31.4 lakh compensation to a physical education teacher who suffered permanent disability in a road accident in 2023 in which his wife was killed.

Presiding Officer Gunjan Gupta was hearing the claim petition filed by Dalbir Singh, who suffered 65 per cent permanent disability in an accident that took place near Shivaji Park Metro Station in west Delhi on January 26, 2023.

In an order dated June 12, the tribunal said, "...the claimants have successfully proved that the petitioner suffered grievous injuries in road accident due to rash and negligent driving of offending vehicle being driven by respondent no.1

(driver Ankit Goel)." According to the tribunal, Dalbir Singh was driving to the New Delhi Railway Station with his wife, son and another person when the offending car hit his vehicle from behind at a high speed. Due to the impact, his vehicle crashed into a metro pillar.

The tribunal noted that Singh suffered grievous injuries while his wife, Suman, sustained fatal injuries.

Rejecting the defence of the driver, the tribunal said the evidence on record, including the charge sheet, mechanical inspection reports and witness testimony, established rash and negligent driving.

The tribunal recorded that the 51-year-old claimant, a physical education teacher earning ₹25,290 per month, suffered 65 per cent permanent locomotor disability in relation to his right lower limb. Considering the nature of his profession, it assessed his functional disability at 50 per cent.

Awarding compensation under various heads, including loss of future earning capacity, pain and suffering, loss of amenities, attendant charges and special diet, the tribunal granted a total compensation of ₹31,41,854 along with 9 per cent annual interest from the date of filing of the claim petition till payment.

Kerala HC orders police protection for viral Kumbh Mela girl

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kochi

Kerala High Court has directed the police to provide protection to the young girl who shot to fame during the Prayagraj Kumbh Mela and whose husband is now facing charges of kidnapping her.

The High Court's order came on the girl's plea seeking directions to the State Government and the SHO of the Ernakulam Central police station to safeguard her life.

"Having heard the counsel for the petitioner (girl) as well as the Government pleader, I am, prima facie, satisfied that the petitioner ought to be afforded protection for her life. "Accordingly, there will be a direction to the second respondent (SHO) to provide adequate protection to the life of the petitioner, pending disposal of the writ petition,"

the court said. It also issued notice to the state government and the SHO and listed the matter on July 10.

Another bench of the High Court had earlier this month said that the girl prima facie appears to be a major and granted transit bail of one month to her husband so that he can move a Madhya Pradesh court to seek anticipatory bail in a kidnapping case against him.

The girl's husband, Mohd Farman, is accused of kidnapping her in a case registered by Madhya Pradesh police based on a complaint filed by her father, who has claimed that she is a minor.

With a captivating smile and beautiful eyes, the Indore girl had shot to fame after a virtual content creator shared a video of her selling rudraksh garlands at Kumbh Mela in Prayagraj in Uttar Pradesh last year. She married the man in Kerala, in the presence of senior CPI(M) leaders, despite her family's opposition.

₹30 lakh compensation to kin of man who died after falling in pit on public road

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has awarded ₹30 lakh compensation to the family of a 37-year-old man who died after falling into a pit dug up by the Delhi Jal Board, and asked authorities to formulate a policy to ensure immediate financial assistance to the affected in such cases.

Justice Purushaindra Kumar Kaurav observed that the loss of the sole breadwinner leaves a family extremely vulnerable, making even day-to-day survival uncertain, and such families should not be compelled to undertake a prolonged and expensive litigation to secure basic financial relief for incidents attributable to the negligence of public authorities.

Justice Kaurav said in the present case, the deceased's widow, mother and three minor children had been enduring hardship since the incident in 2019, and although policymaking is a function of the executive, the court cannot remain oblivious.

Noting that official data shows 8,246 people were injured and 3,904 persons were killed in 2023 in road accidents due to ongoing road works/construction activities, the judge asserted that such incidents are not unforeseeable occurrences but a consequence of administrative negligence and failure to implement basic safety measures mandated for public infrastructure works.

"A structured and effective policy framework for expeditious grant of compensation in cases such as these, would go a long way in ensuring that victims and their families receive immediate assistance without being compelled to pursue litigation for appropriate relief.

Such a mechanism would not only alleviate hardship faced by

affected families but would also enhance accountability among public authorities entrusted with maintaining public infrastructure and safety standards," the court said in a judgement passed on May 29 on a petition by the deceased's kin.

"The concerned authorities are, therefore, urged to examine the feasibility of formulating an appropriate policy in this regard, so as to ensure timely, humane, and efficient disbursal of compensation in deserving cases," it ordered.

On the intervening night of April 17 and 18, 2019, the deceased, who was on a motorcycle, fell in a ditch dug by the DJB for undertaking pipeline repair work in front of its office in Dhichaun Kalan.

The deceased was found lying in the pit the next morning and succumbed to his injuries after a few days.

The DJB contended that the excavation work was carried out by a third-party contractor and since barricades had been placed around the ditch, the deceased's own conduct might have contributed to the accident as he might have failed to stop his motorcycle because of the headlights of an oncoming truck.

Rejecting the DJB's claim of contributory negligence by the deceased, the court stated that it was the board's obligation to ensure that a hazardous excavation on a public road was adequately safeguarded with continuous supervision, adequate illumination and prompt emergency response.

It also observed that the deceased was lying in the ditch the entire night, which was a "systemic and egregious failure of the duty of care owed to the public by a statutory authority like DJB", and absence of adequate barricading, warning signs, illumination, supervision, and emergency response mechanisms reflected a disregard for public safety and human life.

"The DJB ought to have been well aware that such accidents can occur if a pit is dug on a road that is used by the public. Therefore, in such cases, the duty of the State and statutory bodies does not exhaust itself with the mere installation of barricades, it extends equally to vigilant supervision over hazardous sites and ensuring timely emergency response," the court remarked.

"The petitioners are entitled to a rounded off lump sum amount of ₹30,00,000. However, considering that they have received an amount of ₹50,000 from DJB, the respondents are directed to pay a lump sum amount of ₹29,50,000, along with simple interest at the rate of six per cent per annum from the date of the accident till the date of realisation, as compensation to the petitioners, within three months from the passing of this judgment," it ordered.

The court ruled that the DJB cannot defer the consequences of negligence to its contractor but would be at liberty to initiate recovery proceedings against him as per the contract.

Ancient Indian Wisdom on Taxation and Fiscal Ethics: The Startup as the New Seedling

ATANU CHAKRABARTY
FORMER ECONOMIC AFFAIRS SECRETARY, MOF, GOI

DR. ABHISHEK ANAND
SENIOR RESEARCH FELLOW, BHARAT KI SOCH

Ancient Indian thought on taxation and fiscal ethics was not confined to the mechanics of revenue extraction. It was anchored in a profound understanding of how wealth is created and how premature taxation of a nascent enterprise is not a prudent decision but a policy failure. This insight, articulated in Kautilya's *Arthashastra* and echoed in the *Manusmriti, Shanti Parva* of the *Mahabharata* and other ancient Indian scriptures, anticipates Bharat's taxation of startups and early-stage innovation. The 12-year trajectory of the Angel Tax, from its introduction in 2012 to its abolition in 2024, is, in essence, a modern re-enactment of ancient Indian fiscal wisdom.

The Foundational Principle: Do Not Harvest the Unripe Fruit

The Arthashastra's most important teaching on this subject is a governing doctrine embedded across its fiscal prescriptions: the state must not levy taxes on activity that has not yet matured into productive surplus. In the second *Adhikarana,* Kautilya instructs that the state must show *Anugraha,* i.e., favour or concessionary support, to those who establish new productive ground. He prescribes that farmers settling new land be supplied with seeds and working capital, and be permitted to repay only after the harvest, with tax relief structured so that it "swells the treasury eventually". The emphasis is crucial: "eventually". The revenue foregone in the germination phase is an investment, not a loss!

Kautilya understood what modern economists would later formalise in discussions over the Dupuit-Laffer curve, which describes the relationship between taxation rates and the tax revenue collected by a state. A tax rate imposed beyond an enterprise's productive capacity destroys the very base it is meant to tax. As Balbir Singh Sihag (famed author of the book titled "Kautilya: The True Founder of Economics") shows in his scholarly analysis, the *Arthashastra* contains "almost all the essential ingredients of a sound fiscal structure", including a theory of tax timing calibrated to the maturity of economic activity.

The *Arthashastra* also accorded formal recognition to the Shreni (the guild or a corporate body of merchants and artisans) as a legitimate economic actor deserving of regulatory protection. Its *Adhikarana* IV explicitly protects guild deposits in times of distress and *Adhikarana* XI addresses the governance of guilds and confederacies as distinct entities within the state's economic jurisdiction. The *Shreni* was, in effect, ancient Bharat's answer to the corporate enterprise (a collective of investors and skilled producers pooling capital and labour toward a common productive purpose). To tax the capital infusion at the moment of formation - before value had been created - would have been, in Kautilyan's scheme, an act of fiscal arbitration.

The *Manusmriti:* Capacity as the Tax's Measure

The *Manusmriti*'s verse of proportionality (7.128) is equally significant:

यथा फलेन युज्येत राजा कर्ता च कर्मणाम् ।
तथावेक्ष्य नृपो राष्ट्रे कल्पयेत् सततं करान् ।।

It means that taxes should be assessed after careful consideration, so that both he and those who do the work receive their fair share. The key phrase is "those who do the work": a recognition that the entrepreneur's surplus is not a windfall to be appropriated but a return on risk and labour that must be protected for the enterprise to continue.

The differentiated tax shares prescribed in the *Manusmriti* - one-sixth for mature agricultural produce, one-eighth for less productive land, one-twelfth for the least fertile - encapsulate sensitivity to the taxpayer's productive capacity that maps directly onto the question of when and how much a startup ought to bear.

Scrapping of the Angel Tax: An Error Rectified

The tension between the state's revenue instinct and the Kautilyan protection of nascent enterprise was dramatised by the debates over the so-called Angel Tax. Introduced in 2012 under Section 56(2)(viib) of the Income Tax Act, it targeted unlisted companies issuing shares at a premium above fair market value, taxing the excess as income. Intended to curb money laundering, it was criticised for stifling innovation and fundraising. It was terminated in the Union Budget 2024-25, citing the need "to bolster the Indian startup ecosystem, boost entrepreneurial spirit and support innovation".

Its structural problem was precisely what Kautilya would have identified: it taxed not income, not profit, not surplus, but capital at the moment of its commitment to an enterprise that had not yet produced anything.

The *Shanti Parva* (Book XII, Section 88) captures this through a beautiful analogy:

यथा मधुकरः पुष्पात रसग्नाहि न पीडयन्
तथा राज्ञा करः ग्राह्यो न च पीड्यः प्रजाजनः

The ideal state is like a bee that gathers honey without damaging the flower, so that it continues to bloom and yield. The Angel Tax violated this principle at its root. It taxed not profit, not income, not any fruit the enterprise had produced, but the very seeds being planted. In Indian civilizational ethos, those seeds deserve the state's protection, not its appetite.

Dharma, Trust and the State as Trustee

Bhishma's counsel to Yudhishthira in the *Shanti Parva* is clear: the state is a trustee, not a proprietor. Revenue belongs, ultimately, to the welfare of the people from whom it is drawn. When the state taxes capital that is committed to the creation of enterprises that would have employed thousands, generated property and expanded the economy's productive frontier, it is not exercising fiscal authority; rather, it is hampering its own economic base.

The paternal metaphor of the *Shanti Parva* - the state should be as fair between its subjects as a father between his sons - implies that the entrepreneur venturing into new productive territory deserves not predation but protection, precisely because the risks they bear serve the common good.

Conclusion

The Angel Tax's eventual elimination is not merely a chapter in Indian tax history. It is a validation of the civilisational wisdom found in the *Arthashastra*, *Manusmriti* and *Mahabharata*, millennia before modern startup ecosystems were imagined. The principle is simple and durable: protect the seedling. Tax the harvest. The state that confuses the two does not merely lose revenue; it destroys the future it is meant to build. As Bharat positions itself as a global hub for innovation and entrepreneurship, it is revisiting the fiscal ethics of Kautilya, Manu and Bhishma.

However, the relevance of ancient Indian texts on ethical and responsible taxation in the context of startups goes much beyond the scrapping of a tax. It is the state that controls profiteering impulses while protecting businesses, which form the bedrock of a sound startup ecosystem. Needless to say, a sound knowledge system is always a prerequisite for an idea to bloom.

Fable with Moral

The Compassionate Elephant and Prince Meghkumar

Restraint and devotion form the bedrock of Jain teachings, acting as twin forces that purify the soul and dismantle karmic attachments. Through rigorous self-restraint and unwavering devotion, an individual gains the spiritual strength required to conquer earthly desires and achieve ultimate liberation. The following story reflects the same-

Lord Mahavira initiated Prince Meghkumar, but the harsh ascetic life soon overwhelmed the prince. Sensing his distress, Mahavira recounted Meghkumar's past life. In it, a noble elephant balanced on three legs for three days to save a rabbit, proving that profound compassion and values require discipline and sacrifice.

Long ago, during a raging forest fire, a majestic forest elephant managed to stand in a small, cleared safety patch. Around him, dozens of other desperate, terrified animals huddled together to escape the blazing inferno. As the weary elephant shifted his weight and raised a heavy foot to scratch an itch, a tiny, terrified rabbit quickly darted into the newly empty space beneath him.

The elephant looked down and saw the fragile creature trembling right under his massive foot. Realizing that bringing his foot down would instantly crush the little rabbit, he made an extraordinary decision fueled by unconditional mercy. Choosing compassion over his own physical relief, he held his heavy foot suspended in the air.

He maintained this impossible, agonizing posture for over three days and nights until the raging forest fire completely died down. The prolonged physical stress took a severe toll on his body, but his mind remained focused entirely on protecting the fragile life beneath him. When the smoke finally cleared and the rabbit safely scurried away, the elephant's exhausted body gave out, and he collapsed. Yet, this pure intent of selflessly saving a life elevated his soul, ultimately leading to his noble rebirth as Prince Meghkumar.

If a soul could endure such immense physical hardship out of pure kindness when it was just a wild animal, human beings can certainly endure temporary discomforts and challenges to protect their spiritual path, and ethical values.

Moral of the Fable: Be compassionate even if it requires self -sacrifice and unwavering discipline.

Did you know?

Did you know that Punch-marked coins are the earliest known coins in the Indian subcontinent, dating from the 6th century BCE to the 2nd century CE. Punch-marked coins were not "minted" like later coins with a king's portrait, name or inscription. Their authority came from small symbols punched separately into pieces of metal, usually silver. That is why each coin can look slightly irregular, almost like a small metal document carrying several official or semi-official marks. They were predominantly made of silver, though fractional copper and a few gold or lead pieces also exist.

They lacked written text or legends. Instead, they featured punched motifs inspired by nature and daily life, such as the sun, trees, hills, rivers and animals. In ancient Indian literature, they are referred to by names such as *Purana, Karshapana, Pana,* and *Mashaka.*

Punch marked coins are mentioned in the Manu Smriti (c. 200 BCE - 200 CE), and Buddhist Jataka (c. 300 BCE- 400 CE) as circulating in the North until approximately the beginning of the 1st century CE, and lasting three centuries longer in the South until about 300 CE.

So, a punch-marked coin is not just an old coin. It is evidence of a society moving from barter and weighed metal exchange toward a more organised monetary economy. Their symbols were marks of trust in an expanding world of trade, guilds, janapadas and early states.

Wisdom Word Search

A	V	I	T	L	Q	K	O	O	L	I
N	M	A	L	I	B	K	J	D	O	A
G	K	U	P	A	P	O	N	N	U	O
A	K	U	T	P	O	E	A	I	Y	V
A	Y	P	D	H	J	K	L	M	P	A
D	B	J	A	I	A	A	V	A	A	A
I	A	T	L	T	S	L	G	H	A	Y
U	Y	H	A	O	T	S	V	A	T	P
O	B	P	D	E	F	U	I	I	T	A
V	A	R	U	V	U	R	Y	K	A	K
G	I	D	Q	W	K	A	D	A	M	G
C	H	E	L	A	V	U	B	S	R	J

WORDS TO FIND
Angaadi, Chelavu, Kadam, Kooli, Muthal, Paattam, Pattu, Ponnu, Vaaypa, Varavu

THE WISDOM LEXICON

ANGAADI: Market/Trading Center

CHELAVU: Expenditure/Expense. Rooted in the Dravidian base Chel (to go or pass), it literally means "that which goes out."

KADAM: Debt word for a liability or debt owed to someone else. A fundamental term in rural and informal economies.

KOOLI: Wage - The traditional term for the compensation paid for physical labor.

MUTHAL: Capital/Principal Asset - Dravidian root "primary".

PAATTAM: Lease/Rent It refers to the rent given by a tenant to the landowner for the right to use the asset.

PATTU: Credit/Running Tab - Dravidian root meaning "to receive" or "to attach."

PONNU: Gold - This is the definitive Dravidian word for gold. In the traditional economy, ponnu wasn't just jewelry; it was the ultimate liquid asset and security.

VAAYPA: Loan/Credit - Originating from the Dravidian root Vaaykuka (to yield or be granted), this is the traditional word used for borrowed funds or credit facilities.

VARAVU: Income/Revenue - translating to "that which comes in," Dravidian root Varu (to come). The native word for incoming cash flow or earnings.

Note: These terms come from MALAYALAM, one of India's 22 Scheduled Languages.

Marvels of India

THE *SHRENI*

Ancient Bharat's Marvel of Economic Organisation

Bharat's ancient guilds, known as Shreni, were sophisticated economic institutions of the pre-modern commercial world. Shrenis were the most vital institutions driving economic activity, functioning as legal entities composed of individuals engaged in similar trades, governed democratically through general assemblies and operating under the guiding principles of Shreni Dharma.

A Regulated, Standards-Driven Economy

They regulated manufacturing standards, trade, ethical codes, prices and the quality of crafts. Some of them became wealthy enough to act as custodians and bankers of religious and civic endowments. Kautilya's Arthashastra describes their regulation of trade, fixation of prices, supervision of weights and measures and even their judicial powers in commercial disputes, making them pivotal intermediaries between the state and the economy.

Pioneers of Corporate Banking

They also functioned as a bank, providing loans to its members. There is sufficient historical evidence to prove the existence of distinct Shreni banks owned and managed by the guild members.

A Sophisticated Multi-Functional Model

The research on Bharat's economic history shows that the Shreni model was not a primitive associative structure but an evolved institution providing specialised production, quality assurance, capital formation and social security, all undergirded by a profound ideology of corporate ethics.

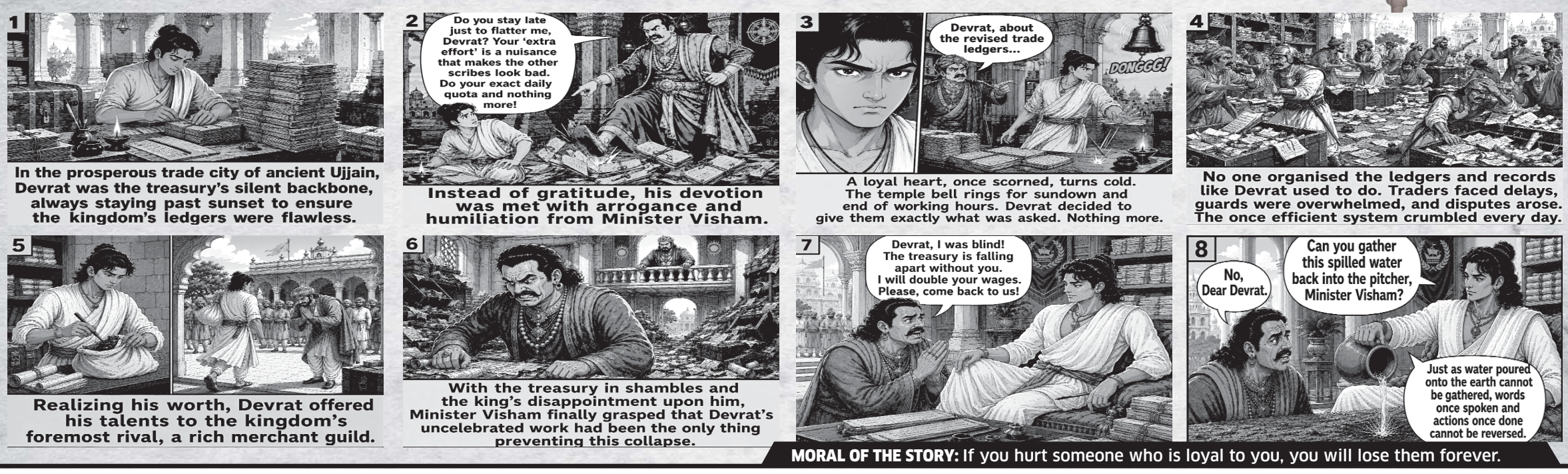
QUIZ — Economy, Commerce & Finance

	Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1	Queen pineapple is renowned for its exceptional sweetness, rich aroma and high juice content. As the official state fruit of X, this GI-tagged variety is also celebrated for its lack of chemical residues. What is X?	Mizoram	Tripura	Goa	Karnataka
2	Which state has a geographical indication for the Chakshesang Shawl?	Nagaland	Manipur	Mizoram	Assam
3	In ancient India, powerful guilds of merchants, artisans and craftspeople played a major role in finance and commerce. What were these groups called?	Sabhas	Shrenis	Samitis	Shreshthis
4	What did the term 'Sarthavaha' designate in the economic landscape of ancient India?	Maritime Ship Captain	Head of Elephant Convoy	Merchant Caravan Leader	A Royal Accountant
5	The old Mesopotamian records refer to trade relations with the Indus Valley Civilization, whose seals have also been discovered in Mesopotamia. What was the ancient name used in those records for this settlement?	Dilmun	Magan	Sindhu Ghati	Meluhha

Answers: 1 - B, 2 - A, 3 - B, 4 - C, 5 - D

folktale

Spilled Water



MORAL OF THE STORY: If you hurt someone who is loyal to you, you will lose them forever.

FROM THE WORLD

UK

PM condemns hatred attacks

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer has condemned violence on the streets of Edinburgh in Scotland which was "motivated by anti-Muslim hatred", after a series of attacks in the city that left five men injured.

Police Scotland said a 36-year-old white Scottish man has been charged after officers received multiple calls from members of the public about violent attacks, including "threats, robbery and vandalism" across Edinburgh on Friday. Counter Terrorism Policing Scotland is investigating, supported by other specialist officers.

"Absolutely appalling. No one should face violence on our streets. The suspect appears to be motivated by anti-Muslim hatred," said Starmer. (*PTI*)

PAKISTAN

PPP names CM candidate

The Pakistan Peoples Party on Sunday named its candidate for the so-called chief ministerial position in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir's Gilgit-Baltistan, days after emerging as the single largest party in elections held in the region.

The party's chairman Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari nominated Amjad Hussain, a lawyer by profession, for the top post, it said in a statement.

India maintains that the entire Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, including Gilgit-Baltistan, are integral and inalienable parts of India by virtue of the "complete, legal and irrevocable accession" of Jammu and Kashmir to India in 1947.

India lodged a strong protest with Pakistan over the so-called elections in the region on June 7, maintaining that Gilgit-Baltistan is part of Indian territory that has been "illegally and forcibly" occupied by Pakistan.

Following the polls, the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) emerged as the largest party, with 12 seats in the so-called 24-member Gilgit-Baltistan Assembly. (*PTI*)

Why Tarique Rahman chose Malaysia, China before India

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's decision to make Malaysia and China the destinations of his first overseas visits since assuming office has attracted considerable attention across South Asia. While Dhaka insists that the move is guided solely by national interests and its "Bangladesh First" policy, the sequencing of these visits carries both economic and geopolitical significance.

Prime Minister Tarique Rahman is currently in Malaysia and is scheduled to meet Premier Li on June 25 and President Xi Jinping on June 26. The official explanation from Dhaka is straightforward: Malaysia and China currently offer immediate economic opportunities that align with Bangladesh's development priorities.

In Malaysia, the focus is expected to be on expanding labor market access, attracting investment, advancing free trade negotiations, and strengthening cooperation in sectors such as energy, semiconductors, agriculture, and the halal economy. Bangladesh is also using the visit to reinforce its bid for ASEAN engagement and eventual participation in the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), the world's largest trade bloc.

China, meanwhile, remains one of Bangladesh's most important economic partners. The planned signing of 15-17 bilateral instruments, discussions on infrastructure projects, investment promotion, and potential financial support underline the economic weight of the relationship. Dhaka also sees Beijing as a key source of technology, industrial investment, and development financing.

From this perspective, the choice of Malaysia and China appears driven by economic pragmatism rather than diplomatic symbolism.

Nevertheless, the absence of India from Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's first foreign tour is politically significant.

Foreign Affairs Adviser Humaiun Kobir acknowledged

as much when he stated that a visit to India would take place "when the temperature comes down and a conducive atmosphere is in place." The comment suggests that while Dhaka remains open to engagement with New Delhi, certain political or diplomatic sensitivities currently need to be managed.

This is notable because Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi had extended an invitation to Tarique Rahman earlier this year, emphasizing cooperation in trade, connectivity, technology, energy, healthcare, education, and regional security.

Historically, India has occupied a central place in Bangladesh's foreign policy due to geographic proximity, economic interdependence, shared cultural links, and security cooperation. Any delay in a high-level visit inevitably invites speculation about the state of bilateral relations. However, Bangladeshi officials have been careful to stress that India is not being sidelined. Instead, they argue that Bangladesh's foreign policy is no longer centered on any single partner but on diversified relationships that maximise national interests.

A recurring theme in government statements is the concept of "Bangladesh First." Officials argue that foreign policy decisions should be based on economic benefits and strategic interests rather than external expectations.

The current diplomatic outreach reflects a broader effort to diversify Bangladesh's international partnerships. Relations with China, ASEAN countries, Middle Eastern states, Japan, the United States, and the United Kingdom are all being pursued simultaneously.

Recent meetings between Bangladesh's foreign minister and ambassadors from the United States, Japan, and the United Kingdom reinforce the message that Dhaka seeks balanced engagement with all major partners. In this context, visiting Malaysia and China first can be interpreted as an attempt to demonstrate foreign policy autonomy rather than a rejection of India.

The timing of the China visit is particularly noteworthy. South Asia has increasingly become a theater of strategic competition between China and India. Any major diplomatic engagement by Bangladesh with Beijing is therefore closely watched in New Delhi.

Yet Bangladesh has traditionally sought to avoid choosing sides. Successive governments have attempted to maintain strong relations with both China and India, benefiting from Chinese investment while preserving deep economic and security ties with India.

The challenge for Tarique Rahman's government will be maintaining this balance while expanding economic cooperation with China and Southeast Asia.

The key takeaway from Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's first foreign tour is that Bangladesh appears to be prioritizing economic diplomacy and strategic diversification. Malaysia offers opportunities in trade, labor, and ASEAN integration, while China provides investment, infrastructure cooperation, and broader economic engagement.

India remains an indispensable partner for Bangladesh, and Dhaka has made clear that an Indian visit remains on the agenda when conditions become more favorable. Rather than signalling a departure from India, the current sequence of visits may reflect Bangladesh's effort to project an independent foreign policy that places national economic interests at the centre.

Whether this approach strengthens Bangladesh's strategic autonomy or creates new diplomatic challenges will depend on how successfully Dhaka manages its relationships with all major partners in the months ahead.

IPF Bihar Council marks International Yoga Day with grand camp in Sharjah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ UAE

The IPF Bihar Council organised a grand Yoga Camp at Sharjah Corniche in the UAE on Sunday to celebrate International Yoga Day 2026, drawing enthusiastic participation from people of different nationalities and communities.

Held in the tranquil surroundings of Sharjah Corniche, the event featured yoga *asanas*, pranayama and meditation sessions aimed at promoting physical fitness, mental well-being and a balanced lifestyle. Participants, including individuals and families, joined the early morning programme and highlighted yoga's growing acceptance as a global wellness practice.

The camp was organised under the leadership of IPF Bihar Council Convenor RK Mahto and his team comprising Sanjeet Jha, Shailesh Pandey, Rajnish Sinha, Vikas Singh, Manas Pandey, Atul Kumar, Om Prakash, Hemant Singh and Amrita Singh.

Speaking on the occasion, Ashok Doshi, Vice-President of the IPF Central Committee, said yoga serves as a powerful tool for connecting people across cultures and fostering a healthier and more disciplined society. He urged participants to make yoga a regular part of their daily routine.

Mahto described yoga as India's timeless gift to the world and emphasised its relevance in addressing the challenges of modern-day life. He said regular yoga practice contributes not only to physical health but also to mental peace and emotional balance.

Israeli strikes in Gaza kill 6, including 2 kids and Al Jazeera staff

WAFAA SHURAFA ■ Deir Al-Balah (Gaza)

Israeli strikes in Gaza on Saturday killed at least six people, including two children and a cameraman with broadcaster Al Jazeera, according to Palestinian health officials.

Despite an October ceasefire between Israel and the militant group Hamas, the enclave has seen near-daily Israeli attacks that have killed over 1,000 Palestinians, according to Gaza's Health Ministry.

The first strike on Saturday hit an apartment in Gaza City around 2 am (local time), according to the ministry. At the site, an Associated Press reporter saw rubble and chunks of concrete stained with blood.

The bodies of two sisters, 4-year-old Zina and 14-year-old Lana, were sent to Shifa Hospital's morgue, where they lay in white hospital bags, surrounded by family members.

"I was sitting at home. The rocket fell on us without a warning," their

cousin, Mohammad Safadi, whose forehead was wounded, said.

He said his wife was also hurt.

"This ceasefire the occupation and the negotiation team speak of ... is this really a ceasefire? We are civilians. I never held a weapon," Safadi said.

The Israeli military said it was looking into the incident.

On Saturday evening, three Israeli strikes killed four people and wounded at least a dozen others.

The first hit a house in central Gaza's Bureij refugee camp without warning, killing three people, including Al Jazeera cameraman Ahmed Wishah, according to Al-Aqsa hospital. Al Jazeera confirmed Wishah's death.

Wishah's brother Mohamed, who was a correspondent for Al Jazeera, was killed in an Israeli strike in April.

Another strike on Saturday targeted a group of people in the sprawling tent camp of Muwasi in southern Gaza, killing one and wounding eight others, according to Nasser hospital, where the casualties were taken.

A third strike in Gaza City targeted a group of people and wounded at least four, according to Shifa hospital.

The Israeli military in a statement said it killed the Al Jazeera cameraman in a "precise strike." It asserted that he had been part of Hamas' military wing and had posed a threat to troops in the area.

Israel says it is targeting Hamas and other militants who pose a threat. Five Israeli soldiers have been killed since the truce. (*AP*)

Colombians vote in presidential runoff, electorate divided

REGINA GARCIA CANO/ASTRID SUAREZ ■ Bogota (Colombia)

A deeply divided electorate will choose Colombia's next president in a runoff on Sunday that pits a progressive against a conservative outsider, with both candidates tapping into fears of a renewed internal conflict in the country.

Voters will choose between businessman and lawyer Abelardo de la Espriella and Ivan Cepeda, a lawmaker and heir to the political movement of outgoing President Gustavo Petro, the nation's first leftist leader. The two defeated nine other contenders in a May 31 vote. Both are pitching strategies that they say will prevent the South American country from experiencing

the nonstop merciless violence, such as car bombs, kidnappings, disappearances and forced displacements that Colombians lived with in previous decades.

De la Espriella is proposing a heavy-handed approach that has earned him the endorsement of US President Donald Trump. Cepeda is promising to continue Petro's efforts, including attempts at establishing dialogue with multiple illegal armed groups even though those efforts have largely failed.

The two candidates also are offering differing solutions for the country's struggling health system, ballooning public debt and entrenched corruption.

"Right now, what worries me is the polarisation that exists between us: there are two very extreme sides, and the violence is concerning," John Manrique, a lawyer in the capital, Bogota, said as he walked his dog.

"What I hope is that people accept who won," he added. "Let's accept it, regardless of the side, and try to reach a social consensus. ... Let's not go out and fight."

In the first round, Cepeda earned 41 per cent of the vote, while de la Espriella garnered 44 per cent, according to official results. Petro, without evidence, sowed doubts in the results after Cepeda, who had consistently lead polls ahead of the May vote, did not win outright and even finished behind de la Espriella. Fighting between rebel groups plagues the nation

The election comes 10 years after Colombia signed a historic peace pact with guerrillas of the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia, or FARC, that had offered hope to break the nation's vicious cycle of fighting between rebel groups and the government. (*AP*)

Ukrainian attacks prompt Crimea to halt civilian gasoline sales

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Moscow

Officials in Russia-occupied Crimea suspended civilian gasoline sales Sunday as Ukraine ramped up attacks on fuel supplies on the Black Sea peninsula.

Gov. Sergey Aksyonov, the Kremlin-appointed head of Crimea, said that overnight Ukrainian strikes killed four people and wounded 28 others. He did not specify the target of the attack.

He later wrote on social media that local gas stations would halt all sales to non-state companies and indi-

viduals for an undefined period.

"Fuel will be sold only to government agencies that ensure the functioning and security of the Republic of Crimea," Aksyonov said. (*AP*)

Indian man charged with fatal stabbing in London's Southall

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

An Indian national has been charged with the fatal stabbing of a 26-year-old man, also an Indian, in the west London suburb of Southall, the Metropolitan Police said.

Navjot Singh, 20, was charged with murder, grievous bodily harm with intent and possessing an offensive weapon after his arrest on suspicion of the murder of Gurbhej Singh last week.

In the early hours of June

10, Gurbhej Singh was attacked on North Road, near the junction with Dormers Wells Lane, in Southall, along with another man in his 30s, who was treated at a hospital and has since been discharged.

The Met Police said officers attended with paramedics after being called to the scene by the London Ambulance Service following the attack. However, despite the efforts of medical staff, Gurbhej Singh - who had suffered a knife wound - was pronounced dead at the scene. (*PTI*)

Pak PM meets US V-P JD Vance on sidelines of talks in Switzerland

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad/Zurich

Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Sunday met US Vice President JD Vance on the sidelines of the technical-level talks in Switzerland, aimed at restoring peace in West Asia, his office said.

Sharif reached Switzerland earlier in the day, accompanied by Army chief Asim Munir and a delegation. Top officials from Iran and Qatar have also reached the Burgenstock Alpine ridges, where the talks are taking place.

"Prime Minister Muhammad Shehbaz Sharif meeting with Vice President of the United States JD Vance on the sidelines of US-Iran technical level talks as a follow-up of Islamabad MoU, being held in Burgenstock, Switzerland, 21 June 2026," Sharif's office said in a post on X on Sunday.

They also shared a video clip in which Sharif and Munir could be seen shaking hands with Vance, envoy Steve Witkoff and adviser Jared Kushner.

In an interview ahead of this meeting, Vance told Pakistan TV that he acknowledged Islamabad's role in the US-Iran negotiations. (*PTI*)

France restricts public alcohol consumption, outdoor sports

ANGELA CHARLTON ■ Paris

France is putting emergency services and military forces on wildfire alert, restricting public alcohol consumption and cancelling some outdoor sports events to cope with a heat wave unfurling across parts of Europe.

About a third of France is under the national weather

service's heat red alert Sunday and temperatures are high nationwide, expected to reach 40 C on Sunday in some areas, in a country where air-conditioning isn't widespread. The forecast for Monday is even hotter.

The Eiffel Tower and other Paris venues set up misting stations to cool crowds, among a raft of measures announced by national and local authorities to minimize risks. (*AP*)

Pressure mounts on Starmer to resign in favour of Burnham

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Keir Starmer has come under mounting pressure to resign as the leader of the Labour Party to pave the way for Andy Burnham to take over as the new British Prime Minister.

Burnham's decisive victory against a looming far-right threat from Nigel Farage's Reform UK in the Makerfield byelection in northern England earlier this week strengthened his claim to the top job.

While Starmer has been steadfast in his commitment to contest any leadership

challenge, the growing voices of dissent from within his own cabinet have triggered speculation around his exit from 10 Downing Street as early as next week.

"I was elected with a considerable mandate to serve the country at a general election two years ago," Starmer told reporters on Saturday.

"There isn't a leadership contest at the moment, but as I have said on many, many occasions, I don't think that's a good thing for the country to plunge us into chaos," he said. "I would also add that now that Andy (Burnham) has won (in Makerfield), which is really good because he is a huge asset to us... It is important that we pull together," he added.

Starmer also said that if there is a contest he will face, he will stand and will not walk away. However, this defiance is said to be chipping away behind the scenes as Burnham pushes ahead with cobbling together what his own Cabinet would look like.

According to 'The Guardian', the tally of Labour MPs supporting him as the new leader is edging closer to 300.

"As well as working really hard over this weekend, I think he is making time to reflect on the political realities, challenges and opportunities that he finds himself in," Business and Trade Secretary Peter Kyle told reporters on Sunday, when asked about Starmer's plans. (*PTI*)

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India-EU trade pact to be signed by Dec: Goyal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

India and the 27-nation European Union (EU) will sign the free trade agreement by December and are likely to implement the pact during February-March next year, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Sunday.

On January 27 this year, India and the EU announced the conclusion of negotiations for the 'mother of all deals'.

"Now, with almost zero duty, almost the entire European market will be open for us. The EU's FTA (free trade agreement) will be signed by December and will be effective by February-March," Goyal said during an interaction with chartered accountants in Mumbai.

He also said that his US Trade Representative, Jamieson Greer, is coming to India this week to hold trade pact talks with him.

"The whole world is looking towards India," Piyush Goyal added.

Under the India-EU FTA, about 93 per cent of Indian shipments will enjoy duty-free access to the 27-nation bloc, while imports of luxury cars and wines from the EU will become less expensive.

Taken together, India and the EU account for 25 per cent of the global GDP and one-third (about USD 11 trillion) of international trade (about USD 33 trillion).

Later, he told reporters that during the G7 Summit in France, the Canadian Prime Minister expressed a desire to conclude the proposed free trade agreement with India this year.

The two sides held the second round of negotiations for the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in May.

Upgrade products to take advantage of FTA with UK, say experts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Indian exporters will have to upgrade product standards and align their goods with British regulatory requirements to take full advantage of the India-UK free trade agreement, which will come into effect from July 15, according to experts.

They also said that the government should conduct an outreach programme in different parts of India to inform the domestic industry about the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) between the two countries.

The UK's Department for Business and Trade has already launched a nationwide free trade agreement roadshow this week across six cities to prepare British businesses for the agreement's entry into force.

"A comparable effort is needed on the Indian side, with CETA-specific outreach export-readiness programmes in manufacturing clusters across the country that can help businesses convert the agreement's potential into actual commercial activity," law firm SAM & Co Partner Rudra Kumar Pandey said.

He added that Indian exporters will need to upgrade product standards and align with UK regulatory requirements to become reliable supply chain partners, not just one-off suppliers. Pandey said that early finalisation of the bilateral investment treaty (BIT) between India and the UK is also important to give investors confidence in binding legal protection, which is a prerequisite for capital-intensive and long-horizon commitments.

The projected gains from the Indian-UK FTA are significant and go beyond just trade facilitation to integrating the supply chains of the country in the longer run.

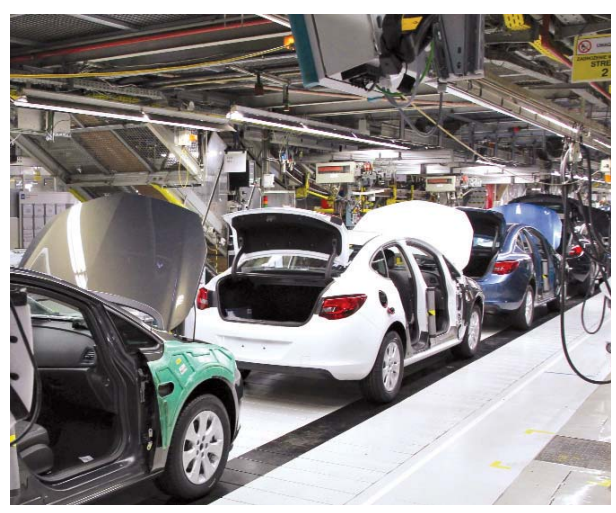
"Realising this will require focused effort on implementation, both at the structural level and in execution," he said.

Gulzar Didwania, Partner, Deloitte India, said that for investors, the agreement is expected to catalyse a new generation of two-way capital flows across advanced manufacturing, electric vehicles and EV components, fintech, life sciences and pharmaceuticals, clean energy and green hydrogen, and high-value services.

For the UK, India offers scale, manufacturing depth and an increasingly mature regulatory architecture. On the other hand, for India, the UK offers a gateway into European and global markets, a deep services economy and access to advanced technology and R&D ecosystems, he said.

Indian passenger vehicle makers eye opportunity in UK's EV market via FTA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Domestic automakers Maruti Suzuki, Mahindra & Mahindra and Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles are looking to tap opportunities in the electric car segment in the UK, as India's free trade pact with the country will allow duty-free exports for specified price segments under a quota system.

As per the India-UK CETA document, released last week, India will get access to the UK's electric, hybrid/hydrogen passenger cars segment, with duty-free exports to that country from the sixth year in the price segment ranging from under GBP 20,000 to 80,000, with the total quota reaching a peak of 88,000 units from the 15th year and continuing in the subsequent years.

The free trade agreement (FTA) between the two countries, which is expected to help double two-way commerce to $100 billion by 2030, will come into force on July 15.

"The India-UK FTA is a positive development that could create new opportunities for India-manufactured electric vehicles," M&M Ltd President, Automotive Business, Velusamy R told PTI in response to a query.

On M&M's plans to tap the EV segment in the UK, he said, "As we have indicated earlier, the UK is one of the right-hand-drive markets...(and) we will evaluate as part of a calibrated global expansion of our electric SUV portfolio. We will study the details of the agreement and the market opportunity, before taking an appropriate decision". Expressing similar optimism, Maruti Suzuki Senior Executive Officer, Corporate Affairs, Rahul Bharti said, "We believe India has the competitiveness to welcome liberalisation and use it for export opportunities, and we thank the Government for this FTA with the UK".

He further said, "We have already started exporting eVITARA to Europe, with about 36,000 units already exported within nine months of the launch, and the UK being the top market. Therefore, we believe this FTA will be positive for 'Make in India for the world'."

Terming the India-UK FTA a positive step towards deepening bilateral trade and advancing sustainable mobility, a Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles spokesperson said, "The phased, quota-based framework creates a calibrated pathway by opening new export opportunities for Indian-made EVs in the UK while supporting long-term competitiveness of the domestic industry"".

India, US ministerial-level trade pact talks this week

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer and Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will hold two-day talks this week on the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement.

"For the US trade deal talks, tomorrow my counterpart is coming to Delhi," Goyal told reporters in Mumbai.

The meeting followed chief negotiator-level discussions on the pact held earlier this month (June 2-4) here in the national capital.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal has recently stated that the discussions between the two ministers are expected to be centred around giving final touches to the framework deal.

On June 5, Goyal said India and the US are moving towards closing all the open ends of the interim trade agreement, and both sides are likely to execute the "very, very vibrant" first phase of the BTA by the middle of next month.

IMPORTANCE OF THE MIDDLE OF NEXT MONTH: The 10 per cent temporary tariff imposed by the US on all its trading partners on February 24, 2026, for 150 days will expire on July 24. After that, the MFN (most favoured nation) tariffs will come into force on goods imported by the US.

The temporary tariff is levied over and above the MFN duty. So before July 24, the US has to put in place a new tariff regime.

For that, the US is conducting two Section 301 investigations against a number of countries, including India. This is the only legal mechanism through which the US can impose new tariffs of any magnitude.

SECTION 301 PROBES: In March, the US Trade Representative (USTR) launched two unilateral Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974 investigations against a number of countries, including India, over excess capacity and failures to eradicate forced labour in global supply chains.

On June 2, the USTR proposed imposing 12.5 per cent tariffs on 54 countries, including India, for allegedly failing to prohibit the import of goods produced with forced labour. The measure remains a proposal and has not yet been finalised. Interested parties can submit requests to appear at hearings and summaries of testimony by June 22. The USTR is scheduled to hold hearings on July 7.

The report of the second probe is awaited.

WHY THIS PROBE: On February 20, the US Supreme Court ruled against US President Donald Trump's sweeping reciprocal tariffs, which were imposed under the 1977 International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA). India was facing a 50 per cent tariff. Because of the ruling, the US has to replace the sweeping reciprocal tariffs with temporary duties.

So, Trump announced 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days, starting February 24.

INDIA-US BTA FRAMEWORK: On February 7, India and the US issued a joint statement finalising the contours or framework of the first phase of the BTA or an interim trade deal.

According to that framework, the US had agreed to reduce tariffs on India to 18 per cent from 50 per cent. It had removed the 25 per cent tariffs on Indian goods for buying Russian oil and was to cut the remaining 25 per cent to 18 per cent under the pact. But the US Supreme Court ruled against these tariffs.

As the tariff landscape changed in the US, both sides are relooking at the agreement's framework.

The February joint statement on the framework has a clause that, in the event of any changes to the agreed-upon tariffs of either country, the US and India agree that the other country may modify its commitments.

Exports rise 15 pc in April-June despite global uncertainties

The country's merchandise exports rose by about 15 per cent during April-June 14 this year despite global economic uncertainties, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Sunday.

The Commerce Ministry will formally release the export and import data for June on July 15.

Goyal said that despite 50 per cent tariffs imposed by the US, India's exports in 2025-26 recorded healthy growth. "Even now, if we see April, May and 14 days of June. I have data until June 14, it (exports growth) is 15 per cent," he said during an interaction with chartered accountants in Mumbai.

India's exports climbed to a six-month high of 18 per cent to $45.2 billion in May, while the trade deficit widened to $28.21 billion.

During April-May 2026-27, exports rose 16.09 per cent to $88.91 billion and imports jumped 15.14 per cent to $145.35 billion. The trade deficit stood at $56.44 billion during the period.

He also urged the chartered accountants to contribute to make India a 'Viksit Bharat'.

"And where does Viksit Bharat begin? It begins in North Mumbai. We have to handle our own area first," he said. Goyal is a Lok Sabha member from the Mumbai (North) constituency. He has called upon senior officials, including the municipal commissioner and corporators, to start a cleanliness campaign here tomorrow.

"We all have to make a collective effort for this. We keep our house clean, we also have to keep our area clean, keep our society clean, keep our kaarobaar (business) also clean," the minister said. *(PTI)*

Mcap of 9 out of top-10 most valued firms jumps ₹2.15 lakh cr

The combined market valuation of nine of the top-10 most valued firms jumped by ₹2.15 lakh crore last week, with Bharti Airtel emerging as the biggest winner, in line with improving global risk sentiment. Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex jumped 1,274.95 points, or 1.68 per cent.

"Indian equity markets extended their recovery during the week, supported by easing geopolitical concerns, softer crude oil prices, and improving global risk sentiment. Although negotiations remain ongoing and the agreement is yet to be fully implemented, the reduction in geopolitical uncertainty has significantly improved market sentiment," Ponmudi R, CEO – Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

The market valuation of Bharti Airtel surged by ₹52,432.67 crore to ₹11,62,963.30 crore, the most among the top-10 firms. Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) added ₹51,675.23 crore, taking its valuation to ₹5,56,726.30 crore. The valuation of Bajaj Finance soared by ₹26,553.71 crore to ₹5,98,501.25 crore, and that of Reliance Industries jumped by ₹22,464.02 crore to ₹17,71,882.96 crore. The market capitalisation (mcap) of Larsen & Toubro climbed ₹21,929.12 crore to ₹5,79,126.95 crore, and that of State Bank of India rallied ₹16,753.57 crore to ₹9,55,415.07 crore.

HDFC Bank's mcap edged higher by ₹11,948.72 crore to ₹12,01,263.14 crore, and that of Hindustan Unilever advanced by ₹6,661.1 crore to ₹5,15,946.75 crore. The valuation of ICICI Bank rose by ₹4,724.22 crore to ₹9,66,021.99 crore. However, the market value of TCS declined by ₹12,699.49 crore to ₹7,69,350.13 crore. Reliance Industries remained the most valued domestic firm, followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, LIC and Hindustan Unilever. *(PTI)*

ONGC is now a gas-and-oil company as output shifts natural gas

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Oil and Natural Gas Corp (ONGC) should increasingly be seen as a 'gas-and-oil' company rather than an oil-and-gas producer, its chairman Arun Kumar Singh said, underscoring a strategic shift as natural gas output outpaces crude oil.

"Gas is now slightly more than oil in our portfolio," Singh told analysts, adding that ONGC's future growth will be driven largely by gas production even as crude output remains broadly flat without major new discoveries.

"We should call ourselves a gas and oil company, not an oil and gas company."

Singh said gas is emerging as the dominant growth driver for the state-run explorer, with rising domestic demand, supportive pricing reforms and new field developments pushing production higher.

"Gas is a more valued fuel in the Indian context, and ONGC is gradually becoming a more gas-heavy company," Singh said, adding that gas output already exceeds oil and will continue to expand over the coming years.

While oil production is likely to remain flat, gas output will rise as newer fields are put into production. With one of the best pricing in the world, gas is now a more lucrative portfolio, he said.

"ONGC produces and sells more gas than oil. In fact, gas is now a little more than oil," he pointed out.

Singh said gas is becoming increasingly attractive relative to oil due to pricing reforms, with 'new well gas' linked to 12 per cent of crude prices, and described India's rising gas demand — including from transport — as a key structural driver.

He added that while oil production is likely to remain broadly flat without major discoveries, ONGC's growth trajectory will increasingly be "gas-led", reinforcing its transition toward a more diversified energy portfolio.

ONGC's exploration and production (E&P) business now accounts for roughly two-thirds of the group, with gas output already exceeding oil and expected to expand further in the coming years.

He said government policy support, including reduced royalties, continued market-linked pricing reforms and a push to fund deepwater exploration, has improved sector economics and left more revenue with upstream producers.

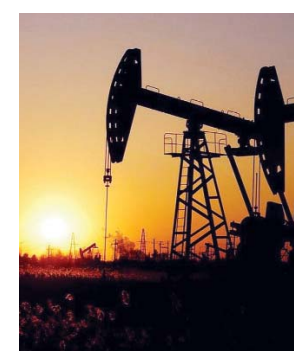
Singh noted that 'new well gas' production is rising sharply and already accounts for about a quarter of total gas output, and added that it could reach 30-36 per cent in the near term and eventually dominate ONGC's gas portfolio as mature fields decline.

He said ONGC expects annual gas production growth of around 7-8 per cent, supported by new projects, including DUDP, DSF fields and offshore developments, such as 98/2 wells, many of which are scheduled to come online over the next fiscal year.

The company continues to drill around 500 wells annually, including exploratory and producing wells, and reported a reserve replacement ratio of more than 1.1 in FY25-26, indicating replenishment of produced reserves.

US-Iran talks, crude prices key drivers for mkts this week

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Movement in the stock market will hinge on the outcome of talks between the US and Iran, crude oil prices and trading activity of foreign investors in the holiday-shortened week ahead, analysts said.

Technical-level talks will be held in Burgenstock, Switzerland, on Sunday between the US and Iran.

US Vice President JD Vance was initially supposed to hold a first round of talks with senior Iranian officials on Friday at a mountainside resort in the tiny Swiss village of Obburgen, but his Iranian counterparts cancelled their plans to attend because of escalating fighting between Israel and Iranian-backed Hezbollah in Lebanon.

Stock markets would remain closed on Friday for Muharram.

PROSPECT

ED attaches ₹1,000-cr assets in Goa illegal iron ore mining case

The Enforcement Directorate on Sunday said it has attached assets worth more than ₹1,023 crore, including properties located in Singapore, in an alleged illegal iron ore mining case in Goa. A provisional order has been issued on June 19 under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) in the matter pertaining to large-scale illegal iron ore mining by the Salgaocar Groups and associates (AVS Group), the central agency said in a statement.

The attached assets include 99 immovable properties located in India (₹459.10 crore), 31 immovable properties in Singapore (₹471.32 crore) and equity shares in Indian companies (₹93.42 crore) held in the names the Estate of Late Anil Salgaocar (through its administrator Lakshmi Anil Salgaocar), Salgaocar Mining Industries, Shantilal Khushaldas & Brothers, S Kantilal & Co., Salitho Ores, Vertex Newton Projects. and Subarnarekha Port, according to the ED. The total value of the assets is ₹1,023.85 crore.

The money laundering investigation stems from a FIR of the Goa Police CID. The ED said the Supreme Court, through its judgements in 2014 and 2018, has held that all mining undertaken in Goa after 22.11.2007 (till issue of fresh mining leases) was illegal.

Sesame Workshop India brings *Chhoti Badi Bhaavnaayein* to life through theatre experience

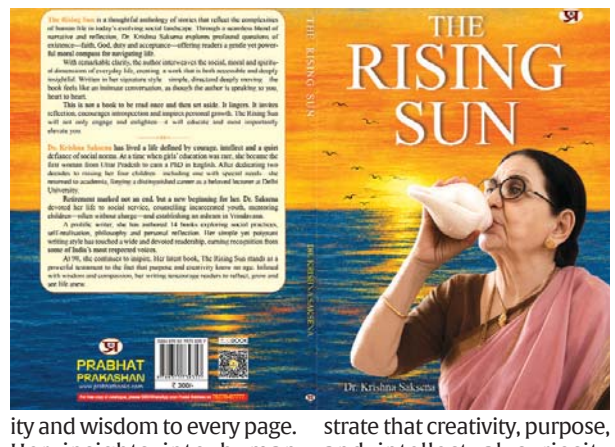
Sesame Workshop India Trust brought its emotional well-being initiative, *Chhoti Badi Bhaavnaayein*, to life through a unique immersive theatre experience supported globally by MetLife Foundation. The event engaged over 100 children, caregivers, educators, and partners in interactive storytelling designed to foster empathy, kindness, cooperation, and emotional understanding.

Featuring beloved Sesame characters Chamki, Elmo, and Grover, the experience encouraged participants to explore emotions, understand different perspectives, and practise positive social interactions through real-life scenarios.

Speaking on the occasion, Sonali Khan, managing trustee, Sesame Workshop India Trust, said that emotional wellbeing is built through everyday relationships and shared experiences. The initiative also includes multilingual digital resources to help families continue nurturing emotional growth beyond the event.

The Rising Sun: where stories become reflection

ATUL RAMESHHWARA DAYAL
New Delhi



The Rising Sun is more than a collection of stories; it is a reflection of a life deeply observed, thoughtfully lived, and generously shared. In this inspiring anthology, Dr Krishna Saksena explores the complexities of human existence through narratives that touch upon faith, morality, duty, compassion, and self-discovery.

What makes the book particularly compelling is its simplicity. Dr Saksena writes with remarkable clarity, making profound ideas accessible to readers from all walks of life. Her stories do not preach; instead, they gently encourage reflection, inviting readers to pause and examine their own beliefs, choices, and relationships.

The author's rich life experience is evident throughout the book. Having dedicated herself to education, social service, and literary pursuits, Dr Saksena brings authenticity and wisdom to every page. Her insights into human nature are both empathetic and practical, offering guidance without judgment.

One of the book's greatest strengths is its ability to remain relevant in a rapidly changing world. The themes of kindness, resilience, spiritual growth, and ethical living resonate deeply, reminding readers of timeless values that often get lost amidst modern distractions.

At the age of 98, Dr Krishna Saksena continues to demonstrate that creativity, purpose, and intellectual curiosity have no age limit. The Rising Sun stands as a testament not only to her literary talent but also to her enduring spirit and commitment to uplifting others. This is a book that lingers in the mind long after the final page is turned. Thought-provoking, heartfelt, and deeply enriching, The Rising Sun is a rewarding read for anyone seeking wisdom, inspiration, and a renewed appreciation for life's deeper meanings.

Indian Army organises medical camp for ex-servicemen at Rupai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Rupai

The Indian Army's Red Shield Division under the Spear Corps organised a medical camp for ex-servicemen and their dependants at Rupai on June 20.

The initiative was aimed at extending healthcare support to the veteran community and reaffirming the Indian Army's commitment towards the welfare and well-being of ex-servicemen and their families.

The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from approximately 150 ex-servicemen, Veer Naris and their dependants. A dedicated medical team conducted comprehensive health check-ups, medical consultations, blood pressure and blood sugar screening, and dental inspections and provided specialist medical advice.

Psychological guidance and counselling sessions were also conducted to promote mental well-being and emotional resilience. Essential medicines were distributed free of cost, and beneficiaries were also educated on preventive healthcare measures and healthy lifestyle practices.

A SPARSH Grievance Cell was also established during the event to assist veterans with pension-related issues, documentation, digital registration and other pension-related matters.

Individual grievances were addressed through one-on-one interactions, ensuring timely guidance and effective resolution of concerns. Veer Naris attending the camp were also felicitated as a mark of respect and gratitude for their sacrifice and contribution to the nation.

The initiative provided a valuable platform for interaction between the Indian Army and the veteran fraternity, strengthening mutual trust and cooperation. The participants expressed their appreciation for the efforts undertaken in bringing essential healthcare and administrative services closer to the veteran community.

1,000 NCC Cadets mark International Yoga Day

TONY DAS Guwahati

NCC Group Headquarters Guwahati, NER Directorate, celebrated International Yoga Day 2026 with over 1,000 NCC cadets performing synchronised Yoga across Guwahati, Dubri and Kokrajhar, under the theme "Yoga for Healthy Ageing".

At the main event in Army Public School, Narangi Cantonment, Guwahati, NCC cadets from units across Kamrup Metro and Guwahati practised Yoga in unison following the Common Yoga Protocol. The session was conducted in collaboration with experienced instructors from North East Yoga and Meditation Centre, Guwahati. Brigadier NC Khuman, Group Commander NCC Group Headquarters Guwahati, while addressing the cadets, motivated them to adopt a disciplined life, emphasising that Yoga teaches balance, focus and resilience essential for nation building.

Cadets also took a pledge to make Yoga part of their daily routine and to act as "Mini Ambassadors" in their society to spread awareness on healthy and disciplined living. The event reinforced values of fitness, mental well-being, discipline, ownership and unity among youth.

From excellence in training to balance in Yoga, the celebrations reaffirmed NCC's commitment to shaping healthy, responsible and patriotic citizens.

KVIC celebrates 12th International Yoga Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

On the occasion of the 12th International Yoga Day, a mass yoga session was organised on Sunday by KVIC's Multi-Disciplinary Training Centre (MDTC) at the Gandhi Darshan Complex, New Delhi.

Chief Guest and Chairman KVIC Manoj Goyal participated in the yoga session alongside officials, staff members, and dignitaries associated with the Khadi sector, conveying the importance of a healthy lifestyle and regular yoga practice.

The theme for this year's International Yoga Day is 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing'. This theme highlights the vital role yoga plays in maintaining physical, mental and emotional well-being at every stage of life.

Following the yoga session, Goyal planted a sapling in the office premises under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign, an initiative inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and urged everyone to contribute actively towards environmental conservation and building a greener India.

Addressing the gathering, Goyal stated that under the leadership and efforts of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, both Yoga and Khadi have evolved into global mass movements. He remarked that yoga is not merely a physical exercise but an Indian way of life that fosters balance and positivity, while Khadi stands as a symbol of self-reliance, Swadeshi (indigenous spirit), and sustainable development. The Prime Minister's efforts to bring both Yoga and Khadi closer to the masses stand as a remarkable example of the renaissance of India's cultural heritage.

Goyal stated that the concept of 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing' conveys a message of maintaining better health, mental peace, and emotional balance at every stage of life, including old age. Regular practice of Yoga enables an individual to lead a more active, healthy, and self-confident life.

He further stated that the Khadi and Village Industries sector has achieved unprecedented progress as a result of the visionary thinking and visions of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The turnover of the Khadi and Village Industries sector has crossed ₹1.87 lakh crore in the 2025-26 financial year, while providing employment to over 2.04 crore people. He expressed assurance that the sector would achieve the turnover target of ₹2.51 lakh crore in the near future.

A large number of officers and staff members from the KVIC State Office (New Delhi), Khadi and Village Industries Bhavan, Resident Representative Office, Northern Zonal Office, and the Multi-Disciplinary Training Centre (New Delhi) participated in the Yoga session. Following the event, Manoj Goyal encouraged the participants by distributing refreshments.

This event not only aimed to raise awareness about health and well-being but also played a significant role in strengthening the national resolution to build a 'Healthy India — Empowered India'.

DAILY SUDOKU

							6	3
7					2	4		9
5		2	3	6			1	
				2		5		
	6	1				8	9	
		5		8				
	2			9	8	6		7
4		7	6					2
6	9							

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.

SOLUTION (20.6.26)

7	8	4	1	2	6	9	3	5
5	3	9	8	4	7	2	1	6
6	1	2	9	5	3	4	7	8
8	5	3	2	6	9	1	4	7
9	6	1	7	3	4	5	8	2
2	4	7	5	8	1	6	9	3
1	7	5	3	9	2	8	6	4
4	9	8	6	7	5	3	2	1
3	2	6	4	1	8	7	5	9

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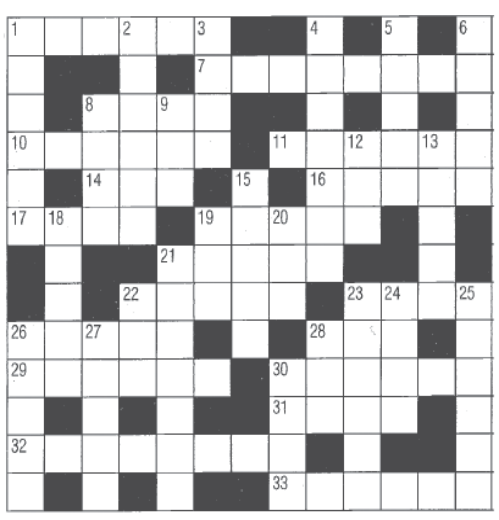
DOUBLE CROSSWORD
MONDAY | JUNE 22, 2026



ACROSS
1 Bootleggers' port? (6)
7 Superlatively youthful (8)
8 They keep quiet about the hard water at Maidenhead (4)
10 Drop it and the stand is broken! (6)
11 It may be waning a shade (6)
14 Slightly less illumination can be clever (3)
16 They can be matches for various teams (5)
17 Girl got up as a flower (4)
19 Bad day out! (5)
21 Continue with mounting success (3,2)
22 Try an out-of-the-way blend of tea (5)
23 Do they contain mild shocks? (4)
26 Exclude going back to bed to get a bit warm (5)
28 Terence's phone? (3)
29 Like an incompetent seaman? (6)
30 Has she half a life with a man? (6)
31 When keeping a team in line (4)
32 A much holed vessel (8)
33 It's just like that Lisa woman to be a grouser! (6)

DOWN
1 Dairy produce, say, at Wembley Central (6)
2 Journey half a mile in one jump! (6)
3 Viewed as having a hackneyed ending (4)
4 Getting warmed up, he may run all over the garden (7)
5 It's no credit when one is in debt (5)
6 Hunted animals, game to take part? (5)
8 Girl in a state? (4)
9 Retiring to copy the piano part out (3)
12 Any upset can be discouraging (3)
13 Certainly not raising some revenue! (5)
15 Blackish mole? (5)
18 Dated ways, as in former days (5)
19 His desire has no passion (3)
20 Glen or Sebastian (3)
21 Flowers for Judy (7)
22 The bill for drinks or some eatables (3)
23 For her, Emil almost finishes in a terrible jam! (6)
24 Seems to parody a girl, unfortunately (4)
25 Joint holder (6)
26 Bad scholar, but he may have been capped (5)
27 May be sportingly whipped off (5)
28 A diminutive and familiar statesman (3)
30 Work the land on a distant mountain top (4)

SOLUTION (20.6.26)

ACROSS
1, Stars
6, Lemu-r
9, Opt-I-mum
10, Savoy
11, C-inch
12,St-a-ir
13, S-event-h
15, Sad
17, Trod
18, N-Eva-Da
19, Blair
20, Fick-le
22, C-ops.
24, Fo-E
25, Shortly
26, 'T-aint
27, Pi-lot
28,Wigan
29, Nemesis
30, Fe-t-ed
31, Ne-W-ts

DOWN
2, Tracer
3, Roo-Ted
4, Spy
5, Fifth
6, Lucifer
7, Emir
8,Unclad
12, Stol-e
13, (Ma)Stiff
14, V-O-ice
15, Sabot
16, Da-is-y
18, Night
19, B-loat-ed
21, Iodine
22, Cruise
23, Pl-I-ant
25, SNe'er
26, Tone
28, Win

Assam Cricket Association launches APL

CM Himanta unveils official logo, league's trophy and participating teams

TONY DAS
Guwahati

The Assam Cricket Association (ACA) on Sunday marked a historic milestone in the State's sporting journey with the official launch of the Assam Premier League (APL) at the 91 Yards Club Auditorium, ACA Stadium, Barsapara, Guwahati.

Assam Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, the Chief Guest, formally unveiled the league's official logo, trophy, and the identities of the eight competing teams. He was joined by Guest of Honour BCCI Honorary Secretary Devajit Saikia, ACA President Taranga Gogoi, Secretary Sanatan Das, franchise owners, and members of Assam's cricketing fraternity. The ACA described the launch as the start of a structured, home-grown competition for cricketers in the State.

The programme began with a welcome address by Rajdeep Oja, Chairperson, Assam Premier League. He outlined the vision behind the league, stressing its role in creating a professional and sustainable platform for emerging cricketers and raising the standard of domestic cricket across Assam. According to the ACA, the launch of the APL is a significant milestone in its vision to give the state's domestic players a regular competitive platform at home and to broaden the talent pool feeding Assam's white-ball tournament and age-group sides.

The inaugural edition of the Assam Premier League will be broadcast live on Star Sports and streamed on JioHotstar, taking Assam's premier T20 competition to cricket fans nationwide.

A major highlight of the ceremony was the unveiling of the eight participating franchises: Jorhat Stallions, Tezpur Titans, Dibrugarh Warriors, Barak Legends, Nagaon Rangers, Barpeta Braves, Guwahati Royals and Charaideo Sunrisers.

Speaking at the event, Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma said, "Cricket occupies a special place in the hearts of the people of Assam, and the launch of the Assam Premier League represents a defining moment for the sport in our state. This initiative will provide a dedicated platform for talented young cricketers to showcase their abilities and pursue their aspirations at the highest level. This league belongs to the people of Assam, and I am confident it will grow into one of the impactful state leagues in the years to come."

BCCI Honorary Secretary Devajit Saikia said, "BCCI has always encouraged the growth of strong domestic cricket, and a professionally managed state league like the Assam Premier League adds significant depth to the cricketing structure. Assam possesses immense cricketing potential, and a platform of this nature will help talented players gain valuable competitive exposure. I congratulate the Assam Cricket Association on this important initiative and extend my best wishes for the successful inaugural season of the league."

He added, "I extend my gratitude to Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma for his vision and leadership, which have helped transform Assam into an emerging destination in India's sporting ecosystem."

The unveiling of the APL logo, trophy, and franchise identities marks the first major milestone ahead of the league's inaugural edition. Further announcements on the player auction, tournament schedule, and other details will be made in the coming weeks.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | MONDAY | JUNE 22, 2026

BRIEFLY

Rory McIlroy fades at the US Open with 5 late bogeys

When Rory McIlroy knocked in a 66-footer during a run of three straight birdies, he looked set for a big move at the US Open. The magic was quickly gone. And once his miserable back nine was over, McIlroy was, too. The Masters champion made five bogeys and shot 40 on the back, finishing with a 3-over 73 that severely damaged, if not entirely ended, his chances of winning. It was a stunning collapse after his birdies on Nos. 5-7 – the first time he made three in a row in a US Open since the first round of his victory in 2011 – sparked him to a front-side 33 that had him in the top 10 at one point. McIlroy quickly left Shinnecock Hills after his round, declining interview requests and making his way through a crowd of fans to his car. He felt he was still in the tournament even after making three straight bogeys in his second round Friday, believing he could make a move if he avoided those kinds of errors.

"Just try to limit the mistakes a little bit over the weekend, and feel like I'm playing well enough to pick off a few birdies here and there," he said. There were way too many mistakes and way too few birdies Saturday. McIlroy opened the tournament with a 69 but in the two rounds since has struggled badly to figure out Shinnecock's second nine, and the mess Saturday started from a perfect position. (*AP*)

Journey of Karting prodigy Arshi Gupta

At an age when most children are still discovering their favourite hobbies, nine-year-old Arshi Gupta has already carved her name into Indian motorsport history. The young racer from Faridabad added another significant milestone to her growing list of achievements on Thursday when she was conferred the prestigious FIA President's Medal in the National Karting Ranking (Women's Category) at the Federation of Motor Sports Clubs of India (FMSCI) Annual Prize Distribution Ceremony in Bengaluru. She was also honoured for winning the 2025 National Karting Championship in the Micro Max category, becoming the youngest-ever National Karting Champion in India. For Indian motorsport, the recognition carries special significance. The Fédération Internationale de l'Automobile (FIA) is the global governing body of motorsport, overseeing premier championships including Formula 1, Formula E, the World Rally Championship and several other international racing series.

Through its awards and recognition programmes, the FIA celebrates excellence and achievements across the global motorsport ecosystem, making an FIA-linked honour a notable recognition for any racer. Arshi's journey to the podium has been nothing short of extraordinary. In just her second year of competitive karting, she clinched the National Karting Championship title, a feat unmatched by any racer of her age in the country.

Her success is even more remarkable considering that karting is a mixed-gender sport, where boys and girls compete on the same track under identical conditions. Today, Arshi stands as the only female national-level karting champion in Asia.

Room makes 15 saves in 0-0 draw with Ecuador

DAVE SKRETTA
Kansas City

Curacao better make some room for a new national hero. Eloy Room delivered for his tiny Caribbean nation one of the finest performances in World Cup history on Saturday night, making 15 saves against a relentless Ecuador attack and helping The Blue Wave earn its first-ever point with a 0-0 draw against La Tri.

The outcome also allowed Germany, which beat Ivory Coast earlier in the day, to clinch Group E.

"It's going to be an insane memory," said Room, who plays for USL Championship club Miami FC. "You don't think about it when you do it but of course it's going to be something you look back to. For me as a goalkeeper, this is almost a perfect game." The 37-year-old Room, whose shutout of Jamaica last November sent Curacao to its first World Cup, bounced back in historic fashion from a 7-1 loss to Germany. His save total was one shy of the record — since saves became an official stat in 1966 — of 16 set by Tim Howard of the US against Belgium on July 1, 2014, in a game that Room remembers watching.

Howard needed 120 minutes for his total, though. Nobody has made more saves than Room without extra time. "I think I need a statue in Curacao now," he said with a smile. The draw doesn't eliminate either team from knockout play, but it put Ecuador in dire shape going into its group finale. Those matches take place Thursday with Curacao facing Ivory Coast in Philadelphia and Ecuador playing Germany in New York. "Well, there are things you cannot explain in football," Ecuador coach Sebastian Beccacece said. "We wanted to win. We didn't do it. I am the one who bears responsibility, and I told my team, If you're giving it all, competing, I have no complaints.'

"As long as we are alive, we will continue to give it our all. We are very united. We are like a family. No one said it would be easy."

Ecuador certainly had a home-field advantage Saturday night at the home of the Kansas City Chiefs. Its fanbase, dressed like its players in bright yellow shirts, filled the stadium to the brim, making it look like a convention of Minions. There was only a couple of small pockets of blue-clad Curacao fans in a stadium whose capacity could house half of its island citizenry.

Among those in the crowd were Kansas City Royals players Bobby Witt Jr., Salvador Perez and Starling Marte. And King Willem-Alexander and Queen Maxima of the Netherlands, who began a memorable day in Houston cheering the Dutch past Sweden, then flew to Kansas City to watch a constituent country within the Kingdom of the Netherlands make history.

"They were even dancing in the locker room to our music," Room said. "That's unreal that they witnessed this game." The pressure mounted on Ecuador earlier Saturday, when Deniz Undav's goal in stoppage time lifted Germany to a 2-1 win over Ivory Coast. The outcome of that match in Toronto meant that La Tri faced World Cup elimination with a loss to The Blue Wave. Curacao made sure the pressure continued once play began.

Throughout the first half, 78-year-old coach Dick Advocaat's team kept finding seams through the middle of Ecuador's defense, and that created open looks at the goal. But each time, Curacao would end the runs with a sloppy pass or a shot wide of net. Ecuador wasted its best scoring chance in the opening minutes, when World Cup veteran Enner Valencia found nothing between him and the goalkeeper. But Room guessed right, dived to his left and deflected the shot to keep the game scoreless.

"For us it's no shock," Curacao midfielder Tahith Chong said. "We've gotten used to Eloy doing these unbelievable saves."

The pressure of La Tri picked up in the second half — and each time, Room was standing in the way.

Moises Caicedo forced him into making a spectacular save early on, then Valencia did the same with a well-placed header that Room knocked wide. On the ensuing corner kick, Room made two more sensational saves before Curacao finally cleared it. Ecuador wound up taking 27 shots to just 10 for Curacao. (*AP*)

Netherlands routs Sweden to lead Group F

KRISTIE RIEKEN
Houston

Brian Brobbey and Cody Gakpo scored two goals apiece to power Netherlands to a 5-1 win over Sweden on Saturday in the World Cup to bounce back after a disappointing draw in its opener and move atop the Group F standings. Brobbey's goals came in the first half, helping the Netherlands get off to a great start and roll to the big win after playing Japan to a 2-2 draw Sunday.

The victory gives Netherlands a group-leading four points. Sweden has three points, with Japan and Tunisia scheduled to play later Saturday.

Gakpo, who also had an assist, extended the lead to 3-0 just after halftime, scoring in the 47th minute off a cross from Denzel Dumfries. He matched Brobbey when he scored on a right-footed shot from the left box in the 54th minute.

Sweden couldn't build on its strong performance in a 5-1 walloping of Tunisia in its first match. The loss to the Dutch was its biggest World Cup defeat since losing 7-1 to Brazil in 1950.

The Dutch gameplan to play out wide to open up Sweden and cross to Brobbey worked perfectly early. He put the Netherlands on top in the fifth minute when Gakpo crossed into the middle of the box and Brobbey one-timed it with his right foot before tumbling forward to the grass.

His second goal came when he took a cross from Dumfries while sliding and just got his right foot on the ball, scoring inside the far post in the 17th minute.

Anthony Elanga's left-footed goal cut the lead to 4-1 in the 59th minute and allowed Sweden to avoid the shutout. Sweden had plenty of chances to score before that, but Netherlands' goalkeeper Bart Verbruggen was brilliant in the first half with four saves.

Sweden appeared to have cut the lead to 2-1 on a header by Gustaf Lagerbielke in the 44th minute, but he was ruled offside. Lagerbielke is a baron from a noble family in Sweden. His father and grandfather are counts.

But he wasn't the only royalty in the stadium Saturday as the Netherlands had two very special guests cheering them on with King Willem-Alexander and Queen Maxima watching from a luxury suite.

The crowd of 68,777 was largely made up of fans of the Netherlands, many of whom made their Oranje Fanwalk 2 1/2 miles from Rice University to Houston Stadium on Saturday morning.

Crysencio Summerville, who assisted on Gakpo's second goal, tacked on a goal for Netherlands in the 89th minute and celebrated with NBA star Steph Curry's "night night" gesture. Sweden finishes group play Thursday night against Japan at Dallas Stadium, and Netherlands meets Tunisia that night in Kansas City. (*AP*)

Undav steers Germany win over Ivory Coast

LEXIE LINDERMAN
Toronto

Deniz Undav scored twice after being subbed on in the second half as Germany defeated Ivory Coast 2-1 on Saturday and clinched a spot in the knockout phase at the World Cup.

Four minutes into stoppage time, Undav received a pass from Felix Nmecha in front of the net and rifled it past Ivory Coast goalkeeper Yahia Fofana to give the Germans a comeback win.

Undav's first goal of the match came after Nadiem Amiri sent in a long ball — that striker Kai Havertz let pass him by — onto the boot of Undav, who slammed it into the back of the net at the 68th minute. Both Amiri and Undav had subbed on eight minutes earlier. Four-time champion Germany has come back from disappointing group stage exits in 2018 and 2022, while Ivory Coast is still searching for its first knockout stage appearance and could still qualify.

The last time Germany got past the group stage it won the tournament in 2014.

Ivory Coast captain Franck Kessie opened the scoring in the 30th minute after midfielder Yan Diomande sent in a cross to forward Amad Diallo. His shot was blocked by Germany's Nathaniel Brown, but the ball bounced back to Kessie, who slotted it in the wide-open left corner of the net.

Germany had two goals waved off in a frustrating first half. The first was in the 21st minute when Fofana batted the ball into his own net, but Germany midfielder Aleksander Pavlovic made illegal contact with Fofana on the play. The second came in the 38th minute on a foul, as Jamal Musiala was called for contact on the build-up to what would've been a Havertz goal.

After a court fight to get into Canada, Elye Wahi, the Ivory Coast striker under investigation for alleged betting-related offenses while playing in France for Nice, did not play. (*AP*)

Coach says Iran still being treated poorly by US at World Cup

GREG BEACHAM
Inglewood (US)

Iran coach Amir Ghalenoei says that although his team is still being treated unfairly by the host US at the World Cup through travel restrictions and visa refusals, he is optimistic FIFA will persuade the Americans to lessen some of those strictures next week.

"I am very glad that the Iranian nation is behind us," Ghalenoei said through an interpreter. "Our martyrs in Iran, we play for them. But I know that this kind of behaviour has hurt our people. Even if we spent billions of dollars, we would not be able to have justice for our people. It just shows we are an oppressed country. But nevertheless, I hope we achieve peace, and I hope this kind of behavior does not become institutionalised in the World Cup."

Iran returned to the Los Angeles area on Saturday for its second match against Belgium on Sunday, but Ghalenoei said he was forced to curtail his team's training ahead of this difficult meeting with the No. 10 team in FIFA's world rankings after his request to travel Friday was denied. "We needed to have 24 hours (in Los Angeles), but they gave us less than 16 hours, and that is why we had to leave our training halfway," Ghalenoei said. "These constraints have made it very difficult for us."

Ghalenoei also appealed to the World Cup's other teams and coaches to speak out against the treatment of the Iranian team. "I ask the other 47 coaches a question, and none of them have responded to me," he said.

"We are here for football, not politics, and we are saying that again. Our grievances are to the way they've behaved with us. I haven't heard anything from other coaches (at the World Cup), and I'm sure they're busy and preparing their own teams and we never expect them to have a reaction. (*AP*)

Ayase Ueda scores twice for Japan

ETHAN WILCOX
Monterrey (Mexico)

Japan moved one step closer to reaching the knockout stages of the World Cup for the fourth consecutive time after pummeling Tunisia 4-0 in Group F.

Japan's four goals were the most the Samurai Blue had ever scored in a World Cup game, as Japan comfortably dismantled a Tunisia side that became the first to ever fire its coach after the opening game.

Ayase Ueda scored twice, along with Daichi Kamada and Junya Ito to put Japan level with the Netherlands on four points. The Dutch are currently on top the group due to having scored one more goal than Japan across its two matches. The loss for Tunisia means it is eliminated from the tournament. Japan are guaranteed at least third in the group, which could be enough to advance to the knockout stages.

Tunisia appointed two-time Africa Cup of Nations winner Herve Renard to try and rescue the Eagles of Carthage after its humiliating 5-1 loss to Sweden, but the North African nation could not contain Japan's speedy attack nor create any clear chances of their own. Kamada opened the scoring in the fourth minute, the fastest in Japan's World Cup history.

The Crystal Palace midfielder was perfectly positioned for Keito Nakamura's cross and barely had to move to tap in his second goal of the tournament. In the 31st minute, Ayase Ueda received the ball in the midfield and drove toward the Tunisia box.

When Ueda opted not to pass to a few advancing runners, any chance of a goal seemed lost — but the 27-year-old fired an angled shot from outside the box which flew into the left corner of the goal to make it 2-0. (*AP*)

Ivory Coast look to last game

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Toronto

If Ivory Coast wins its next match, Saturday's loss won't matter. After surrendering two second-half goals to Germany and missing the chance to clinch a knockout stage berth for the first time in its four World Cup appearances, Ivory Coast turn its attention to its last group stage match against Curacao on Thursday.

Win, and the Elephants are in. Forward Amad Diallo said he and his teammates will get over the Germany loss. They have to.

"We (have) respect for ourselves, but we want to make history for Cote d'Ivoire, and we (are) going to go there with a good mentality and try to live again," he said.

Ivory Coast seemed one step ahead of Germany throughout the first half Saturday and a chunk of the second, with midfielder Franck Kessie's first-half goal silencing German fans for a long stretch. But the German side of the sold-out crowd erupted when Deniz Undav scored the winning goal, his second of the match, leaving Ivory Coast fans hanging their heads.

The team seemed a little shocked as well, and players spoke about the pain of losing a match they felt they should have won. Still, the good news for Ivory Coast is that its next opponent, Curacao, is Number 83 in FIFA's international team rankings, well down the list from the 31st-ranked Ivory Coast.

Pink boots are everywhere at the World Cup

STEPHEN WHYNO
New York

Gio Reyna scored an iconic goal to kick off the World Cup for the US Vinicius Junior scored a dazzling one in Brazil's opener. Kylian Mbappe scored twice to become France's career goals leader. Harry Kane got two of his own to tie England's mark as he and his teammates try to bring the elusive trophy home.

What do they all have in common? Pink, of course.

Of all the colors of the rainbow at the World Cup taking place in the US, Canada and Mexico, pink is the star on soccer's biggest stage. Dozens of players are wearing pink boots that stand out against the green grass of the pitch after multiple shoe companies produced them ahead of this tournament with an eye on performance as well as visibility. "Athletes associate this colour with confidence and standing out, and that resonates," Nike Director of Global Footwear Odinga Nimako said.

Nimako pointed to Nike's silver, yellow and blue boots at the 1998 World Cup changing how people saw boots in the sport. Before that, black and white was the standard.

This time, Nike, Adidas, Puma, Skechers and New Balance all came out with pink boots. Mbappe and Vinicius have the Nike swoosh on his feet, as does Portugal's Cristiano Ronaldo and Norway's Erling Haaland. Reyna, England's Jude Bellingham and Declan Rice, Canada's Jonathan David, Spain's Lamine Yamal and France's Ousmane Dembele wear Adidas.

Whenever Neymar Jr. plays for Brazil, he's expected to be in Puma pink like American Weston McKennie. U.S. teammate Timothy Weah is among those in New Balance. Kane and Sweden's Anthony Elanga are sporting Skechers at the World Cup.

Skechers Director of Technical Performance Alex Bardini said the inspiration came from the company's headquarters in southern California. "The colorways reflect the breathtaking palette of an L.A. sunset: warm shades of pink and purple melting into white, with subtle tinges of orange," Bardini said. From Los Angeles and Vancouver to Guadalajara, Houston, Miami and Boston, long before the World Cup is decided, pink has become a clear winner. When Sweden put up five on Tunisia in Monterrey, Mexico, three came from players in pink boots: two by Yasin Ayari and another in the 84th minute by Mattias Svanberg.

Pink itself does not make players perform any better, but shoe company executives consider it a mindset. Bardini said comfort and performance are at the core of what Skechers does, and Nimako said Nike wants players to feel more aerodynamic.

"That feeling is holistic," Nimako said. "It's the engineering, yes, but it's also how the entire product comes together. When an athlete puts on a Mercurial and it looks fast, feels locked in, and weighs next to nothing, that perception reinforces performance. Everything works together." (*AP*)

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | MONDAY | JUNE 22, 2026

Virat Kohli named in India ODI squad for England tour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Star batter Virat Kohli was on Sunday named in India's squad for the three-match ODI series against England next month, subject to fitness clearance, as the BCCI announced a 15-man squad for the upcoming white-ball assignment.

Kohli, who is in Delhi for a promotional event, will report to the Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru on Monday for a fitness test.

He had suffered a hamstring injury during Royal Challengers Bengaluru's title-defending run in Indian Premier League. The injury had ruled him out of the recent three-match ODI series against Afghanistan. CoE sports science staff had visited Kohli in England some time back to check on his recovery.

The Shubman Gill led ODI team didn't have any surprises except that young batter Yashasvi Jaiswal has been dropped after being a part of short Afghanistan series.

Jaiswal, who a century in the third ODI in the series, wasn't picked as he was replacement for Kohli in the Afghanistan series.

The common practice followed by selection committee is that replacement player will have to make his way once the first choice cricketer out with injury makes a comeback. "Against England, there won't be much experiment with top order. Virat comes back at No.3 and Gill will open with Rohit Sharma. For back up opener's slot, selectors have Ishan Kishan who can be used as a floater," a BCCI source privy to selection matters told PTI.

Pacer Jasprit Bumrah has also been called back to the squad after being rested for workload management. Also making a comeback is veteran all rounder Axar Patel, who replaced rookie left arm spinner Harsh Dubey.

Dubey will link up with the India A red ball squad for the multi-day series against Sri Lanka A. "The Indian team management will give chances to both Dubey and Axar periodically to check who will be more suitable going into the World Cup. As of now only Ravindra Jadeja is being looked at as a Test specialist," the source added. India will play the three ODIs against England at Edgbaston (July 14), Sophia Gardens (July 16) and Lord's (July 19).

Chakravarthy out of Ireland T20Is: Meanwhile spinner Varun Chakravarthy has been dropped from the T20I squad for the Ireland series as he is yet to recover from his foot injury. The board said Chakravarthy is in the final stages of rehabilitation at the BCCI Centre of Excellence following a left foot injury sustained during IPL 2026.

Shreyas Iyer will captain the T20I side in Ireland, with Tilak Varma serving as vice-captain.

ODI squad for England: Shubman Gill (Captain), Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli*, Shreyas Iyer (Vice-Captain), KL Rahul (WK), Ishan Kishan (WK), Washington Sundar, Axar Patel, Nitish Kumar Reddy, Kuldeep Yadav, Jasprit Bumrah, Prasidh Krishna, Harshit Rana, Arshdeep Singh, Gurnoor Brar.

Updated squad for Ireland T20Is: Shreyas Iyer (Captain), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson (WK), Ishan Kishan (WK), Shivam Dube, Tilak Varma (Vice-Captain), Nitish Kumar Reddy, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Ravi Bishnoi, Harshit Rana, Arshdeep Singh, Prince Yadav, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Prasidh Krishna.

India beat NZ to win FIH women's Nations Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Auckland

Continuing their impressive run of form, India defeated hosts New Zealand 2-0 in the final to win their second FIH Women's Nations Cup title and secured promotion to the FIH Women's Pro League here on Sunday.

Navneet Kaur (4') gave India the early lead before Sunelita Toppo (15') doubled India's advantage. The team produced a stellar defensive display to protect their lead and win the title, which also marked their return to the Pro League next season.

Lalremsiami won the 'Player of the Match' award in the final, while Deepika finished as the joint-top scorer in the tournament with six goals to her name sharing the honours with USA's Ashley Sessa. This is India's second Nations Cup title, having won the inaugural edition of the tournament in 2022. India remained unbeaten throughout their campaign, defeating USA (3-2), Japan (2-1), and Uruguay (3-2) in the Pool A matches, before registering a commanding 6-0 win over Chile in the semi-final. To recognise the teams' achievements, Hockey India announced a cash award of ₹3 lakh for each player and ₹1.5 lakh for each member of the support staff.

In the title match, the hosts enjoyed the majority of possession in the early exchanges as they looked to make early inroads. However, the visitors manufactured the first meaningful opportunity of the game when Kaur won a penalty corner. She converted from the set-piece with a thunderous hit in the 4th minute, putting India in front.

India were exceptional in transition, causing all sorts of problems for New Zealand's defence with their intensity.

They doubled their advantage through their fifth penalty corner of the opening quarter, with Sunelita deflecting a sharp attempt from Deepika, handing India a 2-0 lead in the 15th minute.

India were disciplined in the second quarter, while New Zealand began to grow into the game as they looked to claw back. The visitors too had a couple of opportunities to extend their lead.

However, neither side could find the back of the net, resulting in India holding onto their two-goal advantage at half-time.

India remained resolute in the third quarter, putting up a remarkable defensive display that kept the hosts at bay and denied them any clear goal-scoring opportunity. With their high intensity, the visitors forced a mistake from the New Zealand defence, but Navneet's reverse hit was saved by the goalkeeper.

New Zealand earned a penalty corner in the opening exchanges of the fourth quarter. The resulting set-piece, however, was saved by Savita. The visitors remained superb in maintaining a tight defensive structure and eventually secured a 2-0 win to clinch the title.

Sooryavanshi's 94 shines bright in India A's win over SL A in tri-series final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dambulla

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi showcased his astonishing talent and big-match temperament with a 29-ball 94, laying the foundation for India A's lopsided 66-run over Sri Lanka A in the tri-series final here on Sunday. Sooryavanshi's romp, which also contained an 11-ball 50, the fastest in List A cricket, guided India A to a massive 377 for nine.

Sri Lanka A mustered 311 all out in reply as pacer Yash Thakur (3/45) and spinner Vipraj Nigam (3/60) inflicted timely blows.

If the hosts had to get closer to that improbable target, they needed a good start and consistent partnerships. They did not have either of them. Their top three — Niroshan Dickwella, Avishka Fernando and Nuwanidu Fernando — returned to the hut with just 75 on board inside the first 10 overs. Two of the most productive partnerships in their innings was a 53 between Sadeera Samarawickrama (52) and skipper Sahan Arachchige (38) for the fourth wicket, and then a 77 between Wanuj Sahan (62) and Vijayakanth Viyaskanth (39) for the seventh wicket.

Those numbers were vastly insufficient in a chase that demanded a scoring rate in excess of eight constantly, and were good enough only to delay the inevitable and help SL to cross the 300-run mark. Earlier, Sooryavanshi's blitz too had an air of inevitability to it, as he shrugged off a lean run in this tournament with typical gusto. Asked to bat, India A looked set for a score in excess of 400 riding on Sooryavanshi's extraordinary blitz before SL clawed their way back. Skipper Tilak Varma steadied the innings with a composed 67 off 90 balls, while Anukul Roy (39 off 15) and Vipraj Nigam (27 off 20) produced a late burst to lift India beyond 350. The day, however, belonged to Sooryavanshi. The 15-year-old from Bihar's Samastipur needed just 11 deliveries to reach his half-century, eclipsing the 21-year-old record held by Lankan Kaushalya Weeraratne, who had taken 12 balls to get to the milestone in 2005. Having endured a quiet time so far the series, Sooryavanshi walked out with clear intent and unleashed absolute carnage. His first 11 deliveries yielded 50 runs, reading 4, 4, 4, 6, 6, 0, 6, 4, 4, 6, 6, as he dismantled the Sri Lankan attack from the outset.

He reached the landmark with five sixes and as many boundaries, bringing up the record with successive sixes straight down the ground off pacer Dulaj Samuditha.

The left-hander combined brute force with exceptional timing. He initially targeted the leg side against the seamers before effortlessly opening up the off side once Sri Lanka A stationed an additional fielder on the on side. Sooryavanshi's ability to dispatch even good deliveries over the ropes once again stood out. The highlight of the innings was his lofted shots over extra cover.

Three effortless sixes in that region showcased the bat speed, balance and fearlessness that have made him one of India's most exciting young talents. Alongside Priyansh Arya (39), Sooryavanshi added 132 runs for the opening wicket and looked well on course to register the fastest century in List A cricket. However, spinner Arachchige ended the fireworks by having him caught at mid-off in the ninth over. Arya followed an over later as Sri Lanka clawed their way back into the contest. Ruturaj Gaikwad (40) and Tilak then added 63 runs for the third wicket, but the flow of boundaries dried up considerably. As India attempted to accelerate in the closing stages, wickets fell at regular intervals, but Nigam and Anukul provided the final flourish.

New Zealand crush England by 253 runs in 2nd Test

FOSTER NIUMATA
London

New Zealand won The Oval test by 253 runs after routing England for 209 just 48 minutes into the fifth and final day Sunday.

The crushing win followed England's own big win at Lord's and sends the series to a decider in Nottingham starting on Thursday.

England resumed on 182-5 with an improbable target of 463 and fast bowler Matt Henry took the last five wickets. The metronomic Henry gave a masterclass with a spell of 5-3 in 5.1 overs. They earned him 6-29 in the innings and, after his 5-80 in the first innings, 11-109 in the match, the best-ever match figures by a New Zealand bowler against England. Henry also achieved his first 10-wicket match haul in his 35th test.

Joe Root, Jofra Archer, Matthew Fisher and Josh Tongue were dismissed in two double-wicket maidens by Henry. He was on a hat trick but Jordan Cox defended it. Root added only two runs to his overnight 75 and was beaten by Henry between bat and pad and struck plumb on the back thigh. He reviewed in vain and trudged off with 77 from 145 balls, taking with him England's last hope.

Henry was the first bowler to take out Root and Harry Brook twice in a single test. Archer's wickets were smashed by an unplayable shooter under his bat. Archer threw back his head and smiled after his two-ball duck. Fisher chopped on to his leg stump on 0 and Tongue edged to first slip on 0, too. Henry stood still and yelled at his 5-for and 10-for milestones before he was mobbed again by teammates.

Cox, on 0 overnight, had a cameo 25 before he was bowled trying to sweep, bringing the match to its inevitable end. Sonny Baker didn't score. New Zealand earned only its seventh win in England in 95 years of touring, and only its second at The Oval. The other was in 1999. (*AP*)

INDIA BOXERS PUNCH THEIR WAY TO 12-MEDAL HAUL IN CZECHIA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

India's Commonwealth Games-bound boxers finished with a rich haul of 12 medals, including eight golds, capping off a commanding display at the invitational 56th Grand Prix Usti nad Labem in Czechia.

The five-member women's team led the charge by winning four gold medals and one silver. Olympic medallist Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), reigning Asian champion Preeti Pawar (54kg), Sakshi Chaudhary (51kg) and Priya Ghanghas (60kg) all struck gold by registering unanimous victories in their respective finals.

Parveen Hooda (65kg) added a silver medal to complete an impressive showing by the women's squad.

Australia beats Bangladesh by 7 wickets to sweep series

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Chattogram

Captain Mitchell Marsh struck a 28-ball 60 as Australia thrashed Bangladesh by seven wickets in the third T20 to complete a 3-0 series sweep on Sunday.

Chasing a 110-run target, Australia raced to victory in 11 overs, with Marsh hitting seven fours and four sixes in his marauding knock to lead the charge. Australia won the first match by four wickets and the second one by 7 runs. Marsh and Josh Inglis added 54 runs in the first powerplay to lay the platform before left-arm spinner Nasum Ahmed dismissed Inglis for 17.

Marsh slog-swept leg-spinner Rishad Hossain for a six to raise his 14th fifty off 23 balls and appeared set to finish the match. However, pacer Shoriful Islam, one of the three changes made by Bangladesh in an effort to avoid a sweep, had Marsh caught by Shamim Hossain with Australia 22 runs away from the victory.

Tim David confirmed Australia's victory with two consecutive sixes off Rishad as Australia reached 112-3 to secure a clean sweep of the series. David was unbeaten on 12 with Matt Renshaw, who struck 89 not out in the previous game, on 6.

Captain Towhid Hridoy fought a lonely battle for Bangladesh, taking his side to 109-8 after choosing to bat first. Hridoy hit an unbeaten 61 off 51 balls, with three fours and as many sixes. Rishad Hossain was the only other batter to reach double digits with 16.

Fast bowlers Spencer

Kapp powers South Africa to six-wicket win over India in Women's T20 World Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Manchester

Marizanne Kapp made the most of a couple of dropped catches to hit an unbeaten 81 and power South Africa's crucial six-wicket win over India in their Group A contest of the Women's T20 World Cup here on Sunday.

Kapp, who had earlier returned 2/27 with the ball, struck seven fours and four sixes to make her runs off just 45 balls. She was dropped twice by substitute fielder Radha Yadav, which proved catastrophic for India.

In reply to India's laborious 158 for seven earlier in the innings, South Africa won with five balls to spare, making 161 for four in 19.1 overs.

Kapp put on 97 runs for the third wicket with Tazmin Brits (40 off 36 balls), which laid the foundation for an impressive win for the Proteas, which also took them to the third position in the points table behind second-placed India and table-toppers Australia.

Harmanpreet opened with Shafali Verma and kept changing the bowling frequently and the Indian challenge was met by some stoic response from the South African openers, who did not take early initiative of attacking.

It resulted in the Proteas reaching 25 for no loss after the fifth over, and a double-wicket maiden from Shree Charani (3/24) wrecked their start by the end of the powerplay. Charani first timed her jump to perfection to grab a sharp catch over her head to remove the dangerous Laura Wolvaardt (20), and then cleaned up Annerie Dercksen (0) two balls later.

But South Africa fought their way back to controlling the game with the superb stand between Kapp and Brits, consuming only 63 balls to do so.

The pair ran extremely well between wickets and kept finding the odd boundary every over to keep their team in the hunt. But a slow start meant they had to be a tad more aggressive than they were.

The partnership between Brits and Kapp would not have swelled to the extent that it did if Radha Yadav had not spilled a regulation catch coming in from long-on, giving the latter a lifeline.

The association ended when Brits connected well but found Charani at deep backward square in the 17th over off Shafali, who would have got her second wicket in the same over had Radha not dropped another regulation chance.

Coming in from long-on, the hit from Kapp popped out of Radha's hands as India once again missed a crucial opportunity to get rid of the veteran South African.

Earlier, Deepti Sharma made a vital 29 while skipper Harmanpreet Kaur struck 24 as India, struggling on a two-paced wicket, cross 150.

India collapsed from 54 for no loss to 83 for four before the two senior players put on 33 runs for the fifth wicket to stabilise the innings which was also marred by some ordinary shot selection.

Deepti struck three fours in her 21-ball 29 before failing to execute a sweep.

On her part, Harmanpreet (24 off 22 balls), who became the first cricketer across both men and women to feature in 200 T20Is, played one on at a crucial junction for India.

WEST INDIES ADVANCE: In Bristol, the West Indies set up a showdown of unbeaten sides with England after laboring past Sri Lanka by five wickets on Sunday.

Sri Lanka was bowled out for 98 and the West Indies overhauled it in the 17th over on a spilled catch at midwicket.

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